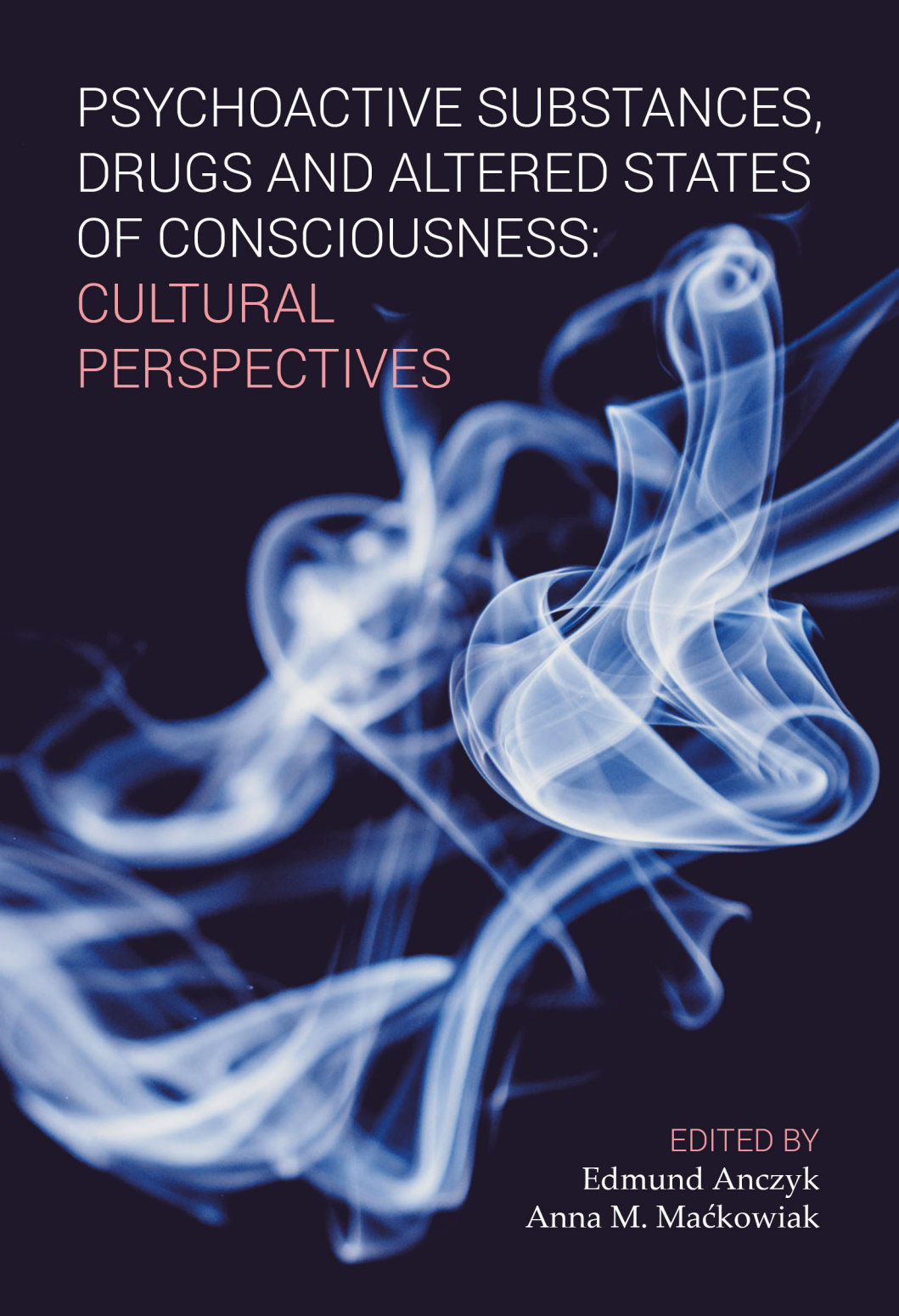


The background of the cover features abstract, ethereal patterns of blue smoke or vapor. These patterns are composed of thin, flowing lines that swirl and rise, creating a sense of movement and transformation. The colors range from a deep navy blue to a bright, almost white light blue, giving the impression of smoke catching light. The overall effect is dreamlike and contemplative, fitting the book's theme of altered states of consciousness.

PSYCHOACTIVE SUBSTANCES, DRUGS AND ALTERED STATES OF CONSCIOUSNESS: CULTURAL PERSPECTIVES

EDITED BY
Edmund Anczyk
Anna M. Maćkowiak

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CURRENT STATUS OF RESEARCH ON THE EFFECTS OF HALLUCINOGEN USE – A BRIEF REVIEW AND METHODOLOGICAL REMARKS

INTRODUCTION

Commonly, the term ‘hallucinogen’ refers to substances which, when consumed, may cause hallucinations, and which generally are regarded as mind-altering. A wide range of substances, both of natural and synthetic origin, is usually included within the cluster of hallucinogens, from marijuana to LSD, dimethyltryptamine, and even ecstasy (MDMA). Moreover, the idea that hallucinogenic substances are allegedly ‘narcotics’ has become widespread within the public opinion, which can to certain extent explain why the issue of hallucinogens has not yet been a subject of proper discussion and been relegated to the area of drug abuse and addiction.

The research on effects of hallucinogen use in clinical and non-clinical context reached its peak during the 1950s and 1960s. Shortly after the research had started in the United States, the idea of hallucinogens as wonder-drugs spread into public opinion, leading to a rise of recreational use, known as the psychedelic culture. Unfortunately, due to hasty enthusiasm regarding the impeccably positive effects of these agents, hallucinogens from being a panacea have quickly become banned substances considered psycho-physically harmful and lacking any therapeutic or medical benefits. It eventually has led to proscribing these substances by national laws and international conventions, namely by the United Nations’ *Convention on Psychotropic Substances* concluded at Vienna in 1971.¹

¹ J. Spillane, W. B. McAllister, *Keeping the lid on: A century of drug regulation and control*, ‘Drug and Alcohol Dependence’, 2003, 70:3 (Supp), pp. 5–12.

The purpose of this paper is to review current research findings on effects of hallucinogen use. Namely, I will address matters, such as legal status of hallucinogens, basic information about psychopharmacology of these agents and their toxicity. Furthermore, I will present a brief report on recent results about therapeutic uses of hallucinogens and conclude with some remarks on safety concerns of hallucinogen use and their implications for designing future studies.

LEGAL STATUS

According to Polish regulations, hallucinogens predominantly belong to the class of psychotropic substances which are thought to have high addictive properties even when used for medical purposes. Due to this fact, they are placed under the 'I-P' label, meaning that these substances can be used only for conducting research and neither can be employed in medical nor industrial purposes.² The only exceptions to this classification are made for two ingredients of ayahuasca brew (*Banisteriopsis caapi* and *Psychotria viridis*) and ibogaine (*Tabernanthe iboga*), which are placed under the I-N, standing for intoxicants that can be used solely for medical, industrial and scientific purposes.³ Polish category of the I-P substances corresponds with Schedule I category of controlled substances of United Nations drug control conventions. The Schedule I includes substances that are to be prohibited from 'all use except for scientific and very limited medical purposes [...]'.⁴ Although this regulation does not explicitly state the criteria of including a substance under Schedule I, as the convention merely consists of the list of substances, it is sometimes assumed that substance belonging to Schedule I has a high potential for abuse, may provide a serious risk for public health, lacks accepted safety

² Cf. Ustawa o przeciwdziałaniu narkomanii z dnia 29 lipca 2005 r. (Dz. U. 2012 poz. 124), art. 33, p. 22, <http://isap.sejm.gov.pl/DetailsServlet?id=WDU20120000124> [19.11.2014].

³ Op. cit., pp. 46–60.

⁴ United Nations, *Convention on psychotropic substances (with lists of substances)*. Concluded at Vienna on 21 February 1971, 'Treaty Series', 1984, 1019, t. 14956, pp. 182–3, <http://treaties.un.org/doc/Publication/UNTS/Volume%201019/v1019.pdf> [22.11.2014].

for use, and has no currently accepted medical use.⁵ Because of widely-accepted legislation concerning hallucinogens, the research on hallucinogens is limited. The United Nations' convention of 1971 imposed serious restrictions on testing hallucinogens on human subjects inside and outside clinical practice.

WHAT IS A HALLUCINOGEN?

Although in common and legal parlance a wide scope of substances is labelled as 'hallucinogens', in scientific literature the term is reserved for both natural and synthetic compounds of similar psychopharmacology. Specifically, there is a consensus among researchers to regard the agonist action at serotonin receptors (mainly 5-HT_{2A}) in central nervous system as a main mechanism responsible for hallucinogenic, psychedelic, mind-altering effects.⁶ Substances that share this psychopharmacological characteristic are also frequently called 'classical hallucinogens' in order to differentiate them from other substances that can also produce 'hallucinogenic' effects though having their distinct mechanism of action.⁷

Moreover, classical hallucinogens are usually divided into three groups: tryptamines, ergolines, and phenethylamines. Accordingly, tryptamines are: psilocybin present in various species of *Psilocybe* mushrooms and endogenous dimethyltryptamine (DMT) which naturally occurs in living organisms and even can be found in human tissues.⁸ LSD (derived from

⁵ This specification is largely based on description of Schedule I substances of American Controlled Substances ACT (CSA). Cf. *Comprehensive Drug Abuse Prevention and Control Act of 1970*. Pub. L. 91-513. 84 Stat. 1236, 27 October 1970, Sec. 202, p. 1247, <http://gpo.gov/fdsys/pkg/STATUTE-84/pdf/STATUTE-84-Pg1236.pdf> [22.11.2014].

⁶ D.E. Nichols, *Hallucinogens*, 'Pharmacology & Therapeutics', 2004, 101:2, p. 132.

⁷ For these reasons, despite being genuine hallucinogens, substances such as ibogaine or salvinorin A are not typically considered classical hallucinogens. On the other hand, MDMA (commonly called ecstasy) does not fit the exact hallucinogen profile in respect to psychopharmacology, though it is traditionally treated as hallucinogen.

⁸ J. Kärkkäinen et al., *Potentially hallucinogenic 5-hydroxytryptamine receptor ligands bufotenine and dimethyltryptamine in blood and tissues*, 'Scandinavian Journal of Clinical & Laboratory Investigation', 2005, 65:3, pp. 194ff.

lysergic acid present in rye fungus) and mescaline (principle active compound of peyote cactus) are also treated as classical hallucinogens, belonging to classes of ergolines and phenethylamines, respectively.

We should also note that the mere term ‘hallucinogen’ is somehow misleading in reference to subjective effects of these substances, since it inevitably suggests that these agents cause hallucinations, or at best emphasises the primacy of perceptual effects.⁹ In fact, genuine hallucinations are infrequent (as people rather report experiencing visions with their eyes closed), and perceptual changes occur simultaneously with a major impact on emotional and cognitive sphere.¹⁰

Due to the biased notion of hallucinogen, researchers tried to introduce other terms that would free these substances from undesirable connotations. The most famous term – ‘psychedelic’ – was invented by Humphrey Osmond in 1957, while he was investigating application of hallucinogens in therapy of alcohol addicts. Within the ‘psychotomimetic’ (psychosis mimicking) paradigm, hallucinogenic agents were considered as a way for inducing subjective effects resembling psychotic experience and Osmond noticed that these effects were not characteristic for hallucinogen-induced states. Searching for more adequate description of experiences that were ‘not escapes from but enlargements, burgeonings of reality’,¹¹ he coined the term ‘psychedelic’ which meant ‘mind-manifesting’. Other, less known names for hallucinogenic substances, are ‘entheogen’ (connecting with a divine within) that stresses the religious context of hallucinogen use by indigenous cultures and associates hallucinogens with spiritual experiences,¹² and ‘psycholytic’ (mind-loosening) which refers to employing hallucinogens within psychoanalytic therapies.¹³

⁹ E. Frecska, L.E. Luna, *The adverse effects of hallucinogens from intramural perspective*, ‘Neuropsychopharmacologia Hungarica’, 8:4, p. 191.

¹⁰ Cf. R. Strassman, *DMT: The Spirit Molecule*, Rochester, Vermont 2001, pp. 153ff.

¹¹ H. Osmond, *A review of clinical effects of psychotomimetic agents*, ‘Annals of the New York Academy of Sciences’, 1957, 66:3, p. 428.

¹² J. Ott, *Pharmactheon. Entheogenic drugs, their plant sources and history*, Kennewick, WA 1996, p. 15.

¹³ T. Passie, *A History of the use of psilocybin in psychotherapy*, [in:] R. Metzner, D. C. Darling (eds), *Teonanácatl: Sacred Mushrooms of Visions*, Rochester, Vermont 2005, pp. 113–138.

PHYSIOLOGY AND PHENOMENOLOGY OF HALLUCINOGENIC EXPERIENCES

Hallucinogen action can involve certain physiological symptoms, such as weakness, dizziness, nausea and vomiting, dilated pupils, slight elevation of pulse and blood pressure.¹⁴ Psychologically, psychomotor functions are impaired, perceptual distortions occur with changed perception of time and weakened selective function of attention.¹⁵ These physiologic and psychological reactions are generally considered harmless when subject is aware they result from drug action, and when hallucinogen use takes place within safe conditions.

The physiological action on human body, however, seems unremarkable in comparison with impressive and rich variety of subjective effects. People often report having profound experiences with visual contents varying from simple, geometric shapes to full-bodied visions of alternate worlds. The content of experience may be a re-lived memory of the past or it can have a form of a mystical-like experience. These experiences are often accompanied by a sense of insight and gaining a novel perspective of one's own life and the world. Because hallucinogen-induced altered state frequently carry contents of great emotional impact and personal importance, the mere experience is rather ambivalent, as feeling of love and understanding can alternate states of despair or anxiety.¹⁶

TOXICITY, ADVERSE EFFECTS, AND DEPENDENCE

On account of wide scale recreational use of hallucinogens in the 1960s, many myths concerning effects of hallucinogens have evolved. One of them concerns the alleged chromosomal damage resulting from the LSD

¹⁴ E. Frecska, L.E. Luna, op. cit., p. 193.

¹⁵ H. D. Abraham, A. M. Aldridge, P. Gogia, *The psychopharmacology of hallucinogens*, 'Neuropsychopharmacology', 1996, 14:4, pp. 288–289.

¹⁶ I am referring here to the latest research conducted at Johns Hopkins University School of Medicine in the United States, see: R. R. Griffiths et al., *Psilocybin occasioned mystical-type experiences: immediate and persisting dose-related effects*, 'Psychopharmacology', 2011, 218:4, pp. 655–657.

intake. The unfortunate hypothesis was soon entirely refuted,¹⁷ yet it has had an impact on preconceptions about hallucinogens nonetheless.

The so-called ‘therapeutic index’ (IT) is a traditional measure for toxicity of medications. The therapeutic index value marks safety of given substance, as it describes the difference between a lethal and effective dose – the higher index value, the safer the substance. Classical hallucinogens are generally considered physiologically safe agents, and relatively non-lethal compared with other substances. For instance, the therapeutic index for psilocybin amounts to 641¹⁸ and for other classical hallucinogens it is above 600; while values of therapeutic index of aspirin, nicotine, and alcohol are 199, 21 and 10, respectively.¹⁹

Investigating harmful effects related to different illicit drugs, hallucinogen use seems to cause the least harm. For example, alcohol appears to be 10 times more harmful than LSD, and 12 times more detrimental than psilocybin.²⁰ Besides, acute physiological reactions to hallucinogens are more often associated with polidrug use (with joined use of at least two psychoactive substances) rather than with the mere hallucinogen ingestion.²¹

¹⁷ For instance, see a report by I. Dishotsky et al., *LSD and genetic damage. Is LSD chromosome damaging, carcinogenic, mutagenic, or teratogenic?* ‘Science’, 1971, 172:3892, 431–440. Although there is no explicit evidence for risky influence of hallucinogens on human foetus, it is advised to abstain from hallucinogens, as from any other psychoactive substances, during pregnancy. Cf. P. Peters, C. Schaefer, *Recreational drugs*, [in:] C. Schaefer et al. (eds), *Drugs during pregnancy and lactation. Treatment options and risk assessments*, London 2007, pp. 530–533.

¹⁸ S. Wojtowicz, Magic mushrooms, [in:] R. Strassman, S. Wojtowicz, L.E. Luna, E. Frecska, *Inner Paths to Outer Space: Journeys to Alien Worlds through Psychedelics*, Rochester, Vermont 2008, p. 147.

¹⁹ E. Frecska, L. E. Luna, op. cit., p. 191. R. S. Gable, *Comparison of acute lethal toxicity of commonly abused psychoactive substances*, ‘Addiction’, 2004, 99:6, p. 689.

²⁰ D.J. Nutt, L.A. King, L.D. Phillips, *Drug harms in the UK: a multicriteria decision analysis*, ‘Lancet’, 2010, 376:9752, p. 1561.

²¹ J. van Amsterdam, A. Opperhuizen, W. van den Brink, *Harm potential of magic mushroom use: A review*, ‘Regulatory Toxicology and Pharmacology’, 2011, 59:3, pp. 424–426.

As far as the relation between hallucinogen use and outbursts of psychopathological effects is concerned, population studies²² in the United States found no significant association between hallucinogen use and occurrence of psychiatric disorders. However, there is certain possibility that some effects of hallucinogen intake can reoccur over time. This phenomenon is called Hallucinogen Persistent Perception Disorder (HPPD), colloquially referred to as ‘flashbacks’. The meta-analysis of studies on hallucinogens showed that HPPD is very rare and is more frequently reported with an abuse of LSD, though it scarcely occurs in controlled (e.g. therapeutic) use of LSD or with use of other hallucinogens.²³ HPPD is mostly transient and its phenomenology consists of perceptual illusions, not proper hallucinations.²⁴ On the other hand, subjects suffering from psychiatric condition or those being in a risk group (i.e. with a family history of psychiatric illness) should refrain from using hallucinogens, since the use of these substances may contribute to developing or exacerbating psychotic symptoms.²⁵

Hallucinogens, like many other psychoactive agents, are often said to be drugs of abuse and dependence.²⁶ Indeed, there is high reciprocal tolerance between LSD, psilocybin, and mescaline, which means that the effects of these agents are diminishing over repeated daily use. However, this tolerance is temporary, as it lasts approximately up to 3 days.²⁷ In addition, dimethyltryptamine (DMT) is exceptional in this regard, since even if taken frequently, it does not result in higher tolerance, and has

²² T.S. Krebs, P.-Ø. Johansen, *Psychedelics and mental health: A population study*, ‘PLOS’, 2013, 8:8, pp. 1–9.

²³ For controversies over HPPD as a category for psychiatric diagnosis and for details of quantitative analysis of studies see a review of J. H. Halpern, H. G. Pope Jr., *Hallucinogen persisting perception disorder: what do we know after 50 years?* ‘Drug and Alcohol Dependence’, 2003, 69:2, pp. 109–119.

²⁴ J.H. Halpern, H.G. Pope Jr., op. cit.

²⁵ J. van Amsterdam, A. Opperhuizen, op. cit, p. 426.

²⁶ Cf. *Ustawa o przeciwdziałaniu narkomanii*, p. 5.

²⁷ E. Frecska, L. E. Luna, op. cit., p. 194.

very limited cross-tolerance with other hallucinogens despite having similar pharmacology.²⁸ Furthermore, classical hallucinogens are, in fact, physiologically non-addictive. Abstinence from these agents causes no withdrawal syndrome and no addictive behaviour, such as compulsive drug seeking.²⁹ One of the reasons why hallucinogens are not likely to be substances of abuse and addiction is that their physiological effects are not often pleasurable (due to dizziness or even nausea), and related experiences can be gratifying and enjoyable as well as frightening.³⁰

THERAPEUTIC APPLICATIONS OF HALLUCINOGENS

After over 30 years of stagnation of research on potential of hallucinogens, a new wave of studies have now emerged in Europe and the United States. Most of ongoing projects are inspired by achievements of research conducted during the 1960s; however, in contrast to past experiments, which were often inconclusive and biased,³¹ contemporary studies adhere to appropriate methodological and ethical standards. Most of recent projects are supported by two non-profit organisations promoting research of hallucinogen: the Multidisciplinary Association on Psychedelic Studies (MAPS) and the Heffter Institute.³²

Research on hallucinogens copes with use of these substances in clinical and non-clinical context. Studies of clinical population are concerned

²⁸ R. Strassman, C. R. Qualls, L. M. Berg, *Differential Tolerance to Biological and Subjective Effects of Four Closely Spaced Doses of N,N-Dimethyltryptamine in Humans*, 'Biological Psychiatry', 1996, 39:9, pp. 791ff.

²⁹ C.P. O'Brien, *Drug addiction and drug abuse*, [in:] L. L. Brunton, J. S. Lazo, K. L. Parker (eds), *Goodman & Gilman's The Pharmacological Basis of Therapeutic 11th Edition*, New York 2006, pp. 623–624.

³⁰ R.S. Gable, *Risk assessment of ritual use of oral dimethyltryptamine (DMT) and harmala alkaloids*, 'Addiction', 2006, 102:1, p. 32.

³¹ It is worth noting, of course, that not all past studies were flawed. For instance, a report by Krebs and Johansen recapitulates experiments on use of LSD in therapy of alcoholism which actually met methodological requirements. Cf. T.S. Krebs, P.-Ø. Johansen, *Lysergic acid diethylamide (LSD) for alcoholism: meta-analysis of randomized controlled trials*, 'Journal of Psychopharmacology', 2012, 26:7, 994–1002.

³² For more information visit official internet websites of MAPS and the Heffter Institute: <http://maps.org>, <http://heffter.org>.

with finding potential benefits for palliative care, therapy of addictions, and specified mental disorders. Research on healthy subjects is centred around influence of hallucinogens upon personal well-being or it focuses on searching for methods of application hallucinogens within neuroscience.

For instance, studies conducted in Switzerland received positive results of LSD-assisted therapy in palliative care. LSD occasioned a decrease of anxiety associated with illness and positively influenced subjects' quality of life.³³ In 2006–2011, studies at Johns Hopkins University in the United States investigated the relation between classical hallucinogens (psilocybin) and spiritual experiences. The results indicate that when psilocybin is used in controlled and safe conditions, it may have positive psychological effects, such as giving a new meaning to one's life, providing insight and increasing life satisfaction.³⁴ The application of psilocybin in treatment of obsessive-compulsive disorder has already been a subject of preliminary study which has demonstrated safety and potential of psilocybin-assisted therapy.³⁵ Referring to positive results of studies on clinical and healthy subjects, the new studies concerning use of hallucinogen are designed in order to explore their possible efficacy in various therapeutic contexts.

CONCLUDING REMARKS – SET AND SETTING

The former and recent research findings unanimously imply that hallucinogens are substances that may either have a therapeutic potential of improving individual's well-being or have harmful effects if not taken with care. Since adverse clinical effects of hallucinogen intoxication, such as an acute anxiety or states of delusion, are very often associated with

³³ P. Gasser, K. Kirchner, T. Passie, *LSD-assisted psychotherapy for anxiety associated with a life-threatening disease: A qualitative study of acute and sustained subjective effects*, 'Journal of Psychopharmacology', 2015, 29:1, pp. 61–64.

³⁴ R. R. Griffiths et al., op. cit. pp. 658–661.

³⁵ F. Moreno et al., *Safety, tolerability, and efficacy of psilocybin in 9 patients with obsessive-compulsive disorder*, 'Journal of Clinical Psychiatry', 2006, 67:11, 1735–1740.

hazardous use of these substances in inappropriate conditions, it is essential to learn how to use hallucinogens safely and reasonably.

Already in the 1960s, researchers investigating hallucinogens found out that the effect of hallucinogen use differs not only person to person, but is also context-sensitive. This phenomenon was recognised as the influence of ‘set and setting’. Strictly speaking, the risk of adverse reactions can be minimised when a subject taking a hallucinogen is informed about possible effects and taking the substance is a result of a conscious decision. Moreover, the appropriate setting must be ensured, which means that the person taking hallucinogens should find themselves in a safe and pleasant environment, avoiding both complete stimulus deprivation and overstimulation. It is also strongly recommended to remain under someone’s supervision during the hallucinogen’s action just in case if comforting is needed.³⁶

Due to these precautionary measures, the priority of contemporary research is to guarantee safety of participants in the first place, and that may result in certain methodological complications. Namely, subjects should be carefully informed about possible reactions, both negative and positive; the suitable conditions for hallucinogen sessions should be arranged, and supervised personnel needs to be properly prepared. These requirements may present a challenge for double-blind models of studies, where the expectations of both, the researcher and participant, are controlled.

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³⁶ M. W. Johnson, W. A. Richards, R. R. Griffiths, *Human hallucinogen research: guidelines for safety*, ‘Journal of Psychopharmacology’, 2008, 22:6, pp. 608–616.

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BETEL: ITS PREVALENCE, CHARACTERISTICS, AND CULTURE, BASED ON EXAMPLES FROM INDONESIA, TAIWAN, AND INDIA

BETEL

Betel is the fourth, after nicotine, alcohol and caffeine, the most popular psychoactive substance in the world,³⁷ which is not particularly shocking when we consider the fact that the habit of chewing betel is observed among residents of India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Burma, Thailand, Cambodia, Vietnam, Laos, Taiwan, China, Malaysia, Indonesia, the Philippines, Papua New Guinea and the islands of the western Pacific, and others. Additionally, with migrants, betel reached the UK, South Africa, and Australia from Asia.

Despite the spread of betel quid chewing, this psychoactive substance has hardly been touched on by scholars who are outside the circle of dentists and cancer specialists. Therefore, the confusion starts with the labelling. Betel nut is a name of neither betel nor nut. Betel nut and areca nut refer to the fruit of areca palm (*Areca catechu*). The fruit is mixed with various ingredients to make up a betel quid. There are many different ways of preparing this formulation. The most widely used additions are: the leaf of *Piper betle*, commonly called the betel leaf and slaked lime (calcium hydroxide), which can be obtained from corals, shells, and lime stones.

³⁷ M. Marshall, *An Overview of Drugs in Oceania*, [in:] L. Lindstrom (ed.), *Drugs in Western Pacific Societies: Relations of Substance: ASAO Monograph No. 11*, Boston 1987, p. 13; C. Pankaj, *Areca Nut or Betel Nut Control is Mandatory if India Wants to Reduce the Burden of Cancer Especially Cancer of the Oral Cavity*, 'International Journal of Head and Neck Surgery', 2010, January–April 2010; 1:1, p. 28; World Health Organization International Agency for Research on Cancer, *IARC Monographs on the Evaluation of Carcinogenic Risks to Humans: Volume 85 Betel-quid and Areca-nut Chewing and Some Areca-nut-derived Nitrosamines*, Lyon 2004, p. 33.

Apart from that, a betel quid can contain for example: tobacco, sweeteners, spices (cardamom, cloves), or catechu (an extract of acacia tree).³⁸

Betel quid is an addictive³⁹ psycho-stimulant formulation. The products of *Areca catechu* palm fruit contain several alkaloids that affect the human body. Arecoline is the most important among them, and is present in the highest concentration.⁴⁰ Organic compounds found in betel affect the autonomic nervous system.

‘Both sympathetic and parasympathetic nervous systems appear effected, with modulation of both cholinergic and monoamine transmission. It has a stimulating effect upon the parasympathetic nervous system causing dilation of the pupil, a hyperthermic effect on skin temperature, as well as an increase in pulse rate and systolic blood pressure’.⁴¹

Betel is used to fight fatigue, improve concentration, relax, experience the feeling of satiety, freshen the breath.⁴² Chewing betel increases the risk of developing precancerous lesions in the oral cavity. This was confirmed by, among others, an international research conducted on a representative sample of 8922 inhabitants of Taiwan, China, Malaysia, Indonesia, Nepal, and Sri Lanka by the Asian Betel-Quid Consortium (ABC).⁴³ The carcinogenic effects of betel use were also described in a World Health Organization International Agency for Research on Cancer report.⁴⁴ The psychoactive substance in question affects the health of the teeth, gums,

³⁸ P. C. Gupta, S. Warnakulasuriya, *Global epidemiology of areca nut usage*, ‘Addiction Biology’, 2002, 7:1, pp. 78–79.

³⁹ A. R. Winstock et al., *A dependency syndrome related to areca nut use: some medical and psychological aspects among areca nut users in the Gujarat community in the UK*, ‘Addiction Biology’, 2000, 5:2, pp. 173–179.

⁴⁰ A. Winstock, *Areca nut-abuse liability, dependence and public health*, ‘Addiction Biology’, 2002, 7:1, p. 137.

⁴¹ Ibidem, p. 135.

⁴² R. Anand et al., *Betel nut chewing and its deleterious effects on oral cavity*, ‘Journal of Cancer Research and Therapeutics’, 2014, 10:3, p. 499; C. Pankaj, op. cit., p. 28.

⁴³ C.-H. Lee et al., *Population Burden of Betel Quid Abuse and Its Relation to Oral Premalignant Disorders in South, Southeast, and East Asia: An Asian Betel-Quid Consortium Study*, ‘American Journal of Public Health’, 2012, 102:3, pp. e17–e24.

⁴⁴ World Health Organization International Agency for Research on Cancer, op. cit.

and oral mucosa. Chewing areca nut stimulates the production of intensely red saliva and regular use stains the mouth permanently.⁴⁵ It was not confirmed unequivocally that betel weakens and abrades the teeth.⁴⁶ It has been shown, however, that the incidence of dental caries is lower in those residents of South-East Asia who chew *Areca catechu* palm fruit than in those who do not have this habit.⁴⁷



Photo 1. Areca nut.

In the following parts of the paper, I will discuss the topic of the betel-chewing culture in three contexts – in the cases of Indonesia, Taiwan and India. These descriptions will provide an introduction to the subject only.

⁴⁵ R. Anand et al., op. cit., p. 500.

⁴⁶ Ibidem, p. 499.

⁴⁷ Ibidem, p. 500.

It is impossible to avoid simplifications while characterising vast, highly diverse ethnically, linguistically, and culturally populations.

INDONESIA

The Indonesians combine the fruit of *Areca catechu* palm with betel leaves and slaked lime. This formulation is supplemented with tobacco. A handful of tobacco is inserted into the mouth and left there for a moment to clean the mouth.⁴⁸ I had an occasion to observe such a classic way of using betel during my field research in Bayan on the island of Lombok (Photo 1, Photo 2, Photo 3). This psychoactive substance is popular in the villages of Bayan; breastfeeding women who chewed betel (Photo 4) caught my attention.



Photo 2. Leaf of the *Piper betle*.

All components of the betel quid are readily available on the islands of Indonesia. The *Areca catechu* palm is thought to originally come from the

⁴⁸ J. J. Pindborg et al., *Global aspects of tobacco use and its implications for oral health*, [in:] P. C. Gupta, J. E. Hamner, P. R. Murti (eds), *Control of Tobacco-related Cancers and Other Diseases: Proceedings of an International Symposium, January 15–19, 1990, TIFR, Bombay*, Bombay, Delhi, Calcutta, Madras 1992, p. 21.

Malay Archipelago, which is supported by botanical⁴⁹ and linguistic⁵⁰ studies. In the past, for the people of today's Indonesia, betel was an important accessory of social interaction and religious rituals. It was offered to guests, used during courtship and weddings. An association between the nuts and pairing people can be seen in the language; in Malaysian and Indonesian, the fruit is called *pinang*, the verb *meminang* means 'proposing', 'wooing', and the noun *pinang* stands for 'engagement'.⁵¹

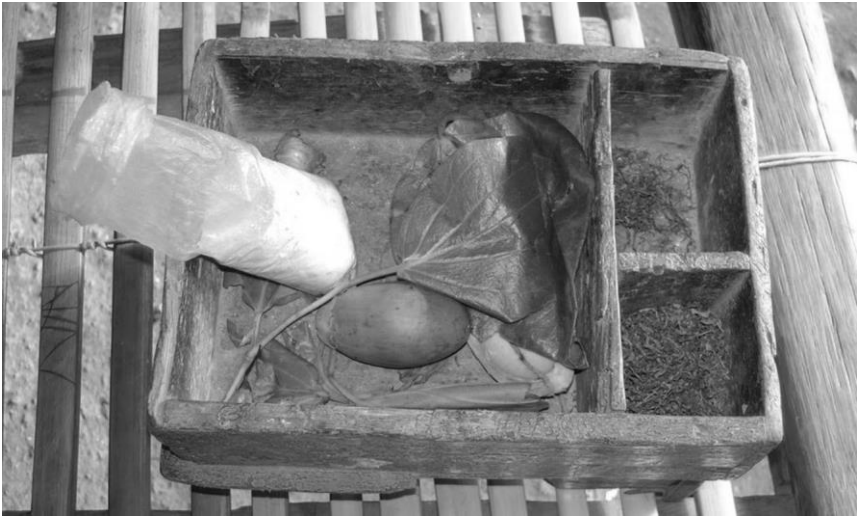


Photo 3. A betel box, Bayan.

The research conducted by the ABC shows that 12% of men and 46.8% of women in Indonesia have the habit of chewing betel (data from the years 2009–2010).⁵² Where does the disproportion between men and women come from? It is all because of cigarettes; according to Anthony Reid, 'cigarette smoking has almost completely replaced the chewing of betel

⁴⁹ C. D. Heatubun et al., *A monograph of the betel nut palms (Areca: Arecaceae) of East Malesia*, 'Botanical Journal of the Linnean Society', 2012, 168:2, p. 164.

⁵⁰ A. Reid, *From Betel-Chewing to Tobacco-Smoking in Indonesia*, 'The Journal of Asian Studies', 1985, 44:3, p. 529.

⁵¹ Ibidem, p. 531.

⁵² Lee et al., op. cit., p. e20.

among male Indonesians during the past century'.⁵³ Cigarettes were suitable to substitute betel, because these two drugs perform a similar function – they put the user in the right mood for social interaction.⁵⁴ This transition happened very quickly and clearly in south Sulawesi, where 'virtually everybody chewed betel in 1900, and virtually nobody did so in 1950'.⁵⁵

Cigarettes were and still are seen in Indonesia as a typically masculine stimulant, though the situation is changing and the tobacco industry is slowly starting to notice women. In 2004, 4.5% of females and more than 63% of males smoked cigarettes.⁵⁶ Due to the prevailing, particularly in rural areas, belief that smoking does not suit women, they chew pieces of areca nuts with betel leaves and a pinch of lime, and then they clean the mouth with tobacco.

TAIWAN

In Taiwan, betel chewing is much more popular among men – 10.7% of them do it regularly, while only 2.5% of women use this substance (data from the years 2009–2010).⁵⁷ The Taiwanese betel culture varies according to the ethnic background in question. According to a study conducted in Kaohsiung, the natives wrapped fresh *Areca catechu* fruit in *Piper betle* leaves, while the Chinese chewed cut in half fruit with a paste containing lime smeared inside.⁵⁸

⁵³ A. Reid, op. cit., p. 529.

⁵⁴ Ibidem, p. 532.

⁵⁵ Ibidem, p. 538.

⁵⁶ S. Baber et al., *Tobacco Economics in Indonesia*, Paris 2008, p. 62.

⁵⁷ C.-H. Lee et al., op. cit., p. e20.

⁵⁸ Y.-C. Ko, T.-A. Chiang, S.-J. Chang, S.-F. Hsieh, *Prevalence of betel quid chewing habit in Taiwan and related sociodemographic factors*, 'Journal of Oral Pathology & Medicine', 1992, 21:6, pp. 261–264.



Photo 4. Women chewing betel quid, Bayan.

Christian A. Anderson's doctoral dissertation concerns betel nut chewing culture in Taiwan and Hainan.⁵⁹ The researcher compared the traditional and contemporary customs associated with this stimulant. In Taiwan, in the case of the former, betel is an object of ritual exchange during courtship and weddings, it is also used in traditional medicine. The contemporary betel use culture began to grow in the 1970s and 1980s, due to socio-economic changes, globalization, industrialization, and urbanization. In the places where betel chewing is popular with men, drivers, workers, it is sold by 'betel nut beauties' (*binlang xishi*),

'The name "betel nut beauty" (*binlang xishi*) refers to a legendary historical figure named *Xi Shi*, renowned as one of the Four Beauties of Ancient China [...]. [...] Traditionally in Taiwan any beautiful women working in the market would be called by the name of whatever they were selling with the added title "*xishi*" such as "*tofu xishi*" Thus, when young women began selling betel nut in Taiwan, they were called "*xishi*".'⁶⁰

Scantly clad young women work in glass stands that can be found along the roads and highways or at night markets (Photo 5). These stands are conspicuous due to neon bright light. Betel, drinks, and cigarettes are sold inside and outside. Betel nut girls found their way into popular culture; they became main characters in films that were screened in cinemas in Europe, *Help me Eros* (*Bang bang wo ai shen* 2007) and *Betelnut Beauty* (*Ai ni ai wo* 2001). The phenomenon raises many controversies related to the exploitation and objectification of women, morality, dress in public places. Such a marketing strategy has proved successful. In the early 1990s, the betel industry become very profitable.⁶¹ Although

⁵⁹ C. A. Anderson, *Betel Nut Chewing Culture: The Social and Symbolic Life of an Indigenous Commodity in Taiwan and Hainan* [doctoral dissertation], University of Southern California 2007.

⁶⁰ Ibidem, p. 185.

⁶¹ Ibidem, p. 177.

the areca nut production is no longer growing, still its cultivation area is large, second only to rice fields.⁶²

INDIA

In India, there is a large variety of products based on the *Areca catechu* palm fruit. I will describe two of them – *gutkha* and *pan masala*. These industrially produced formulations have become in recent years a subject of discussion among the lawmakers and journalists.



Photo 5. Betel nut beauty shop, Taoyuan [from:] C. A. Anderson, *Betel Nut Chewing Culture: The Social and Symbolic Life of an Indigenous Commodity in Taiwan and Hainan* [doctoral dissertation], University of Southern California 2007, p. 184.

Gutkha consists of: areca nut, tobacco, calcium hydroxide, catechu, sweeteners, and flavour enhancers, while *pan masala* does not contain tobacco.⁶³ These products are packaged in small coloured boxes and advertised in the media. In 2003, the anti-tobacco law was tightened in India: selling

⁶² *Yearly Report of Taiwan's Agriculture 2013, Agricultural Production*, eng.coa.gov.tw/list.php?catid=2501664 [12.01.2015].

⁶³ P. C. Gupta, C. S. Ray, *Epidemiology of Betel Quid Usage*, 'Annals Academy of Medicine', 2004, 33:4, p. 33.

tobacco products to minors and near school buildings was banned, together with all forms of advertising the products.⁶⁴ Manufacturers bypassed the latter by selling both (tobacco containing) *guthka*, as well as (tobacco free) *pan masala* under the same brand names and in similar packaging.⁶⁵ The industry associated with *guthka* and *pan masala* was developing rapidly; the products had many buyers, including children and adolescents.⁶⁶ The popularity among children and adolescents as well as the negative impact on health of the users alerted the authorities. Using *guthka* and *pan masala* was linked to an increased risk of oral submucous fibrosis (OSF). This precancerous condition was first described in the 1950s. Still in the 1960s its incidence was very low and it was thought to be due to consuming hot peppers.⁶⁷ Today, in India it is said to be an epidemic.⁶⁸

At the beginning of the twentieth century, in some states of India laws banning production, sale, and possession of *guthka* began to appear. The first such law was introduced in 2001 in Tamil Nadu.⁶⁹ In Maharashtra, manufacturing, selling, and using of both *guthka* and *pan masala* is prohibited since 2012.⁷⁰ The legal situation is far from stable, bans are imposed by state legislation for a year and, if not renewed after that time,

⁶⁴ *The Cigarettes and Other Tobacco Products (Prohibition of Advertisement and Regulation of Trade and Commerce, Production, Supply and Distribution) Act*, 2003, No 34 of 2003, who.int/fctc/reporting/Annexthreeindia.pdf [12.01.2015], sections 5–6.

⁶⁵ P. C. Gupta, C. S. Ray, op. cit., p. 33.

⁶⁶ S. Kaur, S. Singh, *Cause for Concern in Punjab Villages: High Levels of Guthka Intake among Students*, 2002; G. Hans, *Prevention of Cancer in Youth in Particular Reference to Intake of Paan Masala and Guthka*, Mumbai 1998 [as cited in:] C. S. Ray, P. Gupta, J. de Beyer, *Research on Tobacco in India, Including Betel Quid and Areca Nut: An Annotated Bibliography on Use, Health Effects, and Control Efforts*, Washington 2003.

⁶⁷ P. C. Gupta, C. S. Ray, op. cit., p. 34.

⁶⁸ P. C. Gupta et al., *Oral submucous fibrosis in India: a new epidemic?*, 'The National Medical Journal of India', 1998, 11:3, pp. 113–116; P. C. Gupta, C. S. Ray, op. cit., pp. 33–34.

⁶⁹ Ibidem, p. 34.

⁷⁰ G. G. Dhumal, P. C. Gupta, *Assessment of Gutka Ban in Maharashtra: Findings from a Focus Group Discussion*, 'International Journal of Head and Neck Surgery', 2013, 4:3, p.115.

they expire.⁷¹ Furthermore, such bans are often broken, what has been described by researchers from Mumbai.⁷²

SUMMARY

The custom of chewing betel is widespread among the 600 million people who live in South Asia, the Indochinese Peninsula, Malay Archipelago, and islands of the western Pacific. The very name of this psychoactive substance raises misunderstandings. Betel and its impact on the appearance of precancerous lesions in the oral cavity has been the subject of medical research. The literature on preparation, distribution, symbolism, and diverse cultures of taking betel is scarce. These topics could become a basis for many interesting anthropological, literary, and historical research.

I described some elements of the betel use cultures specific to Indonesia, Taiwan, and India. In Indonesia, women use betel much more often than men do since the latter have replaced it with cigarette smoking, while in Taiwan the stimulant is more popular among the men. Therefore specific and controversial marketing strategies were developed. Betel nut girls, scantily clad, sell it in transparent, lit kiosks. In India, the mass-produced and advertised in the media products – *pan masala* without tobacco and *guthka* containing it – have gained popularity in the recent decades. At the beginning of the twenty-first century, bans of production, sale, and consumption of *guthka* began to appear in states of India, in Maharashtra concerning also *pan masala*.

⁷¹ Ibidem, p. 115.

⁷² S. Pimple et al., *Compliance to Gutka ban and other provisions of COTPA in Mumbai*, 'Indian Journal of Cancer', 2014, 51:1, pp. s60–s66.

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Pimple S., Gunjal S., Mishra G. A., Pednekar M.S., Majmudar P., Shastri S. S., Compliance to Gutka ban and other provisions of COTPA in Mumbai, 'Indian Journal of Cancer', 2014, 51:1, pp. s60–s66.

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Yearly Report of Taiwan's Agriculture 2013, Agricultural Production, <http://eng.coa.gov.tw/list.php?catid=2501664> [12.01.2015].

AYAHUASCA AS A SACRAMENT – SANTO DAIME AND SANTA MARIA IN THE NETHERLANDS

Ayahuasca is a hallucinogenic brew which has been used for thousands of years among the peoples of South America. From the scientific perspective, ayahuasca is a psychoactive substance prepared from two plants found among the South American flora. First one is *Psychotria viridis*, a perennial shrub containing *N,N*-Dimethyltryptamine (DMT), an endogenous hallucinogen. Except for ayahuasca, DMT is also an active compound of *changa*, known as ‘smokable ayahuasca’, and it is found in its chemically synthesised, crystallized form. DMT is inactive when administered orally because of monoamine oxidase enzyme present in the gastrointestinal tract; that is why DMT in its pure form is either smokable or administered intravenously (only in clinical experiments). DMT found in ayahuasca is active due to the other plant being a necessary compound of the brew – *Banisteriopsis caapi* – containing monoamine oxidase inhibitors (MAOI). The inhibitor blocks the MAO enzyme so that DMT can be absorbed into a blood stream. In fact ayahuasca takes its name from the latter plant. *Ayahuasca* in Quechua language means ‘a vine of the soul’. It is most commonly used in reference to the brew itself, however it can also refer to *Banisteriopsis caapi*, a vine which is one of the two traditional ingredients of the psychoactive drink. Ayahuasca is known by many names, the most popular of which are *yage*, *caapi*, *hoasca*, *daime* or *vegatal*.

Every research covering the topic of hallucinogens and their effects on the human body is controversial not only because of legal, ethical, and political reasons, but also because of lack of universally accepted scientific vocabulary. There are many names referring to substances commonly known as hallucinogens and every one of them has some important flaws. Even though the term ‘hallucinogen’ seems to be the most appropriate, it suggests that these substances cause hallucinations. In

fact, genuine hallucinations are not a common effect of hallucinogen intoxication. First of all, the term ‘hallucinations’ belongs to the area of psychiatry and it refers to abnormal phenomena associated with many types of mental disorders. However, it is worth noting that *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders DSM-5* includes a broad cultural perspective and states clearly that ‘[h]allucinations may be a normal part of religious experience in certain cultural contexts’.⁷³ Nevertheless, hallucinations are still defined as ‘perception-like experiences that occur without an external stimulus’.⁷⁴ It is crucial to note that ayahuasca only rarely causes hallucinations in the sense presented by the above definition. Ayahuasca induced visions occur mostly when the eyes are closed and it is common that the perception of the outside world remains unaltered, even if the way how the world appears changes drastically. A good example of such an experience is described by Benny Shannon,

‘I was sitting on a balcony overlooking a garden. As the brew was having its effect, I started to sing. What poured out of my mouth was a biblical text—the beginning of the book of Genesis. I chanted, in Hebrew, the creation of the world. And as I did so, the world was being created in front of my eyes: there was water, and then land surfaced, and trees came out of the earth and flowered, and then the world was populated with birds’.⁷⁵

Phenomenologically speaking, the above-described vision was not a hallucination *per se*, as it was not a perception without an external stimulus. The world was exactly the same as before but what changed was the way of perceiving it. Such experiences with ayahuasca use are very common.

It would seem that the term ‘psychedelic’ derived from the Greek *psyche* (*ψυχή* – ‘soul’) and *delos* (*δῆλος* – ‘to manifest’) would be more appropriate in the case of these substances and experiences facilitated by them.

⁷³ American Psychiatric Association, *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders DSM-5*, Washington, DC–London 2012, p. 88.

⁷⁴ Ibidem, p. 87.

⁷⁵ B. Shanon, *The Antipodes of the Mind: Charting the Phenomenology of the Ayahuasca Experience*, Oxford 2002, p. 7.

However, this term is strongly connected with counter-culture and the hippie movement of the 1960s and seems unsuitable when used in the context of religious consumption of these drugs. Among other names used when referring to hallucinogens, we can also find: 'psycholytic drugs' (loosening ego boundaries), 'misticomimetics' (invoking mystical experiences), 'psychotomimetics' (invoking psychotic-like experiences), 'lucidogens' (from the word 'lucid') or simply 'substances invoking altered states of consciousness'. None of these terms is universally accepted.

There is one more term especially worth mentioning in the context of religious use of hallucinogens. 'Entheogen' comes from Greek words *entheos* ('inspired', 'full of God') and *genestai* ('to become'). In English its meaning can be expressed as 'to become full of God' or 'to reveal God within'. It was coined in 1979 by scientists interested in religious use of psychedelic substances.⁷⁶ Even though not every experience facilitated by this class of substances could be characterised in religious terms, the term is still in use since both in the past and nowadays religious use of hallucinogens plays an important role in many religious traditions. Contrary to the common belief, hallucinogens are essential not only to endogenous shamanistic cultures of the past, but they are also starting to be used for spiritual purposes in modern urban societies.

MODERN USE OF AYAHUASCA

Ayahuasca is becoming more and more popular around the world. In the January 2015 *Newsweek* issue, there is an interview with C. Kilham, the author of *The Ayahuasca Test Pilots Handbook: The Essential Guide to Ayahuasca Journeying*.⁷⁷ Likewise, in the Polish edition of *Newsweek Polska* (July 2014), there is an article about modern, urban use of ayahuasca. Unfortunately it is rather of poor quality and does not meet the criteria of

⁷⁶ C. Ruck et al. (1979), *Entheogens*, 'Journal of Psychedelic Drugs', 1979, 11:1–2, pp. 145–6.

⁷⁷ D. Main, *Ayahuasca Can Help You Communicate with Plant Spirits, and Heal Your Body and Mind*, <http://newsweek.com/ayahuasca-can-help-you-communicate-plant-spirits-and-heal-your-body-and-mind-296226> 2015 [08.01.2015].

good journalism due to being judgemental.⁷⁸ The fact that popular magazines address the topic of ayahuasca proves that, due to the process of globalization, the brew used till recently only by the endogenous cultures of South America has spread around the world and now it serves people as a sacrament, a psychedelic or a psychopharmacotherapeutic agent.

The subjective effects of ayahuasca, and of other psychedelic drugs, are determined not merely by its chemical compounds but also by the context of use. The participant's set and setting in which ayahuasca is drunk are crucial factors for the whole ayahuasca experience. There are many contexts in which ayahuasca is being consumed, and the most common are: shamanistic, neoshamanistic, religious, and therapeutic. Drinking ayahuasca almost in every case is connected to some kind of spiritual practice. There are many reasons for this. First of all, consumption of ayahuasca can be very unpleasant since it has very powerful purgative properties (in Latin America it is sometimes called *la purga*), thus it is rather not used as a party drug. Purging is believed to work on both physical and psychological level, and it is always recognized as something positive, even if accompanied by unpleasant feelings.

Ayahuasca may cause visions, psychological insights, spiritual experiences and various sorts of alterations of consciousness. All these phenomena can be either ecstatic and mystical or nightmarish. In both scientific and popular literature the term 'bad trip' is used to describe difficult experiences with ayahuasca or any other psychedelic. However in the case of consuming ayahuasca in spiritual context, the notion of a bad trip is absent. Even though experiences are not always pleasant, and as a matter of fact they can be very disturbing, they are never believed to be simply of negative value. In fact, difficult experiences are often described to be beneficial, since they can serve as a way to get free of maladaptive coping mechanisms.

⁷⁸ W. Cieśla, *Ayahuasca - narkotyk od czarownika*, http://polska.newsweek.pl/ayahuasca-narkotyk-uzaleznienie-zakup-newsweek-pl,artykuly,341625,1.html#utm_source=rasp&utm_medium=click&utm_campaign=autor 2014 [08.01.2015].

Ayahuasca, when being used in spiritual practice, is called *la medicina*, Mama Aya, or the teacher plant. *Ayahuasceros*, people who drink ayahuasca, participate in ayahuasca ceremonies mostly to learn from the spirits and to gain physical and psychological purification. The plant is called the teacher of all teachers⁷⁹ and people are its students.

Traditionally ayahuasca is used by *curanderos* (healers and shamans) to contact spirits and to gain knowledge. They address the spiritual world in order to heal, to see the distant lands, to get advice on matters important for the tribe. Nowadays in neoshamanistic movements, traditional faiths mixed with Christian, Hindu and New Age beliefs create a spiritual background for many ayahuasca ceremonies held all around the world. Ayahuasca has become a sacrament for some Christian churches originating in Brazil as well. União de Vegetal (UDV), Santo Daime and Barquinha are the three most known churches that use ayahuasca during their ceremonies. They were created in the twentieth century and they represent a fusion of Christian and traditional shamanistic beliefs.

SANTO DAIME

Santo Daime is a modern religion originating in Brazil that uses ayahuasca as a sacrament. Santo Daime was established in 1930s in Brazil by Raimundo Irineu Serra who was later known as Mestre Irineu. He was a black rubber tapper who first came in contact with ayahuasca through indigenous Indian healers of the Amazon. While drinking ayahuasca for several days, he had a revelation in which he saw a female figure, The Queen of the Forest, whom he later identified as Virgin Mary. She instructed him that he should start working as a healer and gave him a call for founding a new religion. She told him to address her in his prayers as

⁷⁹ In one of the Santo Daime hymns, ayahuasca (*daime*) is praised as an incorporation of the divine teacher: The Daime is the Daime / The Master of all teachings / It is the Divine Eternal Father / And all divine Beings' (*Santo Daime: Blue Book* (2009), The Confluence of Light and Love, St. Louis, Missouri, p. 14).

Daime which literary means ‘give me’, thus the name of the church, Santo Daime, means ‘Holy Give Me’.⁸⁰

The death of Mestre Irineu in 1971 led to a division among the *daimistas* (members of the Santo Daime community). Nowadays, the biggest church following closely the Mestre Irineaus’ teachings is CEFLURIS (*Centro Eclético Fluente Luz Universal Raimundo Irineu Serra*) known also simply as Santo Daime. The next leader of the church was *Padrinho* (‘God-father’) Sebastião. It was him who introduced the sacramental use of cannabis known under its sacred name as Santa Maria. Since marijuana is illegal in most countries, the Netherlands is the only place in which ceremonies of Santa Maria can be officially held. As cannabis is usually treated as a common party drug, *daimistas* distinguish ritual consumption of marijuana from its recreational use even though this distinction is not clear.⁸¹

Since 1990 Santo Daime, under the leadership of *Padrinho* Alfredo, has spread from Brazil, and now it boasts members in many countries around the world. In Europe the communities of Santo Daime are found in Spain, Belgium, Netherlands, Germany, France, Italy, Portugal, England, Ireland, and Switzerland.⁸² Unfortunately, ayahuasca in many European countries is illegal therefore the followers need to stay underground. The only European country in which ceremonies are practised without any legal obstacles is the Netherlands.

TRABALHOS

Rituals of Santo Daime are called works (*trabajos*). This underlines the fact that taking part in every ceremony is psychologically demanding so that participation is always a matter of individual’s decision. First, every new

⁸⁰ E. MacRae, *The ritual use of ayahuasca by three Brazilian religions*, [in]: R. Coomber, N. South, (eds) *Drug Use and Cultural Contexts ‘Beyond the West’*, Free Association Books, 2004, p. 33.

⁸¹ E. MacRae, *Santo Daime and Santa Maria – The licit ritual use of ayahuasca and the illicit use of cannabis in a Brazilian Amazonian religion*, ‘International Journal of Drug Policy’, 1998, 9, pp. 333–334.

⁸² <http://santodaime.nl>

celebrant needs to provide a written statement that he or she participates by his or her own free will, then the participant is obliged to stay in the church during the whole mass. This request is made mostly to ensure the safety of the individuals, since strong psychedelic properties of ayahuasca make it dangerous for anybody to be alone in the course of the drug's action. The concept of work stresses the fact that genuine reason for drinking *daime* is engaging in spiritual practice, not seeking pleasure. *Daimistas* often say that *daime* is for everyone but not everyone is for *daime*. This is the reason why Santo Daime does not do a missionary work in order to convert people for their faith. Freedom of choice and acceptance of diversity is essential for their beliefs. This diversity also characterises ayahuasca experience itself, as every single experience is different and even advanced *daimistas* cannot predict what their next experience will be like.

Within the Santo Daime works, there is a very interesting relation between the communal and individual aspects of the ayahuasca experience. On the one hand, every work takes place in a person's own mind, and it is very private. Sometimes ayahuasca visions are so emotionally powerful and significant that they could even be called intimate. It is common for people to cry during ceremonies, their tears can be either of sadness, joy, or gratefulness. On the other hand, each work has a crucial social aspect. Namely, there are specific codes which are meant to be respected by everybody. During the mass people should remain sited in their places, assigned to them according to their sex, age, and position in the community. Chairs are arranged around the centre of the church with men sitting at one side and women sitting on the other. *Daimistas*, members of the church, sit near the altar, and guests, people who take part in the ceremony while not being full members, sit towards the edges. While attending the mass, people usually remain sited except for standing up during prayers. Anyone can also leave the circle when feeling unwell, and for this reason buckets are placed around the church in case someone feeling nauseous. However people are expected to return to their places immediately after they clean themselves up. Inexperienced participants may lose control and cry loudly, scream, or even try to run. Therefore, just in case, there are always people whose role is to watch over newcomers and make sure that nothing dangerous is going to happen to them.

There are different codes for each of the five types of ceremony performed by the Santo Daime community. The most common one is called *concentracao* (meditative session); apart from that, there are specific festive sessions (like Christmas), healing sessions, special masses for the dead, and *feitio* – ceremony for preparing *daime*. During the festive sessions, people are singing *hinos* (hymns) and dancing in a structured manner.⁸³ At a *concentracao* in the Netherlands, which I was permitted to attend, *daime* was consumed two times during the whole night. Second drinking was accompanied by smoking marijuana, as it is believed that the ceremony of Santa Maria allows to connect to the feminine aspect of the divine.⁸⁴

THE MUSICAL DOCTRINE

Santo Daime has no theology in the western sense of the term. There is no official doctrine, no writings, except for the *hinários* (hymn books). These hymns are usually simple religious songs, nevertheless they are the core of the Santo Daime beliefs – for this reason doctrine of Santo Daime is sometimes called a musical doctrine.⁸⁵ Hymns are believed to be given by the divine power to the community through the masters of the church who receive them in their visions. Hymns are so important, that sometimes they are called the Third Testament. They are essentially connected with the ayahuasca experience and they are believed to have a double meaning – the first one is open to the public, but the other, sacred meaning, reveals itself only after drinking *daime*.

‘*Daime forca, daime amor, daime luz*’ (‘Give me strength, give me love, give me light’) – these are the words which can be found in many Santo Daime hymns. Below I quote one of the Santo Daime hymn received by *Padrinho Sebastião* in one of his visions:

⁸³ B. Shanon, op. cit., pp. 22–23.

⁸⁴ E. MacRae, *The ritual use of ayahuasca by three Brazilian religions*, op. cit., p. 8.

⁸⁵ Ibidem, p. 6.

Firmeza
Firmness

Firmeza, firmeza no amor
Firmness, firmness in love

Firmeza, firmeza aonde estou
Firmness, firmness where I am

Eu estou firme com meu Jesus
I am firm with my Jesus

Eu estou firme nesta luz
I am firm in this light

Aonde estou
Where I am

Firmeza, firmeza no amor
Firmness, firmness in love

Firmeza, firmeza aonde estou
Firmness, firmness where I am

O Mestre manda eu trabalhar
The Master orders me to work

O Mestre manda eu me firmar
The Master orders me to firm myself

No lugar onde ele está
In the place where He is.⁸⁶

I believe that this hymn represents the overall spiritual atmosphere of Santo Daime. People of Santo Daime are not mystics, living on their own and outside of the society, since ayahuasca experience both serves them as true way of connecting to the divine and it helps them to become good and respectable members of the society. Even though the origins of the church are traced back to the poor of Brazil, nowadays many members of

⁸⁶ Santo Daime: Blue Book, op. cit., p. 2.

the church are middle class citizens successful in their private and professional lives.

For the *daimistas* ayahuasca is primary a sacrament, identified with the blood of Christ, that enables personal contact with a transcendent reality of the sacred. Besides, ayahuasca serves as a therapeutic tool, for many *daimistas* used to suffer from substance abuse prior to joining the community. Visions seen during the ayahuasca experience has made them join the Daime community and break the addiction. In fact scientific examinations prove that 'previously-existing addiction problems had resolved after participants began ritual use of ayahuasca'.⁸⁷

AYAHUASCA IN THE AGE OF GLOBAL VILLAGE

Until recently Santo Daime and other ayahuasca religions had members only in Brazil. However, currently ayahuasca becomes more and more popular around the world serving as a sacrament for many of those who value ayahuasca experience as a way to contact the divine. Robert S. Gable states that '[m]any reported experiences are similar to descriptions of *samadhi* in advaitan Hinduism, *satori* in Zen Buddhism and *beatific vision* in Christianity'.⁸⁸ Scientific studies confirm that consumption of ayahuasca in a religious setting is safe when used by healthy individuals in a controlled environment.⁸⁹ Nevertheless, ayahuasca experience can act as a trigger for spiritual crisis with possibly negative consequences. Such distresses may be caused not only by a bad trip but also by mystical experiences occurring either naturally or under the influence of ayahuasca. A spiritual experience lacking an adequate context for its interpretation can lead to a psychological crisis. Even so, as noted by Lewis, who interviewed people claiming to suffer from psychological distress following

⁸⁷ J. C. Fabregas et al., *Assessment of addiction severity among ritual users of ayahuasca*, 'Drug and Alcohol Dependence', 2010, 111, p. 260.

⁸⁸ R. S. Gable, *Risk assessment of ritual use of oral dimethyltryptamine (DMT) and harmala alkaloids*, 'Addiction', 2007, 102, p. 32.

⁸⁹ Ibidem, p. 24.

ayahuasca ceremonies, '[t]heir experiences suggest that distress was a necessary catalyst for a transformation leading to personal growth'.⁹⁰

Since ayahuasca is not merely another psychedelic, but on the contrary, it is a sacrament, there is a vital necessity for changing the law, which nowadays in many countries, including Poland, penalises the possession and use of ayahuasca in any context. This matter has not yet entered the public debate since as far as I know there are no Santo Daime or UDV communities in Poland. However this situation is soon to change because of growing popularisation of alternative medicine, including ayahuasca. Every year many Polish citizens participate in Santo Daime works around the world, seeking an opportunity for personal and spiritual growth where they acquaint themselves with the transformative and healing potential of ayahuasca.

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⁹⁰ S. E. Lewis, *Ayahuasca and Spiritual Crisis: Liminality as Space for Personal Growth*, 'Anthropology of Consciousness', 2008, 19:2, p. 110.

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PSYCHEDELIC SUBSTANCES AND ESOTERICISM – CHOSEN ASPECTS

Spiritual visions, or in scientific discourse, alternative states of consciousness, are a phenomenon which interests many disciplines of religious studies. Psychology of religion, ethnology or history of religion – all research, within their own scopes, the origin of this phenomenon, and its influence on the person experiencing them.

Religious rituals or rites oriented towards spiritual illumination often entailed the use of psychedelic substances. These are such an integral part of the human experience that only one known society (the Inuit people) have not harvested any psychedelic substances, due to their environmental situation being completely unsuitable for cultivation of any narcotic plants.⁹¹ Research of paleolithic cave paintings in France has shown that the paint used to make them contained hallucinogen substances, and the mode of use of this paint (taking it into the mouth, mixing with saliva and blowing it out on the cave wall) makes it clear that the psychedelic visions shown on the paintings were an effect of this activity.⁹² Ideograms dated 4000 BC show the Sumerians and Assyrians using opium (poppy plant is described as 'the plant that brings happiness'). Opium reached the Ancient Greece through Egypt, and it was used for religious reasons during temple fumigation and oracle rituals, it was offered to the gods and ingested as psychedelic during the mysteries.⁹³ Researchers of this field point out that various narcotics were used in religious and magical rites by both ancient and modern peoples.⁹⁴ They were used by the Native Americans, both Northern and Southern, the aforementioned Ancient

⁹¹ S. Walton, *Out of It: A Cultural History of Intoxication*, London 2001, p. 2.

⁹² A. Szyjewski, *Etnologia religii*, Kraków 2001, p. 282.

⁹³ J. T. Bąbel, *Środki psychoaktywne w kulturach megalitycznych Europy Środkowej. Zarys Problematyki*, [in:] J. Libera, K. Tunia (eds), *Idea megalityczna w obrządku pogrzebowym Kultury Pucharów Lejkowatych*, Kraków-Lublin 2006, p. 182.

⁹⁴ Cf. T. Sikora, *Użycie substancji halucynogennych a religia*, Kraków 2003.

Greeks, Assyrians, Chinese, Persians, Hindus etc. This last people revered the gods Haoma and Soma, who were sanctified forms of hallucinogenic plants used for cult purposes for millenia.⁹⁵ Pantanjali (2nd century BC) already wrote in his *Jogasutra* that 'the supernatural powers (*sidhi*) are caused by incarnation (being born, *najman*), through the miraculous medicines (*osadhi*), through magical spells (*mantra*), ascetics (*tapas*), and through focusing the mind (*samadhi*)'.⁹⁶ However, these 'miraculous medicines' or 'herbs filled with light' were not, as he stated, free of karmic accretions, as only the consciousness born of contemplation is free of those.

Over the centuries, the mystery religions (of Bacchus and Diana, Attis and Kybele⁹⁷) were subjugated by the hierarchical religions, which formed a clearly hostile approach to narcotics, including alcohol (Islam), seeing them as the cause of sin. To illustrate, one can use the example of the Inca people, among whom the use of coca can be traced as far back as 6000 BC, according to the latest archeological research. The catholic conquistadors aimed at a total prohibition of coca use, with the catholic officials being aware that 'one of the ways to pull the Indians away from Inca rituals was taking away the coca leaves'.⁹⁸ During the episcopal conference in Lima, in 1569, this shrub was deemed cursed, and the results of coca ingestion the work of devil himself. The war on coca, started by the church, was partly halted by the conquistadors themselves when they realised they can use it to enhance productivity of colonised workers.⁹⁹

In religious discourse, alternative states of consciousness, such as mystical ecstasy, usually take the form of direct relation of the human being with the divinity, but in most cases (because there are churches using pe-

⁹⁵ R. Czyżykowski, *Wedyjska soma – perspektywy badawcze*, [in:] *Narkotyki, dopalacze, środki psychoaktywne. Studia socjologiczne i kulturoznawcze*, red. E. Anczyk, pp. 183–203.

⁹⁶ L. Cyboran, *Klasyczna joga indyjska*, Warszawa 1986, p. 202.

⁹⁷ Cf. K. Banek, *Mistycy i bezbożnicy. Przełom religijny VI–V w. p.n.e. w Grecji*, Kraków 2003.

⁹⁸ H. Hobhouse, *Ziarna zmian. Sześć roślin, które zmieniły oblicze świata*. Warszawa 2001, p. 427.

⁹⁹ Ł. Kamieński, *Farmakologizacja wojny. Historia narkotyków na polu bitwy*, Kraków 2012, p. 77.

yote or ayahuasca in mysteries) the key condition is the ‘clarity of message’, meaning that the divine epiphany should be spontaneous, or generated through ascetic techniques (fasting, mortification of the flesh etc.). Since official religious currents have rejected narcotic substances from their array of techniques for worshipper-divinity contact (due to their need to control their flock, but also due to the changing social attitude towards the substances themselves), psychedelic substances have emerged in esotericism. Sometimes they are used as means of gaining insight into extrasensory worlds, but they have also (and this is the majority) been ascribed to esoteric practitioners by the apologists of official religions as means of discrediting esotericism, due to the negative image of narcotics themselves.

In its simplest, etymological meaning, ‘esotericism’ comes from the Greek word *esôterikos*, from *esôtero* (*esô*: ‘inside’). The word means all that is ‘interior’. Today, the term ‘esotericism’ seems to be used by scholars in two different meanings, which should not be confused:

‘in a typological sense it refers to traditions of secrecy or (mainly among authors inspired by “religionist” agendas) to what is seen as the deeper “inner mysteries of religion” as opposed to merely external or “exoteric” religious observance, but in a strictly historical sense it functions, rather, as a general label for a series of specific currents in Western culture that display certain similarities and are historically related’.¹⁰⁰

According to Tiryakian’s definition, esotericism is a system of convictions about the cognitive orientation of Nature and the cosmos, and of epistemological and ontological reflection on the ultimate reality, which are a starting point for occult procedures.¹⁰¹ However, many scholars insist this definition does not clarify much. As J. Sieradzan rightly said, the definition of esotericism is so fluid that what some researchers deem to be esotericism, others consider to be Satanism or occultism, or the other way

¹⁰⁰ W. J. Hanegraaff (ed.), *Dictionary of Gnosis & Western Esotericism*, Leiden 2006, p. XI.

¹⁰¹ E. A. Tiryakian, *Toward the Sociology of Esoteric Culture*, [in:] E. A. Tiryakian (ed.), *On the Margin of the Visible: Sociology, the Esoteric and the Occult*, New York 1974, p. 265.

around.¹⁰² The most important expert on esotericism today, W. J. Hanegraaff, considers it to be the 'rejected knowledge'¹⁰³ and distinguishes, after A. Faivre, four important traits of western esotericism and two less important traits which do not have to occur. These are:

'(1) a belief in invisible and non-causal 'correspondences' between all visible and invisible dimensions of the cosmos, (2) a perception of nature as permeated and animated by a divine presence or life-force, (3) a concentration on the religious imagination as a power that provides access to worlds and levels of reality intermediary between the material world and God, (4) the belief in a process of spiritual transmutation by which the inner man is regenerated and re-connected with the divine. The two non-intrinsic characteristics – frequently but not always present – are (1) the belief in a fundamental concordance between several or all spiritual traditions, and (2) the idea of a more or less secret transmission of spiritual knowledge'.¹⁰⁴

Yoga techniques, breathing exercises, fasting or isolation are quite helpful when striving to obtain visions, but the most effective is meditation enhanced with entheogenic substances. The pharmacological effect of hallucinogenic substances entails heightened sensory sensitivity, especially visual and auditory, so psychedelics lead to a stronger presence of sub-conscious content in consciousness.

'Since we then experience the heights and depths of existence with great intensity, there is a danger that we will not be able to integrate our experiences. For this reason, using entheogenic substances is, in archaic cultures, always steeped in religious and ritual context. Thus, they can lead

¹⁰² J. Sieradzan, *W kręgu pojęć: ezoteryzm, okultyzm, satanizm*, [in:] Z. Pasek (ed.), *Ezoteryzm, okultyzm, satanizm w Polsce*, Kraków 2005, p. 219.

¹⁰³ Cf. W. J. Hanegraaff, *Esotericism and the Academy. Rejected Knowledge in Western Culture*, London 2012.

¹⁰⁴ *Esotericism*, [in:] W. J. Hanegraaff (ed.), op. cit., p. 340.

to what humanity wants most, the *unio mystica* and the happiness that comes with it'.¹⁰⁵

Because we can only partially experience the external world (the sender) in the normal state of consciousness, some people induce the mystical state of mind on purpose, tuning their recipient capacity to the 'broadest bandwidth', dissipating – often with the help of psychedelic substances – the boundaries between the ego and the surrounding world, allowing the inner and outer world to merge.

The attitude of esotericism towards narcotics is not univocal. It has been changing throughout the centuries, taking various forms, from complete negation, through reserved acquiescence, to complete hallowed acceptance. The entire history of psychedelic use in esotericism has not been described in Polish literature so far, most of the articles on the subject coming from Western science. It should be noted that researching the matter is not an easy task. Firstly, the social attitude towards narcotics has changed dramatically through the ages. Mid-nineteenth century, some narcotics which are prohibited today were legally on sale over the counter. Naturally, an important part of this change was the advancement of medical knowledge on the addictive and crippling effects of some narcotic drugs.

Secondly, as already mentioned, ascribing narcotic use to certain groups was a deliberate attempt of discrediting an individual or community in the eyes of other religions or society as a whole. In such a case it is very difficult to distinguish the truth from purposeful manipulation.

The third matter is somewhat related to the first. Currently, many esoterists or esoteric congregations officially distance themselves from the use and promotion of narcotics as an element enhancing the mystical insight, or aiding contact with sacrum. Nevertheless, psychedelics are used unofficially, and the adherents know very well that they may even be required on a certain level of initiation. Thus, official teachings of a given master or group should be distinguished from the inner practices.

¹⁰⁵ A. Hofmann, *Eliksir Hofmanna. LSD i nowe Eleuzis. Albert Hofmann i inni, rozmowy i eseje w opracowaniu Amandy Feilding*, Warszawa 2011, p. 92.

Wouter J. Hanegraaff mentions this in his *Entheogenic Esotericism*, a text which will be cited later.

It is thus important that research on the relations between narcotics and esotericism takes all these problems into account. Cultural context must be researched, as must be the perception of a given individual or group by the dominant religions of their environment, and their official and unofficial position on ideas and practices.¹⁰⁶

The most famous oracle, the Pythia priestess, was said to pronounce her prophecies in the state of intoxication, either natural or induced. It could have been induced through the smoke of burned plants¹⁰⁷ or through volcanic fumes.¹⁰⁸ Opium was likely used in Ancient Crete and Greece, by the Demeter cult related to Eleusinian mysteries¹⁰⁹ (Egyptians used it when venerating Osiris). Mircea Eliade mentions the possible existence of Greek shamanism when writing about *kapnobatai* of Mysia, or 'those who walk on smoke'. The smoke in question is the cannabis smoke, the main source of ecstasy for Thracians and Scythians as well.¹¹⁰ Eliade

¹⁰⁶ It should be noted that research into the influence of dance, self-harm and drugs on causing ecstatic states has already been done over a century ago by Achelis (see Th. Achelis, *Die Ekstase In ihrer kulturellen Bedeutung*, Berlin, 1902).

¹⁰⁷ S. Oświecimski, *Zeus daje tylko znak, Apollo wieszczy o sobiście*. Wrocław 1989, p. 125 nn.

¹⁰⁸ The incredibly interesting debate on what was it exactly that Pythia was intoxicated with persists to this day. Plutarch described nauseating vapors rising from fissures in the stony temple floor. A British scholar, A. P. Oppe, made an extensive research in the temple and stated authoritatively that there are no significant fissures in it, while Pierre Amandry stated that the area of the Delphi temple has been volcanically inactive for a long time and thus produced no toxic gases. This has, for many years, stopped any scientific debate on the subject, until new research has been made, and an interdisciplinary team of J. Z. De Boer, J. R. Hale and J. Chanton published their daring text, *New evidence for the geological origins of the ancient Delphic Oracle*, in 'Geology' 2001, 29, pp. 707–710. It stated that the presence of a tectonic fault, with its overlapping strata and friction, results in heat production. This heat causes evaporation of bituminous calcium deposits, which in turn produces methane, ethane and ethylene. This ethylene is theorised to be the narcotic the oracle used. This thesis was subsequently refuted in a publication by J. Foster, D. Lehoux, *The Delphic Oracle and the ethylene-intoxication hypothesis*, 'Clinical Toxicology' 2007, 45, pp. 85–89.

¹⁰⁹ K. Kerényi, *Dionizos*, Kraków 1997, p. 35 nn.

¹¹⁰ M. Eliade, *Szamanizm i archaiczne techniki ekstazy*, Warszawa 2001, p. 387.

points out, however, that narcotics in shamanism are not a vulgar substitute of 'pure' trance.¹¹¹ Chinese Taoists in 1st century AD, turning their interest towards magic and alchemy,¹¹² recommended adding cannabis seeds to burning braziers, and the hallucinations thus caused were considered valuable in the pursuit of immortality.¹¹³ The ointments said to be used by witches for flying (the ingredients of which will be described in detail later) have been known as early as the 2nd century AD, through Apuleius's description of Pamphile.¹¹⁴

Sufism, an Islamist esoteric splinter group (economically and socially discriminated), is considered to be the oldest group using hashish on a larger scale, and defending its use – at least within their own practice – as helpful to attain contact with god.¹¹⁵ Despite the considerable importance of hashish and other psychedelics in Islamist mysticism and esotericism, their holy men did not resort to such surrogate means (ecstasy thus induced was said to come from pre-Islamist¹¹⁶ mystical techniques, and from distorted Hindu techniques which influenced Sufism).¹¹⁷ This relation between hashish and the Sufi community was the cause for the image hashish being that of a substance encouraging contemplation, discouraging work and making their users pariahs; the words 'hashish user' themselves became an insult. Even among modern esotericists there is a belief that a Nizari sect – the name of which is currently spoken as 'assassins' – came to be named because of their use of hashish.¹¹⁸ These followers of Nizar, in their early days, have been offensively branded '*hashishiyya*' or 'hashish users' by their opponents. This term was propagated in Europe by Marco Polo in his account of his time in Persia in 1273.¹¹⁹ The warriors

¹¹¹ Ibidem, p. 397.

¹¹² On the subject of origins or alchemy and its journey through various cultures, see: R. Prinke, *Zwodniczy ogród błędów. Piśmiennictwo alchemiczne do końca XVIII wieku*, Warszawa 2014.

¹¹³ J. Needham, *Science and Civilization In China*, Cambridge 1974, p. 150.

¹¹⁴ Apulejusz, *Metamorfozy albo złoty osioł*, Wrocław 1953, pp. 66–67.

¹¹⁵ E. L. Abel, *Marihuana, pierwsze dwadzieścia tysięcy lat*, Warszawa 2010, p. 60.

¹¹⁶ On the subject of Islamic magic, see: M. Dziekan, *Arabia magica. Wiedza tajemna u Arabów przed islamem*, Warszawa 1993.

¹¹⁷ M. Eliade, op. cit., p. 398.

¹¹⁸ R.A. Wilson, *Seks, narkotyki i okultyzm*, Toruń 2002, pp. 99–105.

¹¹⁹ Cf. M. Polo, *Opisanie świata*, Warszawa 1975, ks. I, rozdz. XLI–XLII, p. 110.

of Alamut fortress, led by Hasan bin Sabbah, were said to be blindly obedient to the sect and ready to lay down their lives for their cause because of their intoxication with hashish. Hasan himself was said to give hashish to them, and lead the intoxicated men to rooms which were specifically made to imitate the gardens of paradise and staffed by beautiful houris. After such a display of 'power', the warriors were ready to die as the master commanded.¹²⁰ Since the Nizari were very effective and loyal killers, capable of reaching the sultan himself and killing him if their master so required, the legend of hashish fell on fertile ground and lives on today. It is very useful to western esotericism, since the Assassins had contact with the Templars, and such organisations as the Ordo Templi Orientis, an order of sexual magic, claim to be the heirs of Templar traditions. This idea of an esoteric master intoxicating and programming his believers through hashish is disproved by, among others, W. B. Barlett in his book *Assassins. Story of Medieval Islam's secret sect*. In his opinion, the Fedayeen could not have acted under the influence of hashish due to the tactics they chose. The assassin had, in the first phase of his operation, infiltrate the victim's closest circles. To fulfill his mission, he waited for a suitable moment and only attacked when the chances of success were greatest, thus having to wait patiently and closely observe. This task needed a methodical person who could control their actions and emotions, and these are not the traits of a person under the influence of narcotics.¹²¹ Narcotics known at the time, let us add, since substances available today may be helpful in such tasks. Still in the area of Islamic esotericism, the members of Iacubite (Jakubici) brotherhood should be mentioned: while practicing their 'paradise dances' and inducing ecstatic states, they used a special beverage composed, among other things, of baobab leaves.¹²²

An interesting European case is the 'flight ointment' of witches. Catholic demonologists as early as 15th century purported that one of the main elements of the black masses and witches' Sabbaths was the use of hemp. In 1484 an edict of pope Innocent VIII denounced magic and use of hemp in satanic rituals, and in 1615 an Italian medic and demonologist

¹²⁰ The topic of 'hashish warriors' is described in detail by Ł. Kamieński, op. cit., pp. 64–68.

¹²¹ W. B. Bartlett, *Asasyni. Dzieje tajemnej sekty muzulmańskiej*, Warszawa 2004.

¹²² K. Banek, op. cit., p. 87.

Giovanni de Ninault mentioned hemp as the main ingredient of ointments and creams used by devil worshippers.¹²³ Hemp, or cannabis, together with opium, henbane, deadly nightshade, mandrake and hemlock, were said to be commonly used during satanic mysteries to induce ecstasy, intoxication and lust. As a side note, the Catholic church itself also made use of narcotic plants during its holy ordeals. Basing on the assumption that, if the defendant is innocent, God Almighty shall shield them from death, they were given poisonous plants. This practice was outlawed in 1215.¹²⁴

The composition of witches' flying ointment was studied already by 19th century ethnologists, who tried to replicate these 'magic ointments' and, while rubbing them on the skin, did indeed experience hallucinations. At least two medieval authors have supplied trustworthy information on the composition: Weirus, a 17th century doctor, and Jean de Nynauld, in his treatise *De la Lycanthropie, Transformation, et Extase des Sorciers* (Paris, 1615).¹²⁵ The use of a broom or a stick was also not just a case of Freudian symbolism, but a way to rub atropine into sensitive vaginal epithelium, thus strengthening the effect, while also giving the illusion of riding a horse or flying on a broomstick, so typical for Sabbath journeys.¹²⁶

The first to state that psychedelic substances were not an integral nor sanctioned element of esoteric practices was Eliphas Levi (1810–1875), a man deeply respected by later occultists, in his *Dogme et Rituel de la Haute Magie*, published in two volumes in 1854–1856. Helena Petrovna Blavatsky (1831–1891), founder of theosophy, was a staunch opposer of narcotics and alcohol, as manifest in her responses to questions gathered in her fundamental work, *The Key to Theosophy* (1889):

¹²³ A. De Pasquale, *Farmacognosia della 'Canape Indiana*, [in:] Estratto dai Lavori dell'Istituto di Farmacognosia dell'Università di Messina 1967, 5:24.

¹²⁴ M. Motyka, J. T., Marcinkowski, *Dlaczego zażywali środki psychoaktywne? Cz. I. Rola i znaczenie środków psychoaktywnych w kulturze: od Pradziejów do początku XX wieku*, 'Problemy higieny i epidemiologii,' 2014, 95:2, p. 227.

¹²⁵ R. Rudgley, *Alchemia kultury. Od opium do kawy*, Warszawa 2002, p. 111.

¹²⁶ M. J. Harner, *The role of hallucinogenic plants in European witchcraft*, [in:] M. J. Harner (eds), *Hallucinogens and Shamanism*, New York 1973, p. 131. On the subject of Polish witches, see: W. Wyporska, *Witchcraft in Early Modern Poland, 1500-1800*, New York 2013.

‘Q. Then with regard to the use of wine and spirits, I suppose you do not advise people to drink them?

A. They are worse for his moral and spiritual growth than meat, for alcohol in all its forms has a direct, marked, and very deleterious influence on man’s psychic condition. Wine and spirit drinking is only less destructive to the development of the inner powers, than the habitual use of hashish, opium, and similar drugs’.¹²⁷

Violet Mary Firth, formed by a branch of the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn (considered to be the most influential esoteric order of the 19th century; we will come back to it) and better known by her esoteric pseudonym Dion Fortune, called the use of narcotics in magic an undesirable and dangerous practice. She accepted certain experiments with doctor participation, however:

‘All initiates of the Right-hand Path agree in declaring that to exalt consciousness by means of drugs is a dangerous and undesirable proceeding. There may be research workers who for legitimate reasons wish to undertake experiments, but I cannot conceive of any legitimate reason for introducing a neophyte to the drug habit. In any case, if such experiments are undertaken, they should be conducted under the supervision of a qualified medical practitioner who will be in a position to prevent catastrophe or deal with it should it arise’.¹²⁸

The philosopher and mystic George Ivanovich Gurdjieff (about 1870–1949) advised strongly against using substances, which – as he wrote – ruin the lives of millions of people, meaning narcotics, and especially cocaine, popularised during his time.¹²⁹ All this despite his teachings being based heavily on Sufism and dervish practices. Many secret magic associations tried to propagate the idea of a noble and upstanding character

¹²⁷ H. P. Blavatsky, *The Key to Theosophy*, London 1893, p. 176.

¹²⁸ D. Fortune, *Psychic Self-Defense* (New edition), San Francisco 2001, p. 135.

¹²⁹ W. K. Kulczyk, *Wprowadzenie do nauk Gurdżijewa*, Łódź 2004, pp. 129–130.

of their members, like Rosicrucianism,¹³⁰ whose heirs, such as Antiquus Mysticusque Ordo Rosae Crucis (AMORC), pass a prohibition of drugs and alcohol onto their members to this day.

Yet the picture would not be complete without a presentation of the other – less prominent, at least officially – attitude towards psychedelic substances. Their important role in esoteric development is confirmed by such works as *Almanac Prophetique* from 1849, which shows a crowd watching a mage who looks upon the future with a telescope. Among the crowd, placards are visible, bearing signs such as ‘ether’ and ‘hashish’.¹³¹

Paschal Beverly Randolph,¹³² an American doctor, occultist, medium, spiritualist and writer, one of the first esotericists to introduce sexual practice into magic, and probably the oldest known Rosicrucian in the USA, advocated individual development through practical techniques, such as narcotics, mirror magic and sex, in his works.¹³³ However, the first place in propagating magical practices with narcotics use belongs to another person, the ‘father of modern magic’, Aleister Crowley (1875–1947).

There are at least seven detailed and extensive biographies of Crowley. The last of those is the *Perdurabo – The life of Aleister Crowley* by R. Kaczynski, valued among researchers for its incisiveness. The number and volume of titles on Crowley’s life indicate that interest in this controversial personage is not dwindling. Crowley himself, it seems, had never chosen any one direction and definition of himself. He seemed to waver between the image of a typical British gentleman scholar and the depraved magician searching for consciousness-broadening experiences in drugs and sex. Almost until his death he was addicted to stimulants, heroin (which was used as remedy for asthma, from which he suffered, at his time, and which he quit when another remedy became available) and cocaine, thus

¹³⁰ Cf. J. Prokopiuk, *Historia Różo-Krzyża*, Kraków 2013.

¹³¹ *Almanac Prophetique*, Paryż 1849.

¹³² Cf. J. P. Deveney, *Paschal Beverly Randolph: A Nineteenth-Century Black American Spiritualist, Rosicrucian, and Sex Magician*, New York 1997.

¹³³ See Randolph P.B [in:] W. J. Hanegraaff (ed.), *Dictionary...*, p. 976.

'being torn between the heroin-induced stupor and the state of excessive excitation caused by strongly addictive cocaine'.¹³⁴

The Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn is an initiative occult and esoteric organisation founded in London in the second half of the 19th century.¹³⁵ It was there that Crowley made his first steps, and it was here that he and his friend Allan Bennet (1872–1923) were one of the first in Europe¹³⁶ to study and experiment methodically with psychedelic plants used to induce clairvoyance. It should be noted that these studies by Bennett and Crowley induced the ire of the Order's leader and founder, Samuel Liddell MacGregor Mathers (1854–1918), who did not appreciate the scientific aspect and saw in the practice a proof of drug addiction.

Crowley wrote several texts about this research, such as *The Psychology of Hashish* (1908), *Cocaine* (1917), *The Fountain of Hyacinth* (1922), or the nightmare of double addiction to heroin and cocaine described in his novel *Diary of a Drug Fiend*. In his *Liber 777*, he makes a systematic comparison between religion and ceremonial magic, including drug use; for our purposes, however, the most important of his works is *Liber AL vel Legis* (*The Book of the Law*), the main text of Thelema, religion of will, manifested to him in Cairo in 1904. We read there:

'I am the Snake that giveth Knowledge & Delight and bright glory, and stir the hearts of men with drunkenness. To worship me take wine and strange drugs whereof I will tell my prophet, & be drunk thereof! They shall not harm ye at all. It is a lie, this folly against self. The exposure of innocence is

¹³⁴ A. Anczyk, *Życie Aleistera Crowleya jako przykład patogenicznej interpretacji doświadczenia religijnego*, 'Ex Nihilo. Periodyk młodych religioznawców', 2009, 1, p. 26.

¹³⁵ On the subject of the Order of the Golden Dawn, see: E. Howe, *The Magicians of the Golden Dawn*, New York 1972; P. Zasuń, *Hermetyczny Zakon Złotego Brzasku – początki współczesnej ezoteryki*, [in:] Z. Pasek (ed.), op. cit.; R. Prinke, *Dwa rękopisy. Polskie tropy u początków Hermetycznego Zakonu Złotego Brzasku*, 'Hermaion', 2012, 1.

¹³⁶ This subject is described in more detail by R. Rudgley, *Alchemia kultury. Od opium do kawy*, Warszawa 2002, pp. 123–130.

a lie. Be strong, o man! lust, enjoy all things of sense and rapture: fear not that any God shall deny thee for this'.¹³⁷

It is not, however, encouragement to freely dose oneself with drugs. They are only permitted as means of helping nature to overcome obstacles on the path of progress. Use of drugs should, according to Crowley, be a precisely planned and thought out religious act. His, however, is one of the few religious texts that openly refers and permits the use of psychedelic substances.

Crowley's longtime friend and secretary, the esotericist Israel Regardie (1907–1985) wrote thus on Crowley's attitude towards drugs:

'I want to emphasize unequivocally that Crowley has asserted not once but a thousand times that the discipline itself was far more important than any one particular result or attainment. His thesis was that in training a concert pianist for example, one concentrates on drills, scales and exercises until enough manual dexterity and self-discipline has been developed by play Beethoven's Emperor Concerto. One does not start with the latter. It was in this area that he differs seriously from most of our contemporaries. [...] His fundamental premise was stated over and over again, in a hundred different ways. It was never that the drug experience per se could possibly replace the basic mental and spiritual discipline that he stood for, and which all occult teachers insisted upon. In fact, he was relatively certain that whatever the drug experience did evoke would soon be forgotten to become a cold, gray, vague memory'.¹³⁸

Gerard Brousseau Gardner (1884–1964), British occultist and the founder, together with Doreen Valiente (1922–1999) of the syncretic Goddess cult related to various forms of magic called Wicca, does not mention drugs

¹³⁷ A. Crowley, *Liber AL vel Legis*, OTO, London, 1938. Introduction, IV,

¹³⁸ I. Regardie, *Roll Away the Stone: An Introduction to Aleister Crowley's Essays on the Psychology of Hashish with the complete text of The Herb Dangerous [by] Aleister Crowley*, Saint Paul 1968, pp. 23–26.

anywhere in his writings, despite drawing his ideas straight from Crowley. It is known, however, that unofficially, some Wiccan branches that cultivate the Cultus Sabbati initiation ceremony, use psychedelic substances. One of modern Wiccans, Belladonna LaVeau, mentions as one of the eight paths of power incense, drugs, wine and all substances that help to liberate the spirit.¹³⁹

‘Satan represents indulgence instead of abstinence, Satan represents vital existence instead of spiritual pipe dreams, Satan represents undefiled wisdom instead of hypocritical self-deceit, Satan represents kindness to those who deserve it, not love wasted on ingrates, Satan represents vengeance instead of turning the other cheek, Satan represents responsibility to the responsible instead of concern for psychic vampires, (...) Satan represents all of the so-called sins, as they all lead to physical, mental, or emotional gratification’.¹⁴⁰

This is a quote from the most popular work by the most popular modern Satanist, Anton Szandor LaVey (1930–1997). The man who encouraged indulging all animal desires and shedding all limitations¹⁴¹ can certainly be expected to promote drugs, if not for magical reasons then at least for hedonist ones. Yet, when examining descriptions of LaVey’s black masses, the main Satanic ritual, or footage from such an event (1968), we will not see any drugs being taken.¹⁴² Poland’s most popular satanic website (satan.pl) presents their stance on drugs, which is said to reflect the general stance of European Satanic Front, thusly:

‘Satanists may divide substances into hazardous to their health or not, calming or stimulating, creating void and giv-

¹³⁹ B. LaVeau, *Awakening Spirit: Wise Seminary, First Year Certification for Wiccan Clergy*, no publication site given, 2003, p. 296.

¹⁴⁰ A. Sz. LaVey, *The Satanic Bible*, New York 1969, p. 25.

¹⁴¹ A. Sołtysiak, *Dobro i zło według satanistów*, ‘The Peculiarity of Man’, 2000, V, p. 153.

¹⁴² A. Sołtysiak, *Czarna msza. Od mitu do bluźnierczej psychodramy*, [in:] J. Olko (ed.), *Ob-rzęd, teatr, ceremoniał w dawnych kulturach*, Warszawa 2008, pp. 87–94.

ing inspiration, deadly or invigorating, but never into permitted and forbidden. Heroin, alcohol, cocaine, methamphetamines, LSD25, tobacco, mushrooms and marijuana derivatives – addictive substances from strongest to weakest – should be available to educated consumers. ESF will strive to propagate this law in all EU countries’.¹⁴³

However, the official website of the Church of Satan (<http://churchof-satan.com>) reminds that the Church of Satan does not tolerate illegal actions (outlawed substances are considered illegal within the church as well). It also cites LaVey’s words on drug use:

‘At any rate, there is no doubt that the manufacture of love potions (above) and their drinking (below) is very nearly as old as love itself. As to what goes into them, aside from a large dose of suggestion, that is one of the secrets of the profession. LaVey, however, does not hesitate to point out that nothing narcotic is among the ingredients. In fact, the use of any narcotics has no place in magic as LaVey sees it. “It is true that drugs have been used in magic and in certain religious practices and still are by some,” he says. “The use of the peyote ritual in certain Indian churches – and which has been recently adjudged legal – is an example. But for our purposes the use of drugs would be definitely harmful. How serious he is on this point is shown by his attitude on LSD. “Like opium, marijuana, heroin and so forth, it ought to be shunned like the plague” – an interesting observation in view of some of his paintings which, despite a definite beauty, are so macabre that they look like the production of a Left Bank artist who had subsisted for weeks on a diet of absinthe and laudanum’.¹⁴⁴

Naturally, in this case as well, the official stance may differ from the unofficial: drug use has been noted during satanic rituals, and of course

¹⁴³ <http://www.satan.pl/faq.php> [30.12.2014].

¹⁴⁴ <http://churchofsatan.com/policy-on-drug-abuse.php> [30.12.2014].

many branches of Satanism are active nowadays¹⁴⁵ and each one can take its own stance on drug use. We shall not examine all of them in depth here.

In Poland, accusations of Satan worship, performing black masses and drug use were often made towards Czesław Czyński (1858–1932),¹⁴⁶ a hypnotist and occultist of some renown. While there is no proof for his Satanism, drugs are known to have been used by his disciples. His secretary, Bohdan Filipowski, was also a co-author of a book on drugs written with the famous artist and drug fiend Stanisław Ignacy Witkiewicz, known as Witkacy (1885–1939). Since Witkacy was allergic to morphine and could not experience it himself, he tasked Filipowski with doing so and describing the effects. He (Filipowski) was also a heroin user and died due to body exhaustion through drug use. Czyński's lover, miss Hirsz was also accused of drug smuggling. There is no information on Czyński himself using any.

According to Jonn Mumford, teacher of tantra to the people of the West, psychedelic-induced ecstasy is a sanctioned method which, in special circumstances can be used at a certain stage of the practice in order to 'open the universe within the skull'. In his opinion, an adept prepared through long years of yoga practice will not be harmed, and such an experience will be transparent, controlled and re-integrating. However, using such consciousness-broadening substances without caution, preparatory training and absolute physical discipline is likened by Mumford to open-

¹⁴⁵ An introduction into various kinds of Satanism and its history can be found in M. Introvigne, *Satanizm, historia, mity*, Kraków 2014.

¹⁴⁶ Cf. Z. Łagosz, *Na obrzeżach religii i filozofii: Czesław Czyński*, 'Nomos. Kwartalnik religioznawczy' 2006, 53–54, pp. 85–95; Z. Łagosz, *Polska myśl magiczna XX wieku na przykładzie Cz. Czyńskiego*, 'Furor Divinus', 2008, 1, *Materiały z konferencji* Lashtal Press, Gdańsk 2008, pp. 89–104; Z. Łagosz, *Mit polskiego satanizmu. Czesław Czyński – proces, którego nie było*, 'Hermaion' 2012, 1, pp. 186–206; Z. Łagosz, *Czesław Czyński – uwodziciel hipnotyczny*, [in:] B. Płonka-Syroka (ed.) *Antropologia miłości*, t. VII, *Miłość Czarowna*, Wrocław 2015, pp. 157–168.

ing the door to the treasury of the mind by use of dynamite. The explosion destroys half of the treasure, and the door cannot be closed again should the need arise.¹⁴⁷

Many tantric techniques have been adopted by the New Age movement, although drugs found their way there via the '60s revolution. Interestingly enough, even in his research done in 1996 W. Hanegraaff states that one of the most characteristic elements of the counter-culture was their common use of psychedelics, while most of the new religious movements which formed in those years strictly prohibited drug use. They focused on the importance of meditation and other spiritual practice instead, which were alternative means of broadening the consciousness; this approach was claimed by Hanegraaff to be typical of New Age movements.¹⁴⁸ However, in his *Entheogenic esotericism*, Hanegraaff points out his own naivete, saying he ought to have been more susceptible, while drawing his previous conclusions, to the unofficial importance of psychedelics in the lives of authors he cited. LSD had been made illegal by then, and Hanegraaff cites Capra's book *The Tao of Physics* (1975) as an example of indirect description of psychedelic experiences induced by the substance.¹⁴⁹

To end these considerations, I will mention an interesting example which has no equivalent in the Western esoteric tradition: the Bimin-Kuskusmin practices of one of the Ok people, living in the mountains of Sandaun in New Guinea. It is an initiatory system, where the elders are those who have passed all the stages and who possess all the knowledge of the ritualistic lore. Initiation into the system happens through ingestion of *waraang*, a sacred plant, and each of the twelve ritual stages of initiation entails ingestion of another substance. The higher one climbs in the hierarchy, the stronger the required drug is, and the initiated is permitted to use the substance that befits his new position as well as the previous, weaker ones, while being strictly prohibited from using the substances

¹⁴⁷ J. Mumford, *Psychoseksualna moc*, [in:] E. Obarski (ed.), *Ekstaza, seks, magia. Inny wymiar erotyki*, Wrocław 1993, pp. 130–131.

¹⁴⁸ W. J. Hanegraaf, *New Age Religion and Western Culture*, Leiden 1996, p. 11.

¹⁴⁹ W. J. Hanegraaf, *Entheogenic Esotericism*, [in:] E. Asprem, K. Granholm (eds), *Contemporary Esotericism*, Sheffield 2012, p. 396.

appropriate for those of a higher level. In this system, sacred substances form an orderly hierarchical system and reflect social position. Their use gives access to hidden wisdom, contact with the ancestral world but also with oneself. Plant care entails magical rites as well as animal sacrifice which is meant to promote growth and power of the plant.¹⁵⁰

As a summary, it can be said that esotericism does not eschew psychedelic drugs. They are used openly or (especially nowadays) covertly. This is not surprising, considering that 90% of known human cultures entailed institutionalised use of trances, usually through use of hallucinogens.¹⁵¹ This introduction into the subject of drug use in esotericism is only a small portion of a subject that still waits to be studied.

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¹⁵⁰ R. Rudgley, op. cit., pp. 100–101.

¹⁵¹ A. Szyjewski, *Szamanizm*, Kraków 2005, p. 19.

PSILOPIN AND MEDITATION: ATTEMPT AT A COMPARISON OF EXPERIENCES CAUSED BY PSILOPIN AND THOSE CAUSED BY MEDITATION PRACTICES USING MODERN SCIENTIFIC RESEARCH

INTRODUCTION

What psychedelics and meditation undeniably have in common is their strong influence on the state of consciousness. In this paper, I refer to research published in the last decade. I analyse and compare the states of consciousness caused by meditation practices and psilocybin ingestion.

My analysis is mostly based on research on neural correlates between the chosen states of consciousness, and on the conclusions thereof. Aware of the limits imposed by passing third-hand data and first-hand experience, I complement third-hand research with an analysis of questionnaires relating subjective experiences, as well as phenomenological descriptions of specific subjective experiences, in accordance with cognitive neuroscience paradigms.

I have narrowed the scope of research to one psychedelic substance to avoid generalisations, since each one of those substances has a unique influence on the human psychophysical system. I chose psilocybin since it is a better researched subject if compared to other psychedelics. The active ingredient of psilocybin is psilocin,¹⁵² for which reason I will use the two terms interchangeably.

¹⁵² The terms psilocybin and psilocin can be used interchangeably in the context of causing psychedelic experiences, because psilocybin is metabolised into psilocin.

To avoid further generalisations, I will also present a distinction between several types of meditation, to demonstrate which among them differ – or resemble – the states caused by psilocin ingestion, and how.

INTRINSIC AND EXTRINSIC NETWORK

To further explain the differences between states caused by meditation and psilocybin, I shall start with an important distinction on neural level. Modern neurosciences distinguish two types of neural connection nets: the intrinsic network and the extrinsic network.¹⁵³

Intrinsic network or default-mode network (DMN)

The DMN is a neural correlate of the ‘internal’ thought processes, such as projecting the future, creating depictions, remembering the past, pondering moral questions or making decisions. Simplifying, the DMN is a neural correlate of such thought as is not related to reaction to current external stimuli.¹⁵⁴ It also associates these brain areas which are active when we are not dealing with anything specific, and thus sometimes it is called resting state network (RSN).

The DMN receives a larger blood flow and consumes more energy than other brain areas, and functions as the central hub for various functional connectivities (FC). It is speculated that the DMN is the biological system responsible for the psychological concept of ‘I’ or ego.¹⁵⁵ Patients waking from a coma into consciousness show activation of DMN, especially the precuneus.¹⁵⁶ Similarly, the precuneus is activated when regaining consciousness during lucid dreaming. Thus, it is speculated that the DMN

¹⁵³ Z. Josipovic et al., *Influence of meditation on anti-correlated networks in the brain*, ‘Frontiers in Human Neuroscience’, 2012, 5:183, p. 1.

¹⁵⁴ V. A. Taylor et al., *Impact of meditation training on the default mode network during a restful state*, ‘Social Cognitive & Affective Neuroscience’, 2013, 8:1, p. 5.

¹⁵⁵ R. L. Carhart-Harris et al., *Functional connectivity measures after psilocybin inform a novel hypothesis of early psychosis*, *Schizophrenia Bulletin*, 2012, 39:6, p. 1344.

¹⁵⁶ Z. Josipovic, *Neural correlates of nondual awareness in meditation*, ‘Annals of the New York Academy of Sciences’, 2013, 1307:1, p. 2.

and especially the precuneus may be the important neural correlates of consciousness and its willfulness.

Extrinsic network or task-positive network (TPN)

It is the neural correlate of activities connected with perception and action in the external world, such as optical perception of a dot on the wall. The extrinsic network is made principally of those brain areas that are responsible for perception and movement.

The DMN and the TPN compete with each other. When one is active, the other is subdued and vice versa. The dynamic of this competition is the same in most states of consciousness, including the waking state, the resting state, sleep and dreaming.¹⁵⁷ Interestingly, in both meditation-induced and psilocybin-induced states, the relation between DMN and TPN can change, which will be described in a following section.

TYPOLGY OF MEDITATION PRACTICES AND THEIR NEURAL CORRELATES

Basing on modern research on meditation, a distinction can be made into four main types of meditation:

1. Focused attention (FA)
2. Open monitoring (OM), also called mindfulness meditation,
3. Nondual awareness (NDA)¹⁵⁸
4. Meditation of pure consciousness (PC)¹⁵⁹

¹⁵⁷ Z. Josipovic et al., *Influence of meditation on anti-correlated networks in the brain*, 'Frontiers in Human Neuroscience', 2012, 5:183, p.1.

¹⁵⁸ Ibidem, p. 2.

¹⁵⁹ A type of meditation distinguished through my own work. Related to suppressing the distinction between the subject and object, and subsequent erasure of all object, when only pure consciousness is present. It is a characteristic state of classical yoga tradition, where it is called *nirbija samādhi*, focus without seed.

There exist types of meditation based on visualisation, mostly in Tibetan Buddhism and bon tradition. These are mostly an imagery variant of the FA meditation, but can take various forms. Because of their complex and unique character, I omit here tantric meditation and other forms of visualisation meditation for the sake of clarity.

Focused attention meditation

FA¹⁶⁰ entails focusing attention on one object and keeping it that way for as long as possible. This object can be real, like the feeling of the breath brushing against the nostrils, or imaginary, like visualising a black dot on a white background. FA can be the goal of meditation in itself, where due to concentration on one object, the dispersed thoughts characteristic of everyday mental life is strongly limited, resulting in less pressure on referring the ego to any kind of mental image. The neuronal correlate of this phenomenon is subdued activity of the posterior superior parietal lobule (PSPL), responsible for spatial orientation.¹⁶¹ It is also responsible for the perception of 'I' because, through arranging the sensory perception, we perceive some sensations as ourselves and others as something separate from ourselves. In deep meditative focus, PSPL activity is subdued, which is a neural correlate of subduing the perception of 'I'. The stronger the meditative focus, the stronger is the alteration of 'I' and calming of the mind. This is due to the link between the PSPL with the thalamus, which filters the sensory experiences. Stronger mental focus means better filtering of experiences and unification of the mind.

Attaining the single-point attention state in a meditative process is related to several cognitive activities: selective attention, keeping it on a single object, and monitoring it. Experts of FA meditation (over 44 000 hours of

¹⁶⁰ A detailed description of this type of meditation can be found in: A. Lutz et al., *Attention regulation and monitoring in meditation*, 'Trends in Cognitive Sciences', 2008, 12:4, pp.1–7.

¹⁶¹ D. J. J. Wang et al., *Cerebral blood flow changes associated with different meditation practices and perceived depth of meditation*. 'Psychiatry Research: Neuroimaging', 2011, 91:1.

practice) also show weaker activity of the amygdala during meditation, which is related to its calming effects¹⁶².

FA meditation has many purposes. Suppressing thoughts calm the practitioner, which makes it a good introductory practice for other types of meditation. It can also help to de-automatise some mental processes, for example habits in directing attention.

Open monitoring meditation

The OM practice consists of observing the experiences in the practitioner's mind in an uninvolved way. Depending on the kind of meditation, this can be any experience, or one specific to the kind of meditation performed. This type of observation is continuous, non-responsive and neutral. For instance, the practitioner may experience pain or pleasure, but is encouraged not to analyse them and respond to them (seek them out or try to avoid them). The practitioner is also neutral towards any thoughts that appear during meditation.¹⁶³

Cognitive processes appearing during OM meditation are usually: heightened introspection and awareness of bodily processes, reactions and sensations. The non-responsivity and neutrality characteristic for OM is related to the precortical regulation of limbic reflexes. The lowered activity of the medial prefrontal cortex when stimulated with negative experiences is a third-party confirmation of emotional stability being caused by meditation.¹⁶⁴ An inverse tendency is observed in patients suffering from depression or other emotional disorders prone to brooding.¹⁶⁵

¹⁶² Ibidem.

¹⁶³ A. Lutz et al., *Attention regulation and monitoring in meditation*, 'Trends in Cognitive Sciences', 2008, 12:4, pp. 2–4.

¹⁶⁴ V. A. Taylor et al, op. cit., p. 4.

¹⁶⁵ D. Baumeister et al., *Classical hallucinogens as antidepressants? A review of pharmacodynamics and putative clinical roles*, 'Therapeutic Advances in Psychopharmacology', 2014, 4:4, p. 162.

Nondual awareness meditation

Nondual awareness meditation is characteristic for Tibetan Buddhism and the bon tradition. It consists of re-contextualising experiences through meditative context. Achieving this requires introductory practices (such as FA meditation) which allow the practitioner to calm down their mind enough to be able to recognise the nondual awareness state.¹⁶⁶

Buddhist masters try to explain what is nondual awareness through a metaphor of the mirror. As a moving mirror reflects a changing world, the surface of the mirror itself remains unchanged. The changing world symbolises all experience, while the unchanging surface of the mirror is the nondual state of consciousness, which – according to Tibetan Buddhism philosophy – is the founding of all consciousness.¹⁶⁷ In NDA, the distinction between ‘me’ and ‘not-me’, between ‘inside’ and ‘outside’ disappear, as do other dualist divisions of reality¹⁶⁸. To quote Zen master Dogen,

‘To learn the Buddhist Way is to learn about oneself. To learn about oneself is to forget oneself. To forget oneself is to perceive oneself as all things’.¹⁶⁹

The fundamental neural correlate of NDA is the lowered competition between DMN and TNP.¹⁷⁰ Higher FC between the precuneus and the dorso-lateral prefrontal cortex has also been observed, which is most probably a neural correlate of the subject feeling one with all objects, blurring the lines of their ego and of their self-awareness of such a state. Lower FC between precuneus and right angular gyrus has also been observed. Since both these brain areas are responsible for integrating the sense of space, their lowered FC may be the reason for a sensation of

¹⁶⁶ Z. Josipovic, op. cit., p. 2.

¹⁶⁷ T. Wangyal Rinpoche, *Tybetańska joga snu i śnienia*, Poznań 1999, p. 265.

¹⁶⁸ NDA should not be equalled with proto-consciousness.

¹⁶⁹ W. Fasching, *Consciousness, self-consciousness, and meditation*, ‘Phenomenology and the Cognitive Sciences’, 2008, 7:4, p. 16.

¹⁷⁰ Z. Josipovic et al., op. cit., p. 2.

spinning and expanding which is typical for deep meditation states (or pre-OBE states¹⁷¹).

EXPERIENCES CAUSED BY PSILOCYBIN IN THE LIGHT OF MODERN SCIENTIFIC RESEARCH

Psychedelic experiences caused by psilocybin are primarily: a change in sensory perception, blurred perception of self and of time, and a feeling of unreality. Entheogenic experiences can occur as well, as can mental and motoric excitation, panic attacks, nausea,¹⁷² and intensive autobiographical recollections.¹⁷³

The phenomenology of psychedelic experiences and physiological reactions caused by psilocybin ingestion has been studied and described extensively. Research into neural dynamics of the psychedelic brain state has, on the other hand, been too sparse to allow any final third-party conclusions on the psychedelic experience caused by psilocybin. Some initial insight can, however, be gleaned as to its nature.

1) The first of the key processes for psilocybin causing psychedelic experiences is the agonist stimulation of 5-HT_{2a} and 5-HT_{2c} serotonin receptors in pyramidal neurons. This is confirmed by the fact that supplying a substance which causes antagonist stimulation of these receptors prior to psilocybin ingestion prevents psychedelic experiences. This proves that agonist stimulation is essential for the experience to occur.

It is not the only condition, however, since lisuride, a derivative of LSD, does not cause psychedelic experiences, even though it is a stronger agonist of serotonin receptors. This means that other conditions must be met for psychedelic experiences to occur.¹⁷⁴

¹⁷¹ OBE – out of body experience.

¹⁷² R. L. Carhart-Harris, op. cit., p. 1347.

¹⁷³ R. L. Carhart-Harris, *Implications for psychedelic-assisted psychotherapy: functional magnetic resonance imaging study with psilocybin*, 'The British Journal of Psychiatry', 2012, 200:1, p. 238.

¹⁷⁴ D. Baumeister et al., op. cit., pp. 157–158.

2) Another important neural correlate of the psychedelic experience is the change in FC between the thalamus and cerebral cortex. Thalamus is responsible for filtering experiences which reach the cerebral cortex. In the case of FA, which is often an introductory condition for all other meditative practices, thalamus narrows the field of sensory experience. In the case of psilocybin, the opposite happens: after its ingestion, the thalamic reticular nucleus limits the activity of the thalamus itself through the GABA (gamma-aminobutyric acid) neurotransmitters, which means that sensory stimuli are filtered less, and more of them reach the cerebral cortex. This is in accord with fist-hand accounts, which claim that psychedelic experiences are rich in varied sensory stimuli, often never experienced before by the subject.¹⁷⁵

This information allows for initial conclusions on the differences between the neural correlates of meditative experiences and the 'psilocybin experience'.¹⁷⁶ Meditative experiences start with directing one's own awareness, while psychedelic experience starts with stimulation of the serotonin receptors. In FA meditation thalamus filters more information, while in psilocybin experience it filters less of them.

3) It is speculated that the changes and disturbances in visual perception caused by psilocybin have their neural correlate in spontaneous increase of alpha wave oscillations.¹⁷⁷ This means that psychedelic state causes intensive changes in brain dynamics, causing different oscillation of electric waves in the brain as compared to resting state. In OM, higher gamma synchronisation can be observed, which points to a key difference between the brain process dynamics of the psilocybin experience and the OM meditation.

4) Brain physiology is also changed by psilocybin. While researchers expected a substance known to induce intensive, euphoric experiences to

¹⁷⁵ Ibidem, p. 159.

¹⁷⁶ The words 'psilocybin experience' will be used to mean psychedelic experience caused by application of psilocybin or psilocin.

¹⁷⁷ M. Komater et al., *Activation of Serotonin 2A Receptors Underlies the Psilocybin-Induced Effects on Oscillations, N170 Visual-Evoked Potentials, and Visual Hallucinations*, 'The Journal of Neuroscience', 2013, 33:25, pp. 10544–10551.

cause an influx of blood, the opposite turned out to be true. Blood flow to the brain was lowered, especially the central regions. The biggest changes were observed in the thalamus and anterior and posterior cingulate cortex. Lowered blood flow correlated to the subjective intensity of the psychedelic experience.¹⁷⁸ This means that the strength of the psychedelic experience is related to the lowered FC between the central brain hubs such as medial prefrontal cortex and posterior cingulate cortex.¹⁷⁹ Lowered activity of the central hubs of DMN causes, in this case, new links in neural nets to form, which in turn causes a more varied and chaotic experience where information which is filtered in other cases can reach consciousness.¹⁸⁰ This is probably the neural correlate of the 'broadening awareness' phenomenon characteristic of the psilocybin experience.

It is speculated that the state of excitation is caused by stimulation of serotonin receptors in pyramidal neurons, despite the overall lower blood flow in the brain. Although FC between the central hubs is abnormal in such a case, many smaller structures of varying stability are formed.¹⁸¹ It should be noted that this more elastic state of consciousness is not chaos caused by destruction of normal neural dynamics; scientists talk of a different order emerging in such cases.¹⁸² FC between the neural nets which form during the psilocybin experience are very stable and only formed during it. This means that the brain on psilocybin does not become a random system, but retains some organisational structures, which are different than those of a normal state of consciousness.¹⁸³

The state of synesthesia, characteristic for psychedelic states, is probably a phenomenological derivative of these neural changes. Heightened neural dynamics is shown in accounts of individuals under the influence of

¹⁷⁸ R. L. Carhart-Harris et al., *Neural correlates of the psychedelic state as determined by fMRI studies with psilocybin*, 'Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences of the United States of America', 2012, 109:6, p. 2138.

¹⁷⁹ Ibidem.

¹⁸⁰ G. Petri et al., *Homological scaffolds of brain functional networks*, 'Interface, Journal of the Royal Society', 2014.

¹⁸¹ Ibidem, p. 1, 8.

¹⁸² Ibidem, p. 7.

¹⁸³ Ibidem, p. 7.

psilocybin being less capable of discerning colours, despite experiencing them with greater intensity. During the psilocybin experience more sensory data is received, but its classification and systematic assessment is more difficult.¹⁸⁴

5) An especially important aspect of the neural dynamics of the psilocybin state is the subdued competition between DMN and TPN. Interestingly, this has also been observed in:¹⁸⁵

- a. Schizophrenia¹⁸⁶
- b. Early psychosis¹⁸⁷
- c. Nondual awareness¹⁸⁸
- d. Under influence of sedatives such as propofol. An important distinction between the two states of subdued competition (between DMN and TPN), one caused by propofol and the other by psilocybin, is the fact that propofol ingestion causes lowered FC between the thalamus and the cerebral cortex as well.¹⁸⁹ In the case of psilocybin, the subdued competition between DMN and TPN is coupled with normal, or even heightened FC between those two regions. It means that this link is an important correlate of the psychedelic state. The strength of the FC did not, however, correlate with the intensity of the psychedelic experience, which means that some other factor must be responsible for that.¹⁹⁰

¹⁸⁴ Ibidem, p. 8.

¹⁸⁵ R. L. Carhart-Harris, *Brain Imaging studies with Psilocybin and MDMA*, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CNR4o5JZEi0> [26.12.2014].

¹⁸⁶ R. Salvador et al., *Overall brain connectivity maps show cortico-subcortical abnormalities in schizophrenia*, 'Human Brain Mapping', 2010, 31:12, pp. 2003–2014.

¹⁸⁷ G. Shim et al., *Altered resting-state connectivity in subjects at ultra-high risk for psychosis: an fMRI study*, 'Behavioral and Brain Functions', 2010, 6:58, p. 1, Human Brain Map 11.

¹⁸⁸ Z. Josipovic, op. cit., p.1.

¹⁸⁹ R. L. Carhart-Harris, *Functional connectivity...*, op. cit. p. 1344.

¹⁹⁰ Ibidem, p. 1343, 1347.

COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS OF STATES CAUSED BY PSILOCYBIN AND MEDITATIVE PRACTICE

According to Carhart-Harris, one of chief researchers of neural correlates of altered states of consciousness, lowered correlation between DMN and TPN, as well as general changes in DMN functioning, can be the reason for entheogenic experiences caused by some psychedelics and deep meditation.¹⁹¹ One of the subjects described their psilocybin experience as follows: 'It was quite difficult at times to know where I ended and where I melted into everything around me'.¹⁹² These words illustrate the blurring line between the subject and the object. They describe a much larger number of people who had the psilocybin experience. They also resemble the Buddhist tale of the bell, wherein, to paraphrase Yasutani Roshi, if an individual perceives the sound of a ringing bell as 'I ring', then that individual is enlightened.¹⁹³ Although, of course, such a description of enlightenment is only metaphorical, hinting at the context and in no way exhaustive.

It should also be noted that the resemblance does not mean that the two states are identical, for a few reasons. Firstly, meditation is a controlled process which, once learned, can be repeated numerous times. There is nothing haphazard about it, either, as opposed to the psilocybin experience.¹⁹⁴ Secondly, NDA meditation is an isolated process, not accompanied by other characteristics which appear in the psilocybin experience, such as altered perception etc. Similar in one aspect is far from identical. NDA, psychosis and psilocybin experience are completely different phenomena, as testified by their neural correlates.

As described in detail above, an important distinction between meditation as a whole and psilocybin experience is the difference in thalamus

¹⁹¹ 'Deep meditation' is used here to mean nondual awareness meditation or advanced practices of the classical Indian yoga (i.e. *samādhi*).

¹⁹² R. L. Carhart-Harris, *Functional connectivity...*, op. cit., p. 1350.

¹⁹³ W. Fasching, op. cit., p. 16.

¹⁹⁴ According to the Breakin and Graeff hypothesis, this depends on the way of activating the serotonin receptors and the environmental conditions (set & setting). Cf. Baumeister et al., op cit., p. 160.

functioning, which in the case of meditation filters out more information before submitting it to the cerebral cortex, and in the case of psilocybin influence, less.

Thirdly, according to Buddhist gurus, intensive meditation practice can lead to the NDA state becoming permanent, wherein the practitioner perceives all experience in a nondual way, whether awake, asleep, or in deep sleep.¹⁹⁵ This is important, because the Buddhist state of nirvana is a state of permanent freedom from suffering. A short, entheogenic experience should not be equalled to the state of permanent freedom from suffering and of re-contextualising experiences into nondual mode regardless of the state of consciousness.

Fourthly, exhaustive preparatory practice – personal development and exercising mental discipline - is necessary to reach the NDA state. Meditative practices are a long and slow process which cannot be hastened. Psychedelic substances can be ingested in various contexts, but the lack of limitation on generating entheogenic experiences through this process means that a given state can be achieved without any preparation.

This does not change the fact that similarities between the two states are fascinating and give us a chance to reflect on these alternative states of consciousness. To draw any precise third-party conclusions on the nature of these experiences, however, much more research is needed.

Entheogenic experiences caused by psilocybin are related to religious questions. Stace, in his book *Mysticism and Philosophy*¹⁹⁶ states that the core of religious experience is the feeling of unity.¹⁹⁷ This same feeling of unity can be found in some psychedelic experiences. The analysis presented here shows that, despite many differences between the meditative experience (which many researchers on religion consider to be ‘mystical’)

¹⁹⁵ T. Wangyal Rinpocze, op. cit.

¹⁹⁶ W. T. Stace, *Mysticism and Philosophy*, London, 1961.

¹⁹⁷ This may mean a feeling of being one with God, Divinity, universe, spiritual reality, own soul, own mind etc. The important aspect is blurring the boundaries of ego and the feeling of unity itself.

and the psychedelic experience, the feeling of unity is similar. The religious character of psychedelic experience should not come as a surprise, since the plants containing psilocybin or DMT, like *salvia divinorum*, or decoctions thereof, have been revered in various shamanistic belief systems.

Carhart-Harris says that, to understand psychedelic or mystical experiences, there is no need to reach towards transpersonalism, but only to understand the neural correlates of such phenomena. He also states that understanding a process on a biochemical level does not reduce it in its phenomenological capacity.¹⁹⁸ However, from a philosophical perspective, understanding the neural correlates will not reduce our uncertainty as far as the nature of such phenomena is concerned, since, to paraphrase Searle, a neurobiologist examining brains is studying his own mind.

Psilocybin may be a catalyst that provokes autobiographical memories and enhances them, which brings about speculation about its use in various forms of psychotherapy.¹⁹⁹ Interestingly, during vipassana meditation courses, students are warned they can experience spontaneous memories or visions. These meditation-induced states remain a mystery, however. There is no research on the subject, mostly due to difficulties in methodology: such occurrences are rare and seem to appear randomly, which makes studying them especially difficult.

The word 'psychedelic' comes from *psychē* (Greek for 'mind' or 'soul') and *dēloun* (Greek for 'show, make visible'). This etymology fits Carhart-Harris's research and his meta-reflection on the subject. His opinion is that psychedelic ingestion sends perception back towards earlier, less synthesised and less refined forms of perceiving. This is an important statement, because many psychedelic users claim they open the human mind to 'other dimensions'. Carhart-Harris denies that, claiming that psychedelics move the user 'back' within the mind, rather than 'beyond' the mind. In his opinion, the experience is not transpersonal, but showing

¹⁹⁸ R. L. Carhart-Harris, *Brain Imaging studies with Psilocybin and MDMA*, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CNR4o5JZEi0> [26.12.2014].

¹⁹⁹ R. L. Carhart-Harris, *Implications for...*, op.cit., p. 238.

the mind in its less synthetic, chaotic form. A frequent element of the psychedelic experience is perception of strange, often geometrical shapes, a fact which has a rich history of mystical interpretations. According to Carhart-Harris, these geometrical shapes are related to earlier stages of perception synthesis.²⁰⁰ The world we perceive daily is the highest form of perception synthesis our brain can produce, while psychedelic substances make us notice an earlier stage of this process.

SUMMARY

Based on the considerations above, the following conclusions can be drawn:

The process of meditation leads to isolation of chosen mental processes, and always has a specific goal to which it leads. This can be single-point focus (FA), awareness and neutrality towards some or all experiences (OM), re-contextualising perception into nondual mode (NDA) or suppression of all experience object²⁰¹ (PC – pure consciousness). Regardless of the meditation type, unless it is externally guided meditation, it begins with the glutamic acid activating prefrontal cortex, then the thalamus which controls the sensory information flow.

The psychedelic experience, on the other hand, causes the mind to intensify its sensations. There is no isolation of specific mental states (or any suppression of experience objects at all), but other changes in various spheres of psychic life. A comparison of meditative practices and psilocybin experience shows much more differences than similarities.

This is confirmed by research into neural correlates of the two experiences, where meditation activates (depending on meditation type) areas of the brain that are responsible for directing, keeping and monitoring attention, emotional stability or a change in relation between ‘me’ and

²⁰⁰ R. L. Carhart-Harris, *Brain Imaging studies with Psilocybin and MDMA*, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CNR4o5JZEi0> [26.12.2014].

²⁰¹ According to the classical Indian yoga tradition, all object of experience vanishes in the state of *nirbija samadhi*.

‘not-me.’ The psychedelic state is characterised by other phenomena: stimulation of the serotonin receptors, less filtering of sensory data by the thalamus, lesser blood flow towards the brain, breaking DMN FC, creating new FC between the neural nets inactive in the default mode. The only important similarity between meditation and psilocybin experience occurs in the case of NDA meditation, where in both cases competition between DMN and TPN is lowered and the limits of ego can be obscured. Both meditation and psilocybin can lead to short-term improvement in well-being. The long-term influence of psilocybin on the human psyche has not been sufficiently researched.²⁰² There is research suggesting positive long-term influence of meditative practices.²⁰³

A comparison between the two phenomena depends on their cultural context as well. Meditation as a process of focusing attention is different from meditation in the context of the entire Buddhist system of limiting suffering. Psilocybin ingestion in a nightclub is different from its ingestion during a mountain hike, from a shamanistic ritual, from a psychotherapy session.

Both psychedelics and meditation are a useful tool in scientific research into experiences which are considered mystical.²⁰⁴ Both psychedelics and meditation throw new light on these experiences. Psychedelic substances, with their spontaneity, unpredictability, are as interesting and important from scientific perspective as the possibility of isolating and controlling consciousness processes through meditation.

Scientific research into the field allow better assessment of risks and consequences of such practices, both in the short and long term. They also broaden the field of philosophy and religious studies considering consciousness and its alternative states.

²⁰² Articles from the year 2014 continuously stress the insufficient amount of data for any definitive conclusions. Cf. D. Baumeister et al., op cit., p. 160.

²⁰³ V. A. Taylor et al, op. cit.

²⁰⁴ R. L. Carhart-Harris, *Functional connectivity...*, op.cit., p. 1350.

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***KHECARĪ-MUDRĀ* – A TANTRIC YOGA PRACTICE OF INVOKING MYSTIC STATES OF CONSCIOUSNESS, AS DESCRIBED BY SANSKRIT SOURCES**

The subject of *khecarī-mudrā* is related to substances that held a key role in Indian religions since the dawn of time, or rather since as far back as Vedic literature testifies: the *amṛta*, ‘nectar of immortality’ and *soma*, ‘elixir of life’, the latter being somewhat synonymous to the former. *Soma*, a hallucinogen indispensable for Rigvedic ritual, fell into obscurity at the end of the Vedic period, but re-emerged in a modified form in yoga and tantric practices. There, the *soma* sacrifice became symbolised and internal, libation and ritual objects replaced by physiological functions and mental substitutes. One of the techniques used to perform this internalised sacrifice was *khecarī-mudrā*.

In its currently most popular form, derived from *haṭhayoga*, *khecarī-mudrā* is a body position (*mudrā*) wherein the tongue is rolled inwards and pressed against the soft palate, the uvula, or at the back of the throat. The oldest sources claim it was supposed to bring peace of mind and meditative focus, while newer texts state that it arrests life energy (*bindu/soma-rasa*, which is interpreted to be *amṛta*) inside the body and allows to taste it, and raises *kuṇḍalinī*, thus bringing health, immortality and deep mystical integration.

This article aims to examine what forms the practice of *khecarī-mudrā* took in Sanskrit religious texts, what were their symbolical connotations, and what role was it given in causing mystical, or alternative, states of consciousness.

METHODS OF SHAPING MYSTICAL EXPERIENCE

Khecarī-mudrā is a part of yogic practice, where yoga is considered to be a system of spiritual discipline meant to bring mystical unification. This does not mean that the practice is limited to one tradition. Yoga system developed in two distinct forms, ascetic and non-ascetic, and it was in those varied shapes that it was adapted to various religious traditions. Some forms of yoga, such as the Brahmin's *rāja-yoga*, were more often practiced by ascetes and orthodox practitioners, while the less ascetic forms gave birth to various systems of tantric yoga, and becoming part of *sādhana* for Shaivas, Shaktas, Vaishnavas or Buddhists. The subject of *khecarī-mudrā* appears mostly in tantric texts, and texts that sprung from the ascetic traditions, but show a strong influence of *Kaula* tradition and *haṭhayoga*. The common ground of these currents is to treat the body as an integral part of the *sādhana*, a tool in spiritual practice – with *haṭhayoga* adding the goal of perfecting the body and making it 'godly'.

Tantric mysticism has soteriologic character – it focuses on the ultimate release (*mukti*), preceded by multiple, lesser mystical episodes. According to Manoranjan Basu, 'Mysticism lies in the unfoldment of the physical states of different centres of our being such as willing, thinking and feeling, culminating in the synthetic unity of the self'.²⁰⁵ Thus, mystical experiences are hierarchical: they reflect the adept's progress, and culminate in attaining the status of *jīvan-mukta* – one freed while still alive. This is rarely accidental, it is usually a finale of prolonged effort and not a spontaneous awakening of awareness. The adept generates these states through conscious and methodical application of systematized practices (*sādhana*), which abound in Indian mysticism. These various methods of training the body-mind complex are seen as tools for transforming the consciousness towards a greater end. A characteristic trait of the tantric practice is searching for means of liberation not only via ascetics and introspection, but also 'in the world and through the world'.²⁰⁶ This goal – full integration of the conscious – is attained also through sublimation of emotions and urges. Tantric techniques are both mental and physical,

²⁰⁵ M. Basu, *Fundamentals of the Philosophy of Tantras*, Calcutta 1986, p. 535.

²⁰⁶ M. Jakubczak, M. Sacha-Piekło (eds), *Między wiarą a gnozą*, Kraków 2003, p. 116.

they take form of contemplative exercises, visualizations, ritual cult (*pūjā*) and transgressive ritual practices which aim to break through social and ritual taboos. Tantra also adapts various forms of yoga (*mantrayoga*, *haṭhayoga*, *layayoga* or *rājayoga*), mantras, control and manipulation of life energy through breathing (*prāṇa*), refers to mystical anatomy and physiology, and develops ritualistic, magical tools such as *mudrā*, *yantra* or *maṇḍala*. A vital part of *sādhana* is *kuṇḍalinī*, initially a tantric concept, subsequently adapted to yoga. It is usually visualized as spiritual power (*śakti*), dormant in the first of the six energy nodes (*cakra*²⁰⁷) – one at the base of the spine, *mūlādhāra*. It can be awoken through force of will and gradually raised through a channel (*nāḍī*) called *suṣumnā*,²⁰⁸ aligned with the spine. Thus *kuṇḍalinī* passes the next chakras and arrives at *sahasrāra*, where through the ‘tenth gate’ (*daśama-dvāra*, the fontanel) it can be freed and unite with the universe. This is the state of liberation.

Another characteristic trait of *haṭhayoga* practice is concentrating on the *bindu* (‘drop of consciousness’ or *soma-rasa*, ‘the moon nectar’), which is the immortal element of the life fluid (*semen*). This substance, equated with *soma* the elixir of life, but also *soma* meaning ‘moon’, is meant to be gathered in the body and transformed to achieve immortality. The main practice in *haṭhayoga* is reversing the natural bodily tendencies, meaning retaining *bindu* and storing it in the ‘nectar well’ at the top of the *suṣumnā* (*brahma-randhra*), either through mechanical means (*mudrās*, *bandhas*²⁰⁹ and reversed positions of the body) or through energy manipulation. Initially, this was the *prāṇa*, then *kuṇḍalinī*. Without these efforts, *bindu*, the nature of it being lunar, will flow to the lower portions of the body, where it is burned in solar energetic nodes (*kālāgni*) of the bellybutton and the base of the spine. As long as *bindu* is present in the body, the body will

²⁰⁷ According to tantra, the human body holds six nodes (*cakra*) which are the centers of consciousness, but in practice their number can vary from tradition to tradition because of differing ideas on the subtle body.

²⁰⁸ *Suṣumnā* – the main channel in the subtle human body, ‘leading upwards’, through which the life-breath or the spiritual element of man (soul) moves. It leads from the base chakra (*mūlādhāra*) along the spine to the crown chakra (*sahasrāra*), where the *brahma-randhra* gate ends it.

²⁰⁹ *Mudrā* (‘seal’) and *bandha* (‘closing’) – body gestures through which the life-breath (*prana*) is enclosed in some parts of the body.

not die.²¹⁰ However, *haṭhayogic sādhana* also entails controlling breath and *kuṇḍalinī*, as well as mental discipline, since all these elements are intertwined, or even equivalent.²¹¹ As long as *prāṇa* flows, *bindu* flows with it, and atrophy of both *prāṇa* and *bindu* means death. The mind, its part, follows the air²¹², and thus *yogi* must also immobilize the breath. The whole process, then, means storing *amṛta*, creating a new body and achieving deep yogic integration, *samādhi*.²¹³ The ultimate goal in *haṭha* is attaining the state of Śiva through immortality. This goal differs strongly from that of other yoga practices, which are more mental in nature and consider body training secondary. Liberation is attained while still alive (*jīvan-mukti*), firstly in the perfected body (*siddha-deha*), and then in the divine body (*divya-deha*). Beyond that is the state of *Maheśvara*, i.e. *parā-mukti*.

ETYMOLOGY OF THE NAME

The word is quite an unusual compound noun:²¹⁴ *khe* is the locative case of the word *kha*, which is a synonym of *ākāśa* and translated variously as ‘space’, ‘heaven’, ‘ether’, but also ‘void’, especially inner void or rupture. *Kha* usually refers to the most subtle among the thick material elements (*mahābhūta*), the four other being made from it, but in this context it can also refer to Brahman – absolute. In *haṭhayoga*, and alchemy, *kha* often means the ‘well’ in which the *yogi* gathers *amṛta*. It can also be interpreted to mean *vyoma-cakra* – the energy node related to the ether, the empty space in the skull where the three main arteries of the subtle body are joined. *Carī* is the feminine form of *cara*, ‘the one who moves’. *Khecara*, then, is the one who moves in the space/void, and *khecarī* is the yoga power (*siddhi*) of moving through space.²¹⁵ The word *khecarī* can also mean a goddess, and a class of female yoga practitioners (*yogiṇī*) – per-

²¹⁰ *Dhyānabindūpaniṣad*, 84.

²¹¹ HYP IV. 28.

²¹² HYP IV. 24.

²¹³ D. G. White, *The Alchemical Body*, Chicago 1996, p. 253.

²¹⁴ It is a compound of the *aluk-samāsa* type, in which the grammatical suffix of the first part is retained.

²¹⁵ In alchemy traditions, the word *khecarī* meant literally the ability to fly caused by mercury ingestion.

sonifications of divine, female yogic powers, which refers to the most ancient, basic meaning of this *mudrā*. Metaphysically – especially in tantra – *kha* is the void which is the central, inner form of a divine being. Whoever can move freely in this space of clear divine consciousness is equaled to the divine being. The word *khecara* is used to refer to Śiva himself. According to N. Bhattacharya, *khecari* refers to the ‘kinetic power of the Brahman’.²¹⁶

The word *mudrā* has many meanings, the most basic being ‘seal’, as well as any other object or tool used to seal, imprint and brand. It can mean an impression, picture or sign imprinted upon the consciousness. In religious context, the word *mudrā* means a symbolic gesture, a specific position of the palm or of the whole body, which is used in religious practices of various schools of Hinduism, in Buddhism, and primarily in yoga and tantra. *Mudrās* are an indispensable part of meditation. Practicing *mudrās* can be done on a cosmically-spiritual, bodily-mental and ritual level. In tantra, this is part of the *pañcamākāra* practice, the ‘Five Ms’ practiced in *vāmamārga*, the ‘left-hand way’, which consists of ritual use of impure substances. These are meat (*māṃsa*), fish (*matsya*), alcohol (*madirā*), fried grain or aphrodisiacs (*mudrā*), and sexual practices (*maithuna*). In Buddhist ritual, the word *mudrā* can also mean the sexual partner. The right-hand tantra (*dakṣiṇācāra*) uses material substitutes or mental symbols of these unclean substances, where *mudrā* is a hieratical palm gesture or inner attitude.

Referring to agamic traditions of Śaivism, like J. Singh does,²¹⁷ one can interpret the *mudrā* as:

1. That which gives joy, *mudam (harṣam) rati (dadāti)*,
2. That which frees one from bonds, *mum drāvayati*,
3. That which unifies (seals, confirms) the whole universe with the consciousness (*turīya*²¹⁸), *mudrāyati iti*.

²¹⁶ N. N. Bhattacharyya, *History of the Tantric Religion* (2nd ed.), New Delhi 1999, p. 407.

²¹⁷ J. Singh, *Śiva Sūtras: The Yoga of Supreme Identity*, Delhi 1979, pp. 101–102.

²¹⁸ Ibidem, p. 254.

Thus, *mudrā* is that which allows the adept to self-realize and unite with the divine consciousness. A similar interpretation can be found in *Tantrāloka* (TA, 11th century) by Abhinavagupta: 'Whatever bodily configuration assumes a yogi who has attained the communion with the absolute consciousness (*khecarī-cakra*), only that is to be considered a *mudrā*. Any other bodily posture is nothing more than an unnatural deformation of the body'.²¹⁹

Abhinavagupta lists four kinds of *mudrā* – one performed with the body, with the palms, with words and with the mind – and two ways of using *mudrā* in Śaiva yoga. On one hand, *mudrā* is a way to achieve a desired state of consciousness, on the other it is a spontaneous expression, physical manifestation of this state of consciousness: a reflection of the original image.²²⁰ Thus, *mudrā* is firstly a sign, and through its practice (mimicking), one can achieve the consciousness it represents.²²¹ In this sense, *mudrā* is a bodily practice, used deliberately. This deliberate use of a specific *mudrā* distinguishes it from the *āsana*.

In *haṭhayoga*, *mudrā* contains an element of *bandha*, of retaining the subtle energy in the body. It is therefore a literal seal, an element used by the yogi to seal the nine gates of the body to shut off the external world and focus inward. Stopping breath and closing all the energetic channels except the *suṣumnā*, through which the yogi will raise *prāṇa*, *bindu* and mind towards the *sahasrāra*.

Thus, the term *khecarī-mudrā* means 'a seal used to move through the space/void'. Although some translate it literally, linking the word to various forms of levitation (*khecarī-siddhi*), most texts on *haṭhayoga* use *mudrā* to describe another way of moving through space – raising consciousness/mind (*citta*) and the tongue. *Gorakṣaśataka* interprets *mudrā* as 'the mind moving through the ether (*khe*) as the tongue moves in the void

²¹⁹ TA 32.65: *tadevaṃ khecarīcakraṇūḍhau yadrūpamullaset tadeva mudrā mantavyā śeṣaḥ syāddehavikriyā*. Translations of Sanskrit source texts by the author unless otherwise stated.

²²⁰ P. E. Muller-Ortega: *Seal of Śambhu*, in: D. G. White, *Tantra in practice*, Princeton University Press 2000, p. 578.

²²¹ Ibidem, p. 578.

(*khe*), and for that reason, *khecarī-mudrā* is venerated by all siddhas'.²²² Through 'moving the mind in the void' one can understand focusing the consciousness in the energetic node between the eyebrows (*ājñā-cakra*), while the tongue moving through void can mean its turning and physically placing it in the upper part of the throat, in the center of sky/void (*vyoma-cakra/sūnya*) where it is free from all touch. According to Abhinavagupta, *khecarī-mudrā* is the most important *mudrā* for the consciousness, from which all other *mudrās* originate.²²³ '*Khe brahmaṇi abhedarūpe sthitvā carati [...] iti khecarī – khecarī* is that which moves through the void, though it is placed in the absolute Brahman, stripped of the dualistic union'.²²⁴ The name of this *mudrā* is related to the concept of *khecarī*, fundamental for the *Trika* school of Kashmir Śaivism, and meaning the divine consciousness, the state of Śiva, full integration with the Absolute.

Khecarī-mudrā is, therefore, a specific psychophysical disposition: on one hand, it is a difficult technique of 'tongue swallowing' and tasting the nectar of immortality which flows from the skull of a qualified yogi,²²⁵ and on the other a state of consciousness. It is also called *vyoma-cakra* – 'the circle of heaven' (or 'void'), *nabho-mudrā* – the *mudrā* of space, *lambika-yoga* – yoga of the palate, and, in early texts, as *jihva-bandha* – immobilization of the tongue. Śaiva tantra calls it *divya-mudrā* – divine *mudrā*, or even *śivāvasthā* – state of Śiva.

THE TECHNIQUE

The descriptions of a *mudrā* called *khecarī* vary in Sanskrit texts, and several forms of it could be presented. There is no certainty whether *khecarī-mudrā* must mean one specific practice. These differences may be caused by parallel development in various traditions and various forms of ritual, but it is also possible – though not very probable – that the same name

²²² GS 67 (=HYP 3. 41): *cittaṃ carati khe yasmāṃ jihvā carati khe gatā teneyam. khecarīmudrā sarvasiddhair namaskṛtā.*

²²³ TA 32. 6.

²²⁴ Abhinavagupta, *Paratṛīśikā-vivaraṇa*, Śrinagar 1918, p. 39.

²²⁵ M. Eliade aptly calls the *hathayoga khecarī mudrā* a 'physiological situation'.

was used for different, unrelated practices. Nevertheless, the most probable idea is that the *haṭhayogic* practice is an internalized form of a tantric ritual of *Śākta* traditions (*kaula*), while the form of *mudrā* in Kashmir Śaivism (*trika*) is a transformation of this ritual into a mental process.

These discrepancies can be categorized in several oppositions, following several key aspects:

1. The form – physical (*haṭhayoga*, *kaula*), as opposed to symbolic and mental (tantric rituals of Kashmir Śaivism);
2. Use of the tongue – pressed to the palate or the uvula, as opposed to ‘swallowed’, placed in the throat or the nasal cavity;
3. Move – immobilizing the tongue (*jihva-bandha*), related to *prāṇāyāma*, as opposed to moving it (signified by the *-cara* suffix) to stimulate the *ājñā-cakra* node (sometimes interpreted to be the pineal gland) to stimulate the production of *amṛta*;
4. Preparation – stretching exercises, as opposed to cutting the tongue frenulum;
5. Character – an introduction to the actual practice, as opposed to being the practice itself;
6. The presence of *amṛta* in the body, as opposed to no mentions of it;
7. The goal – consuming *amṛta* and flooding the body with it (*amṛta-plāvana*) to gain health and immortality as well as a state of quasi-intoxication, as opposed to arresting *bindu* (*bindu-dhāraṇa*) and storing the nectar.

Mentions of a *mudrā* resembling *khecarī* can be found in old sources, though it is not described as very important at that stage. It was one of the positions of the body used in meditation. Pressing the tongue against the palate during meditation is an idea that can be found as early as the Pali Canon and in such early Hindu texts as *Viṣṇusmṛti*, *Maitrāyaṇīya Upaniṣad* or *Yogavaśiṣṭha*. There are no mentions of accessing the nectar, however, and mentions of breath control and thus controlling the mind and body can be found instead. *Mudrā* is a physical exercise meant to ready the adept for further, internal practice, bring him into a desired state. *Maitrāyaṇīya*, a relatively young Upanishad, mentions a practice which resembles the yoga *khecarī*, in a fragment about the six steps of

yoga.²²⁶ It describes using breath control and repeating the *om* mantra while immobilizing the tongue, which can be used to raise the energy along the spine.²²⁷ This shows clear influence of tantric physiological ideas, so that fragment can be a later interpolation. There are no mentions of *amṛta*, but the text recommends using this technique to experience the *turiya* state and liberation. The verse VI.20 says:

‘There is the superior fixed attention (*dhāraṇa*) for him, viz. if he presses the tip of the tongue down the palate and restrains voice, mind, and breath, he sees Brahman by discrimination (*tarka*). And when, after the cessation of mind he sees his own Self, smaller than small, and shining, as the Highest Self then having seen his Self as the Self, he becomes Self-less, and because he is Self-less, he is without limit, without cause, absorbed in thought. This is the highest mystery, viz. final liberation’.²²⁸

According to J. Mallinson’s studies of early sources texts on Śākta and Śaiva tantra throw more light on the technique.²²⁹ Its *haṭhayoga* form probably originates in *kaula* rituals: early *Kīraṇatantra* describes raising the breath similarly to the *Maitrāyaṇīya Upaniṣad*. At this stage, Śaiva tantra makes no mention of raising *kuṇḍaliṇī* yet, speaking of raising *prāṇa* instead. The first mention of the tongue being retreated to the back of the throat can be found in a text called *Jayadrathayāmala* (about 9th century). This is where first mentions of nectar secretion and its consumption by the yogi are made as well. *Kaulajñānanirṇaya* by Matsyendranātha (about 9th or 10th century) introduces the idea of cheating death (*kāla-vañcana*) to the description of the practice: thanks to the *mudrā*, the yogi becomes immortal, independent (*svacchandagaḥ*), immune to aging and can see into the past and future. Mentions of seeing to the future can be found in other

²²⁶ *Śad-aṅga-yoga: prāṇāyama, pratyāhāra, dhyāna, dhāraṇā, tarka, samādhi*.

²²⁷ MaiU VI. 18-22.

²²⁸ MaiU VI. 20: *Athānyatrāpyuktam atah parāsya dhāraṇā talurasanāgra-nipīdanādovān-manah prāṇa-nirodhanād brahma tarkeṇa paśyati yadātmanā’tmānamāṇorāṇiyam saṃ dyota-mānam manah-kṣayāt paśyati tadātmanātmānam drṣṭvā nirātmā bhavati nirātmakatvād asaṅkhaḥ yoni-niścityo mokṣa-lakṣaṇam ityetaṃ param rahasyam ityevaṃ hyāha*. Tr by: E. B. Cowell, *Maitri or Maitrāyaṇīya Upanishad*, Bibliotheca Indica 1870.

²²⁹ J. Mallinson, *Khecarīvidyā of Adinātha*, Oxford 2003, pp. 26–37.

texts as well (KV II. 17 and HYP III. 102 for example), as can be fragments about *amṛta*: ‘The wise man who strains the uvula until he reaches the aperture of brahma (*brahmabila*) and with the tip of his tongue drinks the nectar [accumulated there], he defeats death within a month’s time. If he, o Devi, places his tongue at the root of the palate and sips breath very slowly, he will overcome severe bodily conditions in six months’.²³⁰

Interestingly, while *Śākta* texts speak of drinking *amṛta*, and even describe differences in taste, Kashmir Śaivism recommend visualization of bathing the whole body in it, if they mention the nectar at all.

Fragments of another *Śākta* text, the *Kubjikāmatatantra* (about 9th to 10th century) suggest the root of *khecarī-mudrā* to be rituals of possession, a characteristic trait of which is the spontaneous retreat of the tongue behind the palate, a result of altered state of consciousness.²³¹ According to J. Mallison, *mudrā* could have initially aimed to provoke this state through mechanical replication of its effects. Descriptions themselves make no suggestion of spontaneity, however, while the method of gradual cutting of the tongue frenulum – to enable full performance of the *khecarī-mudrā* – is mentioned several times in texts on yoga.

The first use of the term *khecarī-mudrā* to describe tongue-turning can be found in a text on the western cult of *Kubjikā*, called *Kularatnoddyota* (around 12th century). It is the first and most important of the eight *mudrās* described, but the description has more in common with the pre-agamic ones, where holding breath and keeping the body tense is recommended, as opposed to the typically tantric ones which recommend relaxation and breathing freely while the body is inundated with the nectar. Here, the yogi blocks all body orifices and holds breath, placing the tongue at the tip of the uvula to block the inner canal. Keeping the body taut, they turn the face upwards and immobilize the irises, focusing the eyes on the ‘way of the ether’ (*vyoma-mārga*), trying to make the mind rest in the void at

²³⁰ KJN 6.18-19: *prasārya danturāyāntu yāvād brahmvilaṅgataḥ amṛtāgraṃ rasāgreṇa. dahyamānasudhīrapi. māsenā jitayenmṛtyuṃ satyaṃ satyaṃ mahātape rasanātālumūle tu kṛtoā vāyūṃ pibecchanaiḥ.*

²³¹ J. Mallinson, *Khecarīvidyā...*, op. cit., p. 23.

the ‘crossroads of *prāṇa* canals’ (in *brahma-randhra*).²³² There is no mention of placing the tongue above the palate, and no mention of the nectar.

The *Yoginīhr̥daya* (10th or 11th century), which belongs to the *Śrī-vidyā* tradition, describes *khecarī* differently: ‘Born from the unifying interaction of *dharma* and *adharma* in the form of intelligence, she destroys the faults of omission in ritual action resulting from differentiated thought. [This *mudrā*,] the supreme *khecarī*, destroyer of the diseases born from differentiated thought, abides, made of consciousness, in the *sarvarogahāra-cakra*’.²³³

In this verse, *dharma* (literally ‘religion’ or ‘law’) means Śiva, while *adharma*, the opposite of *dharma*, means Śakti. *Mudrā* is their union (*saṃghaṭṭa*). The *mudrās* in this text take the form of hieratical palm movements, symbolic representations of the goddess Tripurasundarī. Another text of the *Śrī-vidyā* school, *Prasūramakalpasūtra*, describes *khecarī* similarly. Since there are no detailed descriptions of the ritual, it is impossible to say whether their form was only symbolic. Kṣemarāja, commenting on *Śiva-sūtra* (2.5), states clearly that as identification with Śiva, *khecarī-mudrā* is not the same as the *mudrā* in *haṭhayoga* textbooks. This one is more aptly described by the passage ‘Only when the consciousness flows in all the beings is a *mudrā* really *khecarī*’.²³⁴ He calls ‘flying in the ether of an awoken consciousness’.²³⁵

The chief theologian of the *Trika* school, Abhinavagupta (10th–11th century), considers *khecarī-mudrā* to be the most important *mudrā* of the consciousness, and others only its variations. But the tongue seems not to have any important part in the practices of this school. *Tantrāloka* does mention a *karaṅkinī* variant in its description of 10 types of *mudrā*,²³⁶ a variant which entails pressing the tongue to the palate (*jihvayā tālukam*

²³² Ibidem, p. 36.

²³³ *Yoginīhr̥daya* 67–68: *dharmādharmaśya saṃghaṭṭād utthitā vittirūpiṇi / vikalpotthakriyāloparūpadoṣa-vighātini // vikalparūparoganānām hāriṇi khecarī parā / sarvarogaharākhye tu cakre saṃvinmayi sthitā //* Tr by: A. Padoux, *The Heart of the Yogini*, p.52.

²³⁴ *Śiva-sūtra-vimarśinī*, II. 5: *carate sarva-jantūnaṃ khecarī nāma sāmṛitā*.

²³⁵ Ibidem, II. 5: *khe bodhagagane caratīti khecarī mudrā*.

²³⁶ Nine types of *khecarī-mudrā* are: *karaṅkinī*, *krodhanā*, *bhairavī*, *lelihānikā*, *mahāpretā*, *yogamudrā*, *jvālīnī*, *kṣobhiṇī*, *dhruvā*. *Tantrāloka* 32.5.

sprśed, TA 32.26), but one mention does not mean that the *mudrā* of *Trika* tradition resembles that of the yoga texts. In Kashmir Shaivism, descriptions of *khecarī-mudrā* are joined by those of a mantra (as well as *cakra*²³⁷) of the same name, since *mudrā* and mantra are physical and sonic representations of a divinity, and cooperate to achieve the effect. *Mudrā* is an action while mantra is a flow of knowledge (*vidyā*). *Khecarī-mudrā* is an important element of the two texts by Abhinavagupta – in *Parātrīṃśika-vivaraṇa* (10th–11th century) and *Tantrāloka*, which are the only texts to describe it in its typically tantric, *Śaiva* form.

The element of *kha* is interpreted as the inner space, the central void of the consciousness, and therefore the heart. On this interpretation, the *mudrā* practice is based, the heart being a central element of the refined *Trika* system. *Khecarī-mudrā* is a complicated, mental and physical attitude which can bring about the presence of a divinity and unite it with the adept. The highest state of consciousness a yogi can attain is *khecaratā* – the state of being *khecara*, ‘moving through the void of the consciousness’. This state is called *śivāvasthā*, being one with Śiva, and is characterised by absence of all discursive thought. In this state, all mystical powers (*śakti*) manifest in the yogi. According to P. Muller-Ortega, *kha*, despite meaning ‘void’, is ‘full’ in this practice, because it is the matrix of creation (*mātrkā*), the secret cave (*guha*) of the heart, the mysterious opening (*yoni*) in the body of the Goddess who births the world. *Sādhaka* wants to return to the powerful source of creation, and when they do, their immense spiritual accomplishment is called *khecarī-mudrā*.²³⁸ J. Dupuche writes on this form of *mudrā*:

‘Just as cognition is the basis of recognition, so too the person who attains (*cari*) the illimitation of space (*kha*) brings about the presence of many *saktis*. In *khecarī-mudrā* the practitioner attains the space of pure consciousness so that the goddesses arise before him. He enjoys them and secures all

²³⁷ *Cakra* – ‘circle’ interpreted here as ‘couple’ – a feminine and masculine element, Śakti and Śiva, Moon and Sun.

²³⁸ P. E. Muller-Ortega, *The Triadic Heart of Shiva*, New York 1989, p. 143.

their powers' and has no need of other ritual obligations (*niracara*). This state is *khecarīmudrā*'.²³⁹

Trika Śaivism uses an array of methods meant to provoke mystic experiences. It mentions four main methods of attaining the *śivāvasthā* state: the anti-method (*nirupāya/anupāya*), the Śambhu method (*śambhavopāya*), the Śakti method and the individual method (*āṇavopāya*). Although each method has the power to invoke the state of Śiva, the three 'attitudes' (*mudrā*) which are in themselves traits of the state, are useful: *bhairavī-mudrā*, *krama-mudrā* and *khecarī-mudrā*.²⁴⁰ To that last *mudrā*, chapter 29 and part of chapter 32 of *Tantrāloka* are devoted. The system of the *Trika* school is very complex, however, and the language of the text too nebulous to determine the exact form of the *mudrā* with any exactitude. TA 32.20-24 shows its effect indirectly:

'Free, not attached to any ritual (*nirācāro*), without doubt (*niḥśaṅko*), free of worldly concerns, pure (*avadhūto*), not attached to any ritual, reflecting that "I am not" (*nāham asmi*), relying solely on the mantra, viewing all the goddesses who reside in his body, always seeing (*paśyan*) these things as the perceiving subject, he is clearly made perfect by means of *khecarī-mudrā*'.²⁴¹

Abhinavagupta mentions *khecarī* elsewhere, in the symbolic language typical for him, using the analogy of the sexual union. The adept who, through recitative practice became one with the mantra, now copulates with the *śakti* so that together they create a six-rayed *mudrā*, recreated as the phoneme <ai>. In this union with *śakti* the adept attains the state of *khecarī-mudrā*. Abhinavagupta follows the tantric depictions of *maṇḍala*, describing the sexual organs of a man and a woman, then their union, divided into three phases: firstly the contact between the organs, then secretion of sexual fluids male and female – the moon and the sun – and

²³⁹ J. R. Dupuche, *Abhinavagupta: The Kaula Ritual as Elaborated in Chapter 29 of The Tantrāloka*, Delhi 2003, p. 66.

²⁴⁰ Ibidem, p. 79.

²⁴¹ TA 32.20 cd - 24 ab. Cited from: J. R. Dupuche, op. cit, p.11.

then their mixing. From this ritual, fire is formed and its ‘emanation’ occurs (TA 29.150-153):

‘As stated in the *Yogasamcāra*, such a union is the supreme attitude, cherished by the yogini. A [three-petalled] lotus sits hidden in an ever-unfolding circle resting inside a triangle. [In the middle] of this lotus and inseparable from it, resides a stem whose strong root is adorned with a sixteen-petalled lotus flower. The shoot is emitted [on three conditions]: 1. Owing to the successive frictions of the two lotuses strung on the stem standing upright in the center. 2. Owing to the union of ovum and sperm In the three petalled lotus. 3. Owing to the unitive friction in fire (the Subject) of the energy waves of the fully resplendent rays of the sun and the moon. And this shoot is creation itself’.²⁴²

This description of a sexual act can be read into on different levels. According to J. Dupuche, it can mean conceiving a child, but also creating the whole world, called ‘the fourth’ (*turiya*). On another level, it can mean the union of the instrument of cognition with the object of cognition. The couple during the sexual act clearly symbolizes Śiva and Śakti (the static consciousness and the dynamic capacity of consciousness), or the mutual dependence of mantra and *mudrā* during ritual union, which leads to a higher state of consciousness, a spiritual sound. This is mentioned in the following stanzas of the 29th chapter of TA. The text, similarly to other sources on Kashmir Śaivism, does not mention the nectar at all in relation to *khecari-mudrā*, and the few mentions of the tongue are related to preparing the body for meditation. However, both *Tantrāloka*, and *Yoginī-hṛdaya* stress the importance of initiation and the right methods of propagating *mudrā* and mantra in *khecari*. It is probable that in some tradition that used this technique during initiation, a literal transfer of substance took place – the guru, having filled his mouth with the nectar that flowed from his own *śaṅkhinī-nāḍi*, transferred it directly to the adept’s mouth.

²⁴² TA 29. 150–153. Trans. by L. Silburn, *Kuṇḍalinī: Energy of the Depths*, New York 1988, pp. 198.

There are mentions of the guru opening a channel leading to liberation in the adept's body.²⁴³

Despite quite frequent mentions of *mudrā*, tantric texts rarely describe placing the tongue in the throat or the nasal cavity. It can therefore be surmised that the form of *mudrā* known today originates in yoga and not tantra. In the earliest texts strictly on *haṭhayoga* (*Dattātreyayogasāstra* from the 13th century, *Amṛtasiddhi* 11th century, *Gorakṣasamhitā*) the practice meant raising *bindu* and keeping it in 'the moon' (*brahma-randhra*), then in raising the life breath or *kuṇḍalinī*, thus liberating the *sādhaka* from death. It is only in the later sources that mentions appear of the 'nectar well' that the yogi can drink from. *Śivasamhitā* (15th century) IV. 31-32:

'A learned yogi, having seated himself in the *padmāsana* posture in the place free from all disturbances, should fix his gaze between the eyebrows and with his tongue reversed he should make effort to reach the well of nectar situated in the cave above the palate. This *mudrā* has been described [by me] on the request of my devotees. My Dearest, know that this is a *mudrā* of all siddhis (yogic powers). One who by continuous practice drinks this nectar daily, attains *vigraha-siddhi* (bodily perfection) [and conquers death] just as a lion defeats an elephant of death'.²⁴⁴

The most detailed description of the *mudrā* appears in *Khecarīvidyā* by Adinātha (around 14th century), which – apart from its short Part Four, devoted to the medicine and herbs used in yoga – dwells in its entirety on the subject of *khecarī-mudrā* and mantra. The *Haṭhayogapradīpikā* (HYP, 15th century),²⁴⁵ the chief *haṭhayoga* text and a compilation of earlier ones,

²⁴³ D. G. White, *The Alchemical...* op. cit., p. 257.

²⁴⁴ Śivasamhitā IV.31-32: *bhruvorantargatām dṛṣṭīm vidhāya sudṛḍhām sudhīḥ upaviśyāsane vajre nānopadravavarjitaḥ // lambikordhvaṃ sthite garte rasanām viparītagām saṃyojayetprayatnena sudhākūpe vicakṣaṇaḥ mudrāiśā khecarī proktā bhaktānāmanurodhataḥ // siddhinām janani hyeśā mama prāṇādhikapriyā niranantarakṛtābhyāsātpīyūṣaṃ pratyaham pibet tena vīgrahasiddhiḥ syānmṛtyumātāṅgakesarī //*

²⁴⁵ HYP I. 43, III. 6-7, III. 32-54, IV. 43-54.

considers *khecarī* to be the most important of the ten *mudrās* presented,²⁴⁶ the purpose of which is to defeat aging and death: ‘There is no *āsana* that can match the *siddhāsana*, no *kumbhaka* as good as *kevala*, there is no other *mudrā* to rival *khecarī*, and no *laya* that can be compared with *nāda*’.²⁴⁷ This idea is touched upon in *Gheraṇḍa-saṃhitā* (17th century) as well, and in the most orthodox of the sources cited – *Yoga Upanishads*²⁴⁸. The *Yogakuṇḍali Upaniṣad* (about 16th century) devotes its Chapter Two almost entirely to *khecarī-mudrā* (II 15-49), although the text is an assortment of quotes from *Khecarīvidyā*. Another, a *Vaiṣṇava Śāṇḍilya Upaniṣad*, mentions the *mudrā* when dwelling on yoga and knowledge (*jñāna*), as two methods of attaining the *kaivalya/samādhi* state. After describing the power of *kuṇḍalinī*, the main channels of *nāḍi*, *chakras* and *prāṇa*, it mentions the *śakti* located at the tip of the tongue. (I. 60): ‘When he, while fixing his gaze between the eyebrows, inserts his reversed tongue in the hollow of the skull, after having lengthened it by means of cutting, stretching and massaging (milk-ing), he assumes the posture known as *khecarī-mudrā*. When both the tongue and the consciousness roams in the void, the person with his tongue thus raised becomes immortal’.²⁴⁹

In further parts of *Śāṇḍilya* (I. 72), *samādhi* attained through the practice is defined as an union of the individual ‘I’ (*jīvātman*) with the supreme ‘I’ (*paramātman*), free from the triple division (the knower, that which is known, and knowledge). Its nature is that of extreme happiness and clear consciousness.

In its strictly *haṭhayogic* form, the *mudrā* entails placing the tongue in the space behind the nose and mouth. The tongue is pressed into the throat and stays there, in a reversed position, the tip reaching the nasal cavity. Eyes are directed upwards, focused on the point between the eyebrows.

²⁴⁶ The ten *mudrās*: *mahāmudrā*, *mahābandha*, *mahāvedha*, *khecharī*, *uḍḍiyāna-bandha*, *mūla-bandha*, *jālandhara-bandha*, *viparītakaraṇī*, *vajroli*, and *śakti-chālana*. HYP III. 6-7.

²⁴⁷ HYP I. 45: *nāsanam siddha-saḍṣaṃ na kumbhaḥ kevalopamaḥ na khecharī-samā mudrā na nāda-saḍṣo layaḥ*.

²⁴⁸ *Yoga Upanishads* that describe *khecarī-mudrā* are: *Dhyānabindūpaniṣad*, *Yogakuṇḍaliyupaniṣad*, *Yogacūḍāmaṇyupaniṣad*, *Yogatattvopaniṣad* and *Śāṇḍilyopaniṣad*.

²⁴⁹ *Śāṇḍilya Upaniṣad* I. 60: *chedanacālanadāhaiḥ phalaṃ parāṃ jihvāṃ kṛtvā dṛiṣṭiṃ bhrūmadhye sthāpya kapālakuhare jihvā viparītagā / yadā bhavati tadā khecharī mudrā jāyate / jihvā chittaṃ ca khe carati tenordhvajihvaḥ pumānamṛito bhavati*.

Because the tongue is the main tool of the *mudrā*, it has to be prepared accordingly. Both HYP and *Śāṇḍilya* recommend preparation through stretching, elongating with metal tongs and massage (similarly to massaging cows while milking) to avoid discomfort while practicing the *mudrā*; a more invasive method is also recommended, that of cutting the frenulum (*śirās*) which binds the tongue. This procedure is gradual, in twenty-six small, subsequent cuts. The whole process is to take six months, since a week must pass between the cuts. After that procedure, the yogi can place the tongue in the nasal cavity without difficulty.²⁵⁰

What is the goal of this? Right below the *sahasrāra*, *suṣumnā* branches off in two channels. The part that curves left links *sahasrāra* with the void above the palate (*kha*, *vyoma*), called *śāṅkhinī* in yoga physiology. It has two ‘mouths’, upper and lower, closing the channel on both sides. The lower mouth from where the nectar flows downwards the body to be burned, is called the ‘tenth gate’ (*daśama-dvāra*). This gate must be closed to prevent the nectar from draining, bringing about death. *Khecarī-mudrā* is the main method of closing it. The upturned tongue reaches the lower mouth of *śāṅkhinī* and seals it. It also allows the yogi to drink *amṛta*. Some sources recommend stimulating the pineal gland (*ājñā-cakra*) with the tongue to cause *amṛta* secretion.

It may be worth noting that *haṭhayogic* texts are somewhat inconsistent on the goal of *khecarī-mudrā*, most probably because of the influences of *Kaula* tantrism. In *Kaula* texts, *kuṇḍalinī*, having reached the well of *amṛta*, opens access to it, and upon returning to the *mūlādhāra* chakra flows the body with nectar (*amṛta-plāvana*). There are mentions of consuming it, as well, which is consistent with the character of *Śākta* tantra – the *sādhaka* uses *amṛta* for a specific goal. In those currents concentrated on *bindu* and literal immortality, that substance should stay in the yogi's head instead (*bindu-dhāraṇa*), since the body is immortal as long as the substance is present there. However, some texts – like *Vivekamārtaṇḍa* or HYP – take a synthesis approach and recommend both variants. HYP reads: ‘On the top of the *merû* (vertebral column), concealed in a hole, is the *soma-rasa* (nectar of Chandra); the wise, whose intellect is not overpowered by *raja*

²⁵⁰ HYP III. 33–37.

and *tama guṇas*, but in whom *sattva guṇa* is predominant, say there is the (universal spirit) *âtma* in it. It is the source of the down-going *idâ*, *pingalâ* and *suṣumnâ nâdis*, which are the Ganges, the Yamuna and the Sarasvatî. From that Chandra is shed the essence of the body which causes death of men. It should, therefore, be stopped from shedding. This (*khecari mudrâ*) is a very good instrument for this purpose. There is no other means of achieving this end'.²⁵¹

While an earlier passage of the same text reads: 'One who, with his face turned upwards and his tongue closing the aperture at the root of the palate, contemplates *kuṇḍalinî* and sips the pure nectar falling from the moon to the sixteen-petalled lotus [of heart] due to movements of *prâṇa*, that yogi lives a long life free from all diseases in a beautiful and soft body resembling the stalk of a lotus'.²⁵²

MYSTICAL STATES CONNECTED TO THE KHECARÎ-MUDRÂ TECHNIQUE

Early texts seem to link the *mudrâ* mostly to meditation technique – a right position of the tongue aids in focusing the mind, controlling the body, speech and thought, since it regulates the flow of *prâṇa* and closes ('seals') all the bodily gates through which the yogi can be connected to the outside world. Its connection to experiences of the Absolute is thus rather indirect. Texts of *Śākta* tantra connect the *mudrâ* with states of possession by the female *Śakti*, goddesses thanks to whom the *sādhaka* obtains supernatural powers, but also access to *amṛta*, which makes man equal to gods. Its consumption is linked to the state of bliss called *ānanda*. In the *Śākta* approach the dualist character of their path is evident, as they strive for liberation, but also for pleasure (*bhoga*), thus the experience of tasting

²⁵¹ HYP III.52: *yatprāleyaṃ prahitasuṣīraṃ merumūrdhāṃtarasthaṃ tasmimstattoṃ pravadatai sudhīstanmukhaṃ nimnagānām / caṃdrātsāraḥ sravati vapuṣastena mṛtyurnarāṇām. tadbadhniyātsukaraṇam aho nānyathā kāyasiddhiḥ*. Translation by : Hatha Yoga Pradīpika, trans. by Pancham Sinh, 1914, p.51.

²⁵² HYP III.51: *mūrdhnaḥ ṣoḍaśapatrapadmagalitāṃ prāṇādāvāptaṃ haṭhādūrdhvaśyo rasanām niyāmya vīcare śaktiṃ parāṃ cīmtayan / utkallolakalājalāṃ ca vimalāṃ dhārāmayāṃ yaḥ pibennirvyādhiḥ sa mṛṇālakomalavapuryogī ciraṃ jīvati*.

amṛta is compared to alcohol inebriation. A symbolic comparison between the nectar and wine can also be found in HYP:

‘The yogi who constantly eats cow’s flesh and drinks *amaravāruṇī* (wine of immortality) is regarded by me a person belonging to a noble family. Others are just a disgrace to their kin. The word “go” (cow) means “tongue”; “eating cow’s flesh” refers to inserting the tongue in the cavity above the palate, which destroys all great sins. “*Amaravāruṇī*” is the nectar that drips from the “moon”. It is produced by the heat generated by tongue being thrust into the cavum’.²⁵³

Texts on Kashmir Śaivism see *khecarī-mudrā* as much more important for ritual: it becomes the crucial *mudrā*, the one that represents and calls the highest state of consciousness, called *turiya*, or the state of *khecarī* (*khecarī-samatā*). TA 29.153-154:

‘He suddenly becomes rooted in the Fourth state who, by means of this *mudrā* wherein moon, sun and fire coalesce, internally takes hold of the processes of emission, resorption. He is indeed as if “sealed” (*mud*); such a *mudrā* is called “*khecarī*” which roams in the ether of ultimate Consciousness (*kha*) and which, associated with Siva and the energy, assumes the form of the eightfold wheel’.²⁵⁴

Haṭhayoga, in its interpretation of the *mudrā*, focuses on immortality and gaining supernatural powers, longevity and health. HYP mentions transformation of consciousness into the *unmanī-avasthā* and *turiya* states, as well:

‘[...] By the practice of *khecarī* one enters the state of *unmanī-avasthā*. Śiva resides between the eyebrows – it is the place

²⁵³ HYP III.47-49: *gomāṃsaṃ bhakṣayaṇ nityaṃ pibed amaravāruṇīm kulīnaṃ tamahaṃ manye itare kulaghātakāḥ // gośabdenoditā jīhvā tatpraveśo hi tāluni gomāṃsabhakṣaṇaṃ tattu mahāpātaka-nāśanam // jīhvāpraveśa-saṃbhūta-vahninotpāditaḥ khalu caṃdrātsravati yaḥ sāraḥ sa syādamaravāruṇī*.

²⁵⁴ TA 29.153-154. Cited from: L. Silburn, op. cit., p. 200.

where mind melts. This state is to be known as “the fourth” (*turya*) where time has no access. One should practice *khecarī-mudrā* until he reaches *yoga-nidrā*, as for those who experience this dream there is no death. Depriving the mind of its basis one should think of nothing at all, but just sit [in void], unimpressed, just as a pot surrounded and filled with ether’.²⁵⁵

Gheraṇḍasaṃhitā links *khecarī-mudrā* to the *samādhi*: ‘[the body] becomes beautiful; *samādhi* is easily achieved, and the tongue through contact with the holes in the cranium obtains various juices’.²⁵⁶

To summarize, the altered states of consciousness that the *khecarī-mudrā* technique can lead to according to the examined texts, are as follows:

Bhoga (pleasure of a *bhoga* category) – a state of bliss similar to inebriation with wine (*madya*). In *Kaula* sources, the fragments that praised *madya* were changed to praise *khecarī* instead. A comparison with wine appears in *hathayoga* as well (HYP). *Amṛta* is called *amaravāruṇī*, ‘wine of the immortals’ and, together with the tongue, they are the yoga equivalents of alcohol and meat (*māṃsa*) consumed in a tantric ritual. This symbolic comparison expresses the situation of the yogi who, by transgressing the most important prohibitions of Hinduism, is free from bonds, and through consuming the heavenly nectar participates in transcendence directly. The closing of *cavum* by the tongue and arresting breath can be complemented by a sexual practice.

Siddhi – obtaining supernatural powers, including physical and material ones: reducing wrinkles or gray hair, levitation, obtaining the body that resembles a diamond (*vajrakāya*), materialising objects, ability to meditate

²⁵⁵ HYP IV.48-50: *bhruvormadhye śivasthānaṃ manastatra vilīyate jñātavyaṃ tatpadaṃ turyaṃ tatra kālo na vidyate // abhyaset khecarīm tāvadyāvatsyādyoganidritaṃ saṃprāptayoganidrasya kālo nāsti kadācana // nirālambaṃ manaḥ kṛtvā na kiṃcidapi cīṃtayet sabāhyābhyāmtare vyomni ghaṭavattiṣṭhati dhruvam.*

²⁵⁶ *Gheraṇḍasaṃhitā* III. 30: *lāvanyañca bhavedgatre samādhir jāyate dhruvam kapāla-vaktra-samyoge rasam apnuyāt.*

for days on end, divine insight, cheating death (*kālavañcana*), yogic suicide (*utkrānti*), entering the body of another person (*parakāyapraveśa*), or leaving the body to avoid death. According to *Khecarīvidyā* after five months of drinking the *amṛta*, adept is able see the three worlds, in sixth month he becomes liberated, and in eighth month he attains communion with gods.²⁵⁷ The most important of those, *khecarī-siddhi*, is the ability to ‘move in the void of the consciousness’. In other words, *yogin* becomes an ethereal being (*khecaratvam avāpnoti*)²⁵⁸.

The state of deep meditation – caused by arresting the breath (*kumbhaka*) and immobilising the tongue (*jihva-bandha*). This closing of air circulation is meant to give the yogi a special kind of focus and to awaken the dormant powers of *kuṇḍalinī*.²⁵⁹ Sometimes *kumbhaka* is called *khecarī-bandhana*.

Ānanda (or *jagadānanda* according to Abhinavagupta) - the state of ‘pure happiness’, ecstatic spiritual bliss caused by contact with sacrum. Described in *haṭhayogic* texts and *Kaula* tantra as the effect of consuming *amṛta*. When the nectar flows from the *sahasrāra* chakra onto the tongue, the yogi becomes ecstatic.²⁶⁰

Turiya/turiyātita – ‘the fourth state’ or ‘the state above fourth’ – the highest state of consciousness known to man, described as early as the Upanishads. In the context of *khecarī* described by *Maitri*, *Śaṇḍilya*, *Dattatrayayogaśāstra* and HYP. A type of mystical experience in *Śaiva* (*śaiva-āgama*) or *Vaiṣṇava* (*advaita*, *viśiṣṭādvaita*, *gauḍīya* etc.) traditions. In this state, the ‘I’ - enlightened consciousness – perceives the Supreme directly.²⁶¹

²⁵⁷ *Khecarīvidyā* II.11-17.

²⁵⁸ *Khecarīvidyā* I.74-75.

²⁵⁹ See: M. Eliade, *Yoga Immortality and Freedom*, p. 260.

²⁶⁰ K. A. Harper, R. L. Brown (eds), *The Roots of Tantra*, New York 2002, p. 239.

²⁶¹ D. Goodall, M. Rastelli (eds), *Tāntrikābhidhānaśa: A dictionary of technical terms from Hindu tantric literature III*, Vienna 2013, definition of: *turiya/turiya*.

Samādhi – the state of deep yoga integration, the peak mystic experience, also called enstasy (the opposite of ecstasy, ‘mystical excitation’), ‘standing inside’ in the sense of being inside one’s true form. This state is characterized by deep focus and silence, curtailing all activity through suppressing the senses and mind. In classical yoga, this is the *samādhi* without seed (*nirbīja-samādhi*), total dissipation in cosmic consciousness without retaining the individual consciousness; in tantric forms of yoga, this is *samādhi* with seed (*śabīja-samādhi*), the state of highest consciousness, tinted with self-awareness and the awareness of the divine nature of the conscious,²⁶² synonymous to *turīya*.

Yoga-nidrā - yoga lucid dreaming, equal to *turīya*. Described as an effect of *khecarī* in HYP and *Śaṇḍilyopaniṣad*.

Khecarī-sāmya/khecarī-samatā – a synonym for ‘the state of Śiva’, the highest state of consciousness which suppresses all discursive thought (*Trika* school, *Śrī-vidyā*).

Śivāvasthā – the state of Śiva or the state, the ‘interfusion’ of individual consciousness with the absolute consciousness, until they integrate and the lower one is transformed into the higher. In the context of *khecarī* described by *Parātrīṃśikā-vivaraṇa* (*trika*).

Yoginī-melana/melaka – ‘the meeting with *Śakti*’, a source of knowledge, supernatural powers and *samādhi*. It is a state of union with *yoginī*, described in *kaula* (TA 28.373-380) and *haṭhayoga* (*Khecarīvidyā* I. 5-13) texts. It can be interpreted on various levels: on the lowest level, as an act of intercourse of *sādhaka* with a female partner (*dūtī*) representing *Śakti*, on the highest level as *samādhi*.

Unmanī-bhāva/avasthā – ‘the absence of mind’, a state synonymous to *turīya*. Described as the effect of *mudrā* in *haṭhayoga* texts such as HYP (IV. 38-39, 47-51), *Śaṇḍilya* (II.18) and *Maitrī* (VI. 34). *Nāḍabindu-upaniṣad* (53-54) calls it the state in which the yogi is as if dead, like a piece of wood:

²⁶² M. Jakubczak, M. Sacha-Piekło (eds), op. cit., p. 145

feels neither heat nor cold, neither joy nor pain. He does not hear any sound either, because he transcends even mystical hearing.

Regardless of the specific form that *khecarī-mudrā* takes in religious literature of the ancient India, it has an important role in provoking mystical experiences. All techniques of yoga and tantra are meant to lead the adept to deep experiences that the subject considers contact with the Absolute, but *khecarī-mudrā* seems to hold a special place among those. It is related to *amṛta* and gaining immortality through its consumption, which in itself is a state of spiritual bliss (*ānanda*), transforming the consciousness into a higher level, and related to *soma*, the life fluid through which man can come into contact with the Absolute. In addition to this, the texts link it directly with mystical states and their culmination – final liberation.

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HYPNOSIS – AN EXAMPLE OF CONTROVERSY AROUND ALTERED STATES OF CONSCIOUSNESS

The term ‘altered states of consciousness’ has become popular in the second half of the 20th century, and it seems to have been integrated into pop-culture. This, in turn, had built a specific image of the phenomenon, usually related to psychedelic substances, religious practices or various self-improvement techniques. The same term, used in academic discourse, has a much more complicated and less obvious meaning. Research on the subject had long been marginalised, partly because of these pop-culture connotations, and partly because of the unclear scientific status of the very idea of consciousness. For these reasons, before a definition of an altered state of consciousness can be attempted and any controversy on the subject discussed, it seems necessary to focus on the superior phenomenon.

NORMAL STATE OF CONSCIOUSNESS

An effective research into the subject of consciousness seems to be one of the bigger challenges faced by modern science. It seems to be hampered by a multitude of ideas on the nature of consciousness itself, its characteristic traits, functions or symptoms that could determine it. On one side, it seems obvious that every human being knows what consciousness is, or rather knows what it is like to be conscious. This popular understanding of consciousness and its obvious nature (at least for one possessed of this consciousness), as well as the lack of indisputable signs of its presence, have placed this aspect of human experience on the edges of scientific inquiry. The scientific attempts to describe the subject, performed in the early nineties, have, on the other hand, resulted in a very different image of consciousness. Not only was it not obvious at all, but it caused

various difficulties when it came to a precise definition, as well as choosing appropriate research methods.

Despite 25 years of scientific research, using self-description, behavioural measures and neuroimaging, there is no consensus as to what consciousness actually is. According to numerous philosophers, the distinctive trait of a conscious state is subjective experience²⁶³ related to specific qualities (qualia – for instance, the redness of an apple) which appear in the human mind. These sensations are only accessible to the subject experiencing them, which is often used as an argument on the impossibility of objective research on consciousness. This is related to the other proposed characteristic of consciousness, which is the sensation of being the subject of an experience (Thomas Nagel says that being conscious means knowing one is oneself, or human²⁶⁴). There also exist behavioural definitions, such as Searle’s famous one: ‘By “consciousness” I mean those states of sentience or awareness that typically begin when we wake up in the morning from a dreamless sleep and continue throughout the day until we fall asleep again’.²⁶⁵ And even though this seems too broad an approach, it suggests the existence of objective symptoms of consciousness, not only one’s own, but also that of others.

Modern science, picking up the subject, had to let go of the subjective consciousness idea – the idea of consciousness being only accessible through first-person, subjective experiences – and to form experimental paradigms that could shed some light on the matter through objective determinates.²⁶⁶ One of the possible sources of such knowledge is behaviourist research, studying the correctness, speed or relevance of reactions to various stimuli. This research assumes that subjects consciously perceiving the stimulus will react to it differently than those not perceiving it. Neuroimaging methods have also been growing in popularity; these,

²⁶³ D. J. Chalmers, *Facing up to the problem of consciousness*, ‘Journal of Consciousness Studies’, 1995, 2:3, pp. 200–219.

²⁶⁴ T. Nagel, *What is it like to be a bat?*, ‘The Philosophical Review’, 1974, pp. 435–450.

²⁶⁵ J. R. Searle, *Mind, Language and Society: Philosophy in the Real World*, New York 1995, pp. 40–41.

²⁶⁶ A. K. Seth, Z. Dienes, A. Cleeremans, M. Overgaard, L. Pessoa, *Measuring consciousness: relating behavioural and neurophysiological approaches*, ‘Trends in Cognitive Sciences’, 2008, 12:8, pp. 314–321.

on their part, assume that consciousness is a result of specific functioning of the nervous system and as such will produce different activity pattern than unconscious states.

This objectivisation of research methods does not mean that the subjective has been neglected. Many tools of psychology have been based on subjective relations of personal experiences; though it may be difficult to generalise and create a coherent set of verifiable hypotheses (Wundt's attempt at using introspection to study the mind may be an example here). Modern use of subjective data is mostly limited to reports of a subjective experience having occurred, or to ratings of its aspects on various scales of subjective experiences.²⁶⁷ Structuralised interviews can also be used to manage quantity research without limiting the subjects to, for instance, descriptive categories. It also seems that simultaneous use of objective and subjective measures could result in much more effective experimental procedures.

ALTERED STATE OF CONSCIOUSNESS

Despite these theoretical and methodological difficulties facing researchers on the subject of consciousness, the substances, practices and afflictions classified as relating to altered states of consciousness have become very popular. However, this term does not refer to any precise theory of consciousness, and seems mostly based on its popular understanding and on human capability of experiencing consciousness. The key element of this new class of phenomena is its 'alternative' or 'different' character – thus reuniting all states, even those drastically different from one another, under the umbrella term, since every one of these states is supposed to differ strongly from 'normal' consciousness. This definition, being very inclusive, makes it – paradoxically – more difficult to classify experiences as 'alternative' or otherwise. It is difficult to determine a specific aspect whose manifestation would guarantee the alternative-ness of a given state. It's easy to define the states caused by psychedelic intake,

²⁶⁷ Cf. M. Wierzchoń, B. Paulewicz, D. Asanowicz, B. Timmermans, A. Cleeremans, *Different subjective awareness measures demonstrate the influence of visual identification on perceptual awareness ratings*. 'Consciousness and Cognition', 2014, 27, pp. 109–120.

lucid dreaming or rhythmic trance. But what about those subtle changes in our consciousness caused by, for example, strong emotions, drowsiness or exhaustion? One solution would be to define the 'alternative' state as one that is not commonplace, that happens only in specific circumstances or to a small group of people. Still, a need remains for a criterion that would differentiate between the truly uncommon states from those that, while different from typical awareness, are not an altered state of consciousness.

Researchers of altered states of consciousness seem to have similar problems in creating a clear definition as their counterparts working on the subject of 'normal' consciousness. Therefore, they reach for similar solutions, such as references to subjective impression, seeing as 'alternative' that which differs from the usual pattern of experience as observed by the subject.²⁶⁸ This approach seems too inclusive, however: using this definition, one could classify every new experience, a change in reasoning or a new perspective of stimuli organisation, as such. What's more, Kihlstrom proposes to objectivise the subjective, seeing it as a method of organising one's experiences, without referring to the active influence and the agency the subject has over its own experience.

Charles Tart's definition seems more helpful. Tart, being one of the pioneers of scientific research on the subject of altered states of consciousness, mentions the necessity of a change in the paradigm of subjective experience, but he also insists on the subject having to be aware of the change.²⁶⁹ Kihlstrom's definition does not expect the subject to recognise the alteration, and thus makes it possible for neither the subject or the researcher knowing that such a state had occurred. Tart, on the other hand, gives all the power over the subjective to the subject of the experiment, seeing the first-person perspective as the superior, or even the only possible means of access to such states. The external observer, therefore,

²⁶⁸ J. F. Kihlstrom, *Convergence in understanding hypnosis? Perhaps, but perhaps not quite so fast*, 'International Journal of Clinical and Experimental Hypnosis', 1997, 45, pp. 324–332.

²⁶⁹ C. T. Tart, *States of consciousness and state-specific sciences*, 'Science', 1972, 176, pp. 1203–1210.

would have no say on the matter, and the occurrence (or not) of the altered state is determined fully by the subject of the experiment.

Some scholars decided to go even further, linking altered states of consciousness not only to the character or content of a subjectively perceived experience, but also to the biological processes that, according to their hypotheses, were supposed to accompany psychological changes. A definition in this line has been proposed by Shapiro, calling for a proof of change both subjective, psychological sensations as well as on psycho-physiological level²⁷⁰. Such construction of a definition allows for study of not only subjectively reported altered states, but it also allows the verification of such reports by objective measures, such as behavioral observation or changes in neural activity. An altered state of consciousness thus becomes an observable phenomenon, potentially quantifiable as to, for example, its intensity.

It is also clear that the definition of altered states of consciousness determines the methods of their study. An approach concentrated on the subjective will make use of self-description methods, used both during and after experiencing an altered state by the subject. This approach risks complete dependence on the subject's own account, while the subject may have a vested interest in convincing the researchers of having attained such a state. Reports made during an experience of an altered state of consciousness should also be treated cautiously due to the uncertain nature of the subject's very communicating skills – the language, the perception and memory can all be affected, resulting in confabulation and misleading descriptions. The third definition brings in the objective psycho-physiological measuring, but even those are only an indirect source of knowledge on mental processes. Thus, it seems that the best approach is to join all these strategies in search of the fullest understanding of the phenomenon.

²⁷⁰ D. Shapiro, *A biofeedback strategy in the study of consciousness*, [in:] N. E. Zinberg (ed.), *Alternate States of Consciousness*, New York 1977, pp. 145–157.

HYPNOSIS

Hypnosis has been treated as a phenomenon mystical²⁷¹ or supernatural in nature since its advent; thus, it has always aroused the public interest. History of hypnosis reaches back to the late 18th century, but scientific research into the subject has met with various difficulties, theoretical, methodological or ideological (since for a long time hypnosis was considered charlatanry). The most important symptom of this phenomenon is a heightened susceptibility of the subject to suggestion, accompanied by limited agency, plasticity of body and selective functioning of memory. For these reasons, it was assumed to be a drastic change in the psyche of the hypnotised subject. It seems natural to include a hypnotic state into the wider category of altered states of consciousness, since scientific study has in fact broached the subject.

Researchers are divided, however, where this classification is concerned. Two approaches have been proposed to the subject. One is the so called trance approach, which suggests that there is a separate, characteristic mental state that the hypnotised subject enters. This means that the subject undergoes a mental re-organisation that makes them more susceptible to external influence, while their will weakens and they are unable to resist this external influence. On the other side is the non-trance approach, which states that there is no empirical proof of this mental re-organisation, and that the hypnotic effect is due to social mechanisms – assuming a given role or trying to fulfil the expectations stated.²⁷²

While the scientific community knows more than these two approaches to hypnosis, the subtleties of these various stances are often lost when the necessity arises to declare one's side. In his revue, Kirsch demonstrates that these approaches are numerous and they span across a wide continuum, from complete rejection of hypnotic trance to its full affirmation.²⁷³

²⁷¹ A. Niedźwieńska, *Modyfikacja podatności hipnotycznej*, Kraków 1998, p. 9.

²⁷² Ibidem, pp. 17–18.

²⁷³ I. Kirsch, *The Altered State Issue: Dead or Alive?*, 'International Journal of Clinical and Experimental Hypnosis', 2011, 59:3, pp. 350–362.

The socio-empirical approach, which places itself on one end of this continuum, postulates that the phenomenon of hypnosis has no relation to the altered states of consciousness and is only a result of the instructions and influence of the hypnotist on the subject. For example, most hypnotic techniques are based on relaxation, which makes the proponents of the socio-empirical approach suggest that giving the same instructions to the merely relaxed subject would give similar results. The social context of this influence will make the subject erroneously ascribe the change in their subjective sensations not to the relaxed state, but to the hypnotic technique.

Kirsch mentions a less rigid non-trance approach, a definition of hypnosis as a linguistic term used to describe a set of sensations and subjective experiences.²⁷⁴ These do not correspond to any altered state of consciousness: the term 'hypnosis' is an umbrella term for a accumulation of mental, social and contextual factors influencing the subject of hypnosis.

Another approach to hypnosis is the epiphenomenal one, wherein the instructions of the hypnotist are a suggestion that the subject submits to, convincing themselves that they have in fact entered an altered state of consciousness. Researchers accepting this approach treat the subjective experience of the hypnotised as differing from a normal mental state, but they suggest no functional change takes place: a quale specific to the process does not induce any heightened susceptibility in the subject (nor does any neural process). Kirsch includes this approach in the socio-empirical group, since it accepts the altered state of consciousness, but one that does not cause any additional consequences.

The trance approach can also be sub-divided into at least two groups, with different definitions of the altered mental state of the hypnosis subject. The first is sometimes called the quantity approach, which reflects the most popular understanding of hypnosis among psychologists – a state of heightened susceptibility to suggestion (seen as a psychological trait).²⁷⁵ Researchers concentrate on the behaviour of hypnosis subjects, namely on the increased number of cases where actions were performed

²⁷⁴ J. F. Kihlstrom, *Hypnosis*, 'Annual Review of Psychology', 1985, 36, pp. 385–418.

²⁷⁵ E.g. E. Hilgard, *Hypnotic susceptibility*. New York 1965.

that were conform to the suggestions given, which is treated as proof of the subject attaining the hypnotised state. The subjective experience of the subject is not actually analysed.

The other end of this spectrum is the quality approach, wherein hypnosis as a mental state different than normal is the centre of attention. This approach has been long considered anachronistic, associated mostly with 19th century scholars mixing science and mysticism, and eschewed in favour of quantity research, especially by Hull.²⁷⁶ Lately, this approach seems to have regained the interest of researchers, especially those dealing with psycho-physiological aspects. The modern version of this approach sees hypnosis as a separate mental state, both objectively – altered functioning – and subjectively – altered sensations and experiences of the subject being a condition of classifying a given state as hypnosis.

A POSSIBILITY OF SETTLING THE MATTER EMPIRICALLY

Scientific attempts at settling the controversy around hypnosis and, more broadly, the definition of an altered state of consciousness itself (if hypnosis were to be treated as such) must resort not only to theoretical arguments, but use experimental methods. It seems that a definition is needed that would allow for various methods of measuring the activities of hypnosis subjects, thus allowing to discover objective characteristic traits and proof of hypnotic state. Researchers focusing on the subjective aspect usually use questionnaires and other means of self-description while trying to determine these tell-tale factors. As mentioned above, the methodological difficulties and vulnerability to manipulation make this method unsatisfactory on its own.

The necessary effect should be attainable by behaviouristic methods, and paradigms borrowed from cognitive psychology. The rapid development of neuroimaging technology in the last twenty years had encouraged many researchers to use it to either prove or disprove the trance character of the phenomenon. Basing on the research on consciousness, two main

²⁷⁶ C. Hull, *Hypnosis and Suggestibility: An experimental approach*. New York 1933.

areas of interest can be discerned here: one is a study of differences between the activity of a hypnotised brain and of a normally conscious one.²⁷⁷ This is the simplest method of proving a difference in brain functioning, as well as determining the portions of the brain which are linked to the hypnotic state. The second area is the study of similarities between the researched state – in this case hypnosis – and a state of consciousness which is known to be abnormal, or altered. In the case of hypnosis, the natural candidates for comparison seem to be the state of a lucid dream,²⁷⁸ or pharmacological anaesthesia, often linked to such states.²⁷⁹

As an example of the first approach, the behaviouristic experiments of Lifshitz and his associates could be mentioned: using the classical Stroop test, the team had demonstrated that subjects in a hypnotic trance were significantly less affected by the discrepancy between the meaning of the word and the colour of the font (which usually affects normally conscious subjects).²⁸⁰ Another example is the research by Kosslyn, where the research team, using a PET scanner, compared the neural activity of conscious subjects reacting to coloured stimuli and hypnotised subjects reacting to monochrome stimuli, while hypnotised to see colour.²⁸¹ An analysis of the experiment's results showed that the brains of the hypnotised subjects reacted, as suggested, as if they had been given coloured stimuli as well.

Neuroimaging also supplies hypotheses as to the mechanism of hypnotic suggestion. McGeown and his associates have demonstrated the difference between the brain activity during not only task performance, but

²⁷⁷ S. W. G. Derbyshire, M. G. Whalley, D. A. Oakley, *Fibromyalgia pain and its modulation by hypnotic and non-hypnotic suggestion: An fMRI analysis*, 'European Journal of Pain', 2009, 13, pp. 542–550.

²⁷⁸ The term 'hypnosis' relates, in fact, to the similarities between that state and a state of sleep, though its author had later tried, unsuccessfully, to introduce a more adequate name.

²⁷⁹ Hypnosis is mostly used in medicine as an equivalent to general anaesthesia in less invasive procedures.

²⁸⁰ M. Lifshitz, N. K. J. Campbell, A. Raz, *Varieties of attention in hypnosis and meditation*, 'Consciousness and Cognition', 2012, 21, pp. 1582–1585.

²⁸¹ S. M. Kosslyn, W. L. Thompson, M. F. Costantini-Ferrando, N. M. Alpert, D. Spiegel, *Hypnotic visual illusion alters color processing in the brain*, 'American Journal of Psychiatry', 2000, 157, pp. 1279–1284.

also during the short pauses between phases of the experiment.²⁸² The change in the so called Default Mode Network shows that hypnotised subjects can react to experimental instruction differently. Demetzi with his associates had received similar results when comparing brain activity in a normally conscious brain, the activity while performing a task of mental visualisation, and a hypnotic state.²⁸³ Derbyshire and team have, on their part, compared the reaction to a real pain stimulus and one that had been hypnotically suggested.²⁸⁴ They have observed the activity of analogous areas of the cerebral cortex in both cases. This shows that mechanisms of hypnosis are probably not unique to the phenomenon, but that a suggestion implemented in a certain way can cause a similar reaction to the actual experience. This, in turn, means that a subjective experience related to the suggestion can occur, thus validating the whole process for both the subject and the researchers.

SUMMARY

Altered states of consciousness are doubtlessly a fascinating phenomenon, a fuller understanding of which could aid in understanding the brain processes that consciousness itself is based on. However, attempts at a comprehensive summary of the problem have not been satisfactory so far.²⁸⁵ Imprecise, overly broad definitions and methodological problems in empirically verifying hypotheses have prevented a consensus on the very idea of what an altered state of consciousness even is, and which human experiences, life situations and activities could be qualified as such. Progress in scientific research on consciousness and the growing array of experimentation tools give hope of solving these difficulties in the future.

²⁸² W. J. McGeown, G. Mazzoni, A. Venneri, I. Kirsch, *Hypnotic induction decreases anterior default mode activity*, 'Consciousness and Cognition', 2009, 18, pp. 848–855.

²⁸³ A. Demetzi et al., *Hypnotic modulation of resting state fMRI default mode and extrinsic network connectivity*, 'Progress in Brain Research', 2011, 193, pp. 309–322.

²⁸⁴ S. W. G. Derbyshire et al., *Cerebral activation during hypnotically induced and imagined pain*, 'Neuroimage', 2004, 23, pp. 392–401.

²⁸⁵ A. Revonsuo, S. Kallio, P. Sikka, *What is an altered state of consciousness?*, 'Philosophical Psychology', 2009, 22:2, pp. 187–204.

This progress has also allowed for a better understanding of the hypnotic state, and for including in the research psychological and biological mechanisms present in hypnotised subjects. Cited work seems to suggest that the phenomenon of hypnosis is not only an effect of social convention and acceptance of a role proposed, as the radical non-trance approach suggests. Both behavioural reaction and brain activity of hypnotised subjects differs from what we can see in normally conscious subjects. It is too early, however, to decide whether these differences are due to a specific psychological process (or an array of processes), or due to the subjects themselves inducing a specific state of mind while 'getting in character'. Still, it cannot be denied that a change in subjective experience does take place, as demonstrated by contemporary research. Therefore, in the light of modern scientific findings, hypnosis seems to be a solid inclusion into the array of altered states of consciousness.

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WOMEN'S FERTILITY DANCES FOR FLAX AND HEMP: RECONSTRUCTION OF RITUAL USE OF ALCOHOL

Agricultural societies have maintained a strong reverence for those farming activities that open a new vegetation cycle; a reverence that had been ritualistically observed in Poland till the end of 19th century.²⁸⁶ These ritualistic observances, quasi-bacchic²⁸⁷ in character, were common during carnival, but also during Lent, sometimes continuing until harvest.²⁸⁸ Common ritualistic practices included dances for flax and hemp, prosperity leaping dance or parading dummies (representations of goats, bears, horses, storks, but also a Jew, a Gypsy or a Turk). These activities were magical in nature, and aimed to invigorate the powers of Earth-Mother, ensuring rich crops.²⁸⁹

²⁸⁶ Eliade wrote: 'Farm labour is a rite; partly because it is performed upon the body of Earth-Mother and unleashes the sacred powers of vegetation, but partly also because it involves the farmer's being integrated into certain beneficent or harmful periods of time; because it is an activity involving certain dangers (such as the anger of the spirit who was master of the land before it was cleared); because it presupposes a series of ceremonies of varying form and origin intended to assist the growth of cereals and hallow the work of the farmer; and finally because it brings him into a sphere which is, in a sense, also under the jurisdiction of the dead'. M. Eliade, *Traktat o historii religii*, Warszawa 1966, p. 326.

²⁸⁷ D. Niewiadomski, *Orka i siew w ludowych wyobrażeniach agrarnych*, Lublin 1999, p. 29.

²⁸⁸ A. Szlagowska, *Elementy kultu i symbole Ziemi w polskiej obrzędowości ludowej*, 'Literatura Ludowa', 2001, 4:5, p. 24.

²⁸⁹ Cultivation of fibre crops in 19th century was an important element of peasant's self-reliance, and was cared for accordingly. Flax was used to produce linen for cloth, as well as linseed oil, the seeds also used to feed cattle, in medicine and ritual food (flax seed soup was a traditional meal for Christmas). Hemp was important for rope making and other textiles.

Women's ritual dances increasing the yield of flax and hemp, which form a part of carnival customs,²⁹⁰ have been described by ethnographers more than once.²⁹¹ However, these authors have focused on the choreographic form of the ritual, without paying much attention to beverages used therewith. And yet, alcoholic beverages are always included in these practices, and especially during the traditional parties in taverns, which lasted for the last few days of carnival, they were consumed in copious amounts. This inebriation was an element of magically procuring prosperity, a bountiful harvest and happiness and, therefore, part of the article will examine it as an attempted reconstruction of ritualistic use of alcohol. I propose to approach the matter in three parts. Firstly, an introduction to the ritual of leaping dances and their significance; secondly, interpretative context of ritual semantics – time and space in which ritual consumption takes place, accompanying behaviour (pranks, dance, jumping, noise, ritualised forms of drinking); thirdly, function of alcoholic beverages.

WOMEN'S FERTILITY DANCES – RITE OVERVIEW

Prosperity-bringing dances, accompanied by alcoholic feasting, were once common not only in whole of Poland, but across Europe.²⁹² The scenario of women's ritual dances was quite complex and varied from region

²⁹⁰ Vegetative fertility dances are one of the main customs of *Zapusty* – the three last days before Ash Wednesday, from Sunday to Wednesday. Additional customs were dress up parades and other kind of feasts reserved for married women only. The scope of the subject means this article will have to concentrate on women's fertility dances for flax and hemp.

²⁹¹ B. Stelmachowska, *Podkoziółek w obrzędowości zapustnej Polski Zachodniej*, Poznań 1933; S. Benetowa, *Konopie w wierzeniach i zwyczajach ludowych*, Warszawa 1936; J. Dydowiczowa, *Wielkopolskie zapusty*, 'Polska Sztuka Ludowa – Konteksty', 1963, 17:2–3, pp. 72–80; Z. Kupisiński, *Wiosenne zwyczaje i wierzenia ludowe w Opoczyńskim*, 'Lud', 1998, 82, pp. 177–192; D. Kalinowska-Kłosiewicz, *Tańce zapustne kobiet na wysoki len. Elementy zaduszkowe w obrzędowości zapustnej*, 'Polska Sztuka Ludowa – Konteksty', 1988, 42:1–2, pp. 71–80; D. Niewiadomski, op. cit.; A. Gawęł, *Zwyczaje, obrzędy i wierzenia agrarne na Białostocczyźnie od połowy XIX wieku do początku XXI wieku*, Kraków 2009; B. Ogrodowska, *Zwyczaje, obrzędy i tradycje w Polsce. Mały Słownik*, Warszawa 2000, p. 221.

²⁹² P. Benetowa, op. cit., p. 34.

to region; however, a common structure can still be found.²⁹³ Married women would meet in a local tavern after the mass on Ash Wednesday, where they would dance to violin music, sing and drink copiously. This feast was for married women only. In the afternoon, they would go back to the village to 'kidnap' those young girls who had married in the previous year, and who now had to pay with beer and vodka to be accepted among the housewives. In the evening, men would join the women in a general feast, which included ritual leaping dances for conjuring bountiful crops. These dances had a clear sexual undertone,²⁹⁴ but their goal was practical: to make hemp grow tall and plentiful. They referred to one of standard ideas in magic thinking, 'the higher, the better',²⁹⁵ which was reflected in leaping dances symbolising tall crops.

There were some small differences in ritual practice from region to region: Mazovia,²⁹⁶ Pomerania,²⁹⁷ Podlachia,²⁹⁸ kieleckie²⁹⁹ or wielickie³⁰⁰ voivodships had their own variants, usually differing by the number of jumps made, or by watering the tree trunk that was being leaped over. In Podlachia, a large mortar (used for groats grinding) was brought to the tavern after the dance and filled with water. Blows of the pestle made the water splash out to the floor; the floor was then covered with straw,

²⁹³ Similar elements are present in carnival dances in Kujawy region, in the town of Stradom, around the city of Lublin, and in Międzyrzecze and Siedleckie regions. Cf.: O. Kolberg, *Dzieła wszystkie*, Vol. 9, *Wielkie Księstwo Poznańskie*, Kraków 1963, p. 128; Ibidem, Vol. 3, *Kujawy*, Kraków 1962, p. 213; M. R. Witanowski, *Lud wsi Stradomia pod Częstochową. Szkic etnograficzny*, 'Zbiór Wiadomości do Antropologii Krajowej', 1893, 17, p. 38; O. Kolberg, op. cit., Vol. 16, *Lubelskie*, Kraków 1962, p. 114; A. Pleszczyński, *Bojarzy międzyrzeccy. Studium etnograficzne*, Warszawa 1893, p. 85; U. Ulanowska, *Niektóre materiały etnograficzne we wsi Łukówcu (mazowieckim)*, 'Zbiór Wiadomości do Antropologii Krajowej', 1884, 8, p. 265.

²⁹⁴ B. Stelmachowska, op. cit., pp. 35.

²⁹⁵ The rule is described in detail by K. Smyk. Cf.: K. Smyk, *Choinka w kulturze polskiej. Symbolika drzewka i ozdób*, Kraków 2009, pp. 121–122.

²⁹⁶ O. Kolberg, op. cit., Vol. 28, *Mazowsze*, Warszawa 1964, p. 80.

²⁹⁷ B. Stelmachowska, *Rok obrzędowy na Pomorzu*, Toruń 1933, pp. 100–104.

²⁹⁸ Z. Gloger, *Rok polski w życiu, tradycji i pieśni*, Warszawa 1900, p. 112; P. Dworakowski, *Kultura społeczna ludu wiejskiego na Mazowszu nad Narwią*, Białystok 1964, pp. 73–74.

²⁹⁹ W. Siarkowski, *Materiały do etnografii ludu polskiego z okolic Kielc*, 'Zbiór Wiadomości do Antropologii Krajowej', 1878, 2:1, p. 224. p. 12

³⁰⁰ P. Cercha, *Przebieczany, wieś w powiecie wielickim*, 'Materiały Antropologiczno-Archeologiczne i Etnograficzne', 1900, 4, p. 124.

which was lit on fire several times over. This rite refers to the symbolic stature of water, fire and straw: water being a staple of agricultural rites, especially those related to new beginnings, as the primal matter from which all life sprang.³⁰¹ Straw, due to its kinship to grain, held the promise of rebirth, while its golden colour symbolised wealth. Contact with straw was to bring fertility to people, plants and animals.³⁰² Fire destroyed that which was old, used up and bad, thus making way for the new and fresh. 'Through its destructive power, fire thus brings an object [...] to an amorphous state (ash) which is necessary for a rebirth in a new form'.³⁰³ In this light, the custom of throwing ash at men who had come to the tavern during the women-only part of the feast becomes understandable.³⁰⁴

The ritualistic context explains other folk practices as well. Jan St. Bystron had described a custom of harnessing unmarried men and women to a block of wood, and interpreted it as a magical, plant reviving rite.³⁰⁵ The custom of Pomerania, wherein unmarried girls had to pay a tribute to a goat, was interpreted by B. Stelmachowska as a magical analogy for a wedding, performed for those who, by remaining unwed, did not fulfil their breeding obligations.³⁰⁶ Their state did not promote fertility, so they had to symbolically pay for that by a gift to the goat, which invigorated nature.

This concludes a short introduction to the form of women's crop fertility rites. However, ritualistic behaviour should not be viewed outside their broader social context and traditional customs. Therefore, a broader examination of worldview, activities, space and time is in order.

³⁰¹ Water was the fertilising and life-giving agent in agrarian beliefs. Pouring water over a log was an act of vegetative magic. D. Niewiadomski, op. cit., p. 126.

³⁰² J. Adamowski, *Obrzędy kołędnicze południowego Podlasia. Forma, typy, funkcje*, [in:] J. Adamowski, M. Wójcicka (eds), *Tam na Podlasiu*, Vol. II, *Tradycje podlaskiej obrzędowości*, Lublin 2009, p. 118.

³⁰³ P. Kowalski, *Kultura magiczna. Omen, przesąd, znaczenie. Leksykon znaki świata*, Warszawa 2007, p. 371.

³⁰⁴ J. Dydowiczowa, op. cit., p. 79.

³⁰⁵ J. S. Bystron, *Etnografia Polski*, Warszawa 1947, p. 117.

³⁰⁶ B. Stelmachowska, *Podkoziółek...*, op. cit., pp. 120–126.

INTERPRETATIVE CONTEXT OF RITES

The behaviour or activities of ritualistic dances can be analysed from six main points of view: time, space, actions - movement (leaps and dance), noise and verbalising wishes, performing subjects, and ritual consumption.

Time

The time of women's fertility dances determines their function and in fact is their main condition. The magical, mystical association of the moment is clear: a time of passage, a moment when the worlds of death and life, end and beginning (ending winter, starting spring) become close, a rapprochement of this world and the netherworld.³⁰⁷ The usual order was suspended,³⁰⁸ there was no moderation in fun and games. Villagers dressed up as representants of the 'old order'.³⁰⁹ Finally, Zapust himself appeared (*Zapusty* being the Polish folk name for carnival), wearing a sheepskin coat turned inside-out and claiming to come from a land where 'dogs bark with their tails', further symbolising the reversal of usual laws.³¹⁰ The feast ended at midnight to symbolically break with the madness of feasting and a passage to profanum that ultimately happened on Ash Wednesday, with the start of Lent. The carnival customs, including prosperity dances, were an attempt to tap into the magical powers of the netherworld while the border between worlds was thin, to ensure a better life in the new year and strengthen various aspects: life, health, fertility, prosperity, beauty, wealth, happy marriage, success, protection from illness and misfortune. The three last days before Lent served to create a new order, when the world leaves death and chaos behind, and it was then that the demiurgeous powers of humanity could be used to magically influence the emerging reality.

³⁰⁷ Cf.: D. Kalinowska-Kłosiewicz, op. cit., pp. 71–80.

³⁰⁸ H. Czerwińska, *Czas świąteczny w tradycyjnej kulturze ludowej*, 'Lud' 1984, 68, pp. 74–81.

³⁰⁹ O. Kolberg, op. cit., Vol. 9, *Wielkie Księstwo...*, op. cit., p. 23.

³¹⁰ Ibidem, t. 5, *Krakowskie*, Kraków 1962, p. 264.

Space

The participants of vegetative rituals operated in an *orbis interior* – the familiar space of their own village. This means that magical activities were meant to affect the microcosm of a village and its inhabitants. An observation of these spaces lets us divide them into two groups:

1. Public space – the taverns. These were the interim spaces, a link between places in the *orbis interior*, between the centre and border regions as well as the profane world and the sacred netherworld. The link of taverns with the chronic sacrum was evident in their location, as they were usually at crossroads.³¹¹ Thus a tavern is a different place, unsafe, unclean, and as such can facilitate contact with supernatural forces, an idea demonstrated in many folk tales. The power of chronic sacrum was used in rites to magically create prosperity and wealth in a renewing world.
2. Private space – fields, yards, houses. Thus the increase in prosperity was not limited to crops, but was meant to benefit the life of a whole family and homestead, to improve the lives of their inhabitants by bringing abundance to the field, the barn etc.

Dances and leaps

The leaping dance for flax and hemp usually entails jumping high and stamping or touching the earth, symbolically awakening it. The dance cumulated the fertility powers of the earth, especially since it was performed by women: their own fertility power strengthened the vegetative energy of the earth. High jumps were meant to cause tall growth of flax and hemp. B. Stelmachowska says that the dance was a kinetic representation of vegetation, since ‘movement is the key element of life, there is

³¹¹ ‘By the bigger roads, on crossings, a tavern always stood, like a trap that a passing peasant always fell in’. J. Madejczyk, *Wspomnienia*, Warszawa 1965, p. 39. Polish traditional culture saw crossroads as strongly sacred, as well as forks in the roads. They were a place where contact with the supernatural was easier, as shown in many stories and beliefs in ways of meeting devils and supernatural beings at crossroads. Cf.: J. Adamowski, *Kategoria przestrzeni w folklorze. Studium etnolingwistyczne*, Lublin 1999, pp. 179–188.

no life without movement'.³¹² In this context, dance has a creative power,³¹³ it becomes the tool used to bring back life to the world dormant in winter. Based on the principle of similarity, the actions performed symbolically were to be replicated in nature.

Verbalising wishes and noise

The ritual noise-making usually had the form of music and shouting. While performing the dances women would shout things like 'thus let it grow'³¹⁴, or 'for hemp, for hemp, let it abound, don't let our kids run naked around'³¹⁵, or 'go up, go up, like the hemp will too.'³¹⁶ In magical thinking, spoken word intervenes between sacrum and profanum and it can cause specific consequences in the profane space.³¹⁷ Thus everything said in a ritual has magical power. This was accompanied by clapping, stamping and shouting; noise has many functions in folk culture and all these are present in vegetative dances. In magical practices, noise means life, as opposed to silence, which means death. Women's dances brought life and vitality, so women's singing and shouting were a magical way of supporting the new life.

Noise can also fulfil an apotropaic function, and therefore shouting, stamping and other ritualised noise-making can be interpreted as a sonic influence on a given space, meant to secure it against unwanted influence by the dangerous forces of sacrum.³¹⁸

³¹² B. Stelmachowska, *Podkoziółek...*, op. cit., p. 120.

³¹³ D. Niewiadomski, op. cit., pp. 32–33.

³¹⁴ Z. St., *Znad Buga. Szkic etnograficzny*, 'Lud', 1897, 3, p. 29.

³¹⁵ K. Mátyás, *Zapust – Popielec – Wielka Noc. Kilka zwyczajów ludu w Tarnobrzelskiem*, 'Lud', 1895, 1, p. 83.

³¹⁶ W. Siarkowski, op. cit., p. 23.

³¹⁷ Cf.: A. Engelking, *Kłątwa. Rzecz o ludowej magii słowa*, Warszawa 2010.

³¹⁸ P. Kowalski, op. cit., pp. 67–72.

Performing subjects

The character of performers themselves was also a way of strengthening the re-awakening fertility. The importance of women in these rites, the loosening of manners – jokes and pranks with erotic undertones, heavy drinking – these and other activities were a way to invigorate the human energy,³¹⁹ they were signs of life.³²⁰ The supremacy of women in these rituals was due to their affinity to earth, since their own birthing powers make them akin to Earth-Mother herself. There is a mystical solidarity between the fertility of a woman and the fertility of the earth. While men were associated with seed, women gained special importance for being associated with earth.³²¹ Thus women's dances were a ritual form of expression favourable to magically influencing crops.

Ritual alcohol consumption

The special, final period of the Carnival, called *Zapusty* in Polish tradition, is the time from Fat Thursday till midnight before Ash Wednesday. It was celebrated with no shyness or moderation as far as eating, drinking, dancing and matchmaking was concerned. 'The host would slaughter a hog for *Zapusty*, because it had to be a fat feast. They invited neighbours and feasted on lard and scrambled eggs and lots of vodka. They would bring whole cauldrons of it to the house, and then go to the tavern for some hair of the dog'.³²² On the last days, sometimes called devilish days or 'leftovers', people would eat everything fat and sweet – pancakes, fried yeast dough, doughnuts and pastry stuffed with lard and fried in pork dripping. Fat Thursday began the whole fat week which crowned the carnival.

Ritual feasting was the opposite of Lent customs introduced by the church: prevalence of meat and animal products, big quantities. *Zapusty*

³¹⁹ D. Niewiadomski, op. cit., p. 37.

³²⁰ Many folk sayings prove that alcohol was considered the 'water of life': 'He lives fine who drinks wine'; 'An old wine and young wife give you life'; 'Vodka to cool, vodka to warm, vodka will never bring you harm'; 'Sad to think, have a drink'.

³²¹ M. Eliade, *Sacrum, mit, historia*, Warszawa 1974, p.146.

³²² K. Matyas, op. cit., p. 47.

were a time of sensory and physical hedonism, when searching for various types of intoxication was the chief concern: 'In a bunch of neighbouring villages, one could count on one hand the number of days when there was no feasting, because if not here, then in the adjacent village the tavern was shaking with the noise of music, with shouts of the drunk and drinking, and bursting with dancers'.³²³ The usual order and lay norms were suspended, because carnival is a holiday of Chaos.³²⁴ Leaving the mundane rules behind meant the time belonged to the other world, and the presence of both divine and demonic sacrum meant miraculous changes in reality were possible.

RITUAL FUNCTIONS OF ALCOHOL

All the elements of women's vegetative dances are known in culture. The examination above supports Nikita Tolstoi's claim, that ritual symbolism always strives for synonymity: many symbols in a given rite have the same meaning. This is also true for ritual alcohol use, which is one of the obligatory elements of the rite, replicating the function of other symbols and thus strengthening them.

During the last days of carnival, the time of intensive merriment and consumption, feasting went on practically non-stop, and alcohol helped to achieve this ecstatic state. It was usually vodka, cheap and strong. Everyone participated in the feast, regardless of age, so it was a time to meet new people, strengthen the bonds of acquaintance or friendship. Who drank with whom and how was a symbol of status, attainable now.³²⁵ The amounts of food and drink consumed symbolised its abundance and accessibility throughout the whole year and brought vital strength to the participants. It should be noted that alcohol was the 'water of life' (lat. *aqua vitae*) and served as a panacea to the country populace: 'the only substance protecting, and even curing of all ills [...] is vodka. Leastways,

³²³ Ibidem, p. 46.

³²⁴ R. Callois, *Żywioł i ład*, Warszawa 1973, p. 140.

³²⁵ This was despite the fact that a tavern was open to all social classes. The social divisions were still represented by who sat with whom and who drank with whom. Cf.: W. Witos, *Moje wspomnienia*, Paryż 1964, pp.135–136.

from it the simple folk expect help; it's vodka that, in their opinion, will strengthen them and aid their work, protect them from sickness since their work is exhausting; it will take their sadness away and suffering; in short, for its adherents, it is all'.³²⁶

In the course of carnival rites, alcohol was not only used for entertainment purposes. It was also a gift, a sacrifice for the ancestral spirits, which were believed to have influence on the homestead's wellbeing. Vodka was splashed upwards from the glasses, so that the crops would grow as high as the alcohol could go.³²⁷ Traditionally, throwing foodstuffs up into the air, towards the sky, '[...] was an offering and a pleading or penitent act. It was a sacrifice for the spirits of the dead, for the gods, demons and all the irrational forces that were active [during the time – B.H.] and whose favour was thus sought. It was supposed to protect and defend, but also bring blessing and prosperity'.³²⁸

I have divided the ritual functions of alcoholic beverages into two groups, for clarity, according to the scope of transformation ritualistically attributed to alcoholic beverages:

1. Relation functions, concerning the relationship of the users with two types of subjects:
 - a. Relating to the denizens of this world:
 - Courting functions – aiding matchmaking;
 - Entertainment functions – aiding in socialisation and fun;
 - b. Relating to the denizens of the sacred sphere:
 - Mediation – making contact with the sacred forces, which is a condition of the ritual itself, interceding in the transfer of energy and vital forces. Being the creator of this link, alcohol allowed a radical change in perception of the world, induced an ecstatic state that took mundane worries away and transported the participants into the paradise of joy, thus causing change in the real world;

³²⁶ M. Zieleniewski, *O przesądach lekarskich ludu naszego*, Kraków 1845, p. 40.

³²⁷ W. Drozdowska, *Obrzędy i zwyczaje związane z gospodarką w Jesieniu*, *Prace i Materiały Muzeum Archeologicznego i Etnograficznego w Łodzi*, 1957, 1, p. 108.

³²⁸ K. Leńska-Bąk, *Pokarmy obrzędowe w religijności ludowej. Kilka słów o maku, zbożu i każdym innym drobiazgu*, [in:] R. Pierskała, T. Smolińska (eds), *Pobożność ludowa w życiu liturgiczno-religijnym i w kulturze*, Opole 2004, p. 193.

- Necromancy – making contact with the spirits of the dead. D. Kalinowska-Kłosiewicz describes some necromantic elements of the carnival fertility dances, focusing on the ritual use of hair (a link between the material world and the chthonic sphere, where abundance never ends). Alcohol, with its mediative powers, was also a part of funeral and wake rites, where it was chiefly used to bid farewell to the departed, though it should be noted that in traditional rural culture death was a beginning of eternal life, a sacred moment that had its own kind of joy.³²⁹ During the ‘empty nights’ that preceded the funeral, the deceased was left a meal of bread, and ‘everyone who came to visit was given a shot of vodka [...]’.³³⁰ It was believed that the soul of the deceased participated in the repast, and ‘proper receiving of the guests was, symbolically, a proper feeding of the deceased’.³³¹ This libation was accompanied by speeches commemorating the deceased and wishing ‘eternal rest’ on them.³³² The presence of the chthonic sphere in vegetative rites is demonstrated by these rites taking place after a mass that was said for the dead, but at the same time for bountiful harvest.³³³ Guests from all over the village were invited for this occasion. Alcohol was used here not only as a beverage for the living, but mainly as an offering to the denizens of the netherworld, especially the souls of the dead;
- Apotropaic magic – controlling and limiting the influence of the supernatural forces, especially those unfavourable to mankind. The belief in otherworldly origin of alcoholic beverages caused

³²⁹ Cf.: M. Bachtin, *Twórczość Franciszka Rabelais’go a kultura średniowiecza i renesansu*, Kraków 1975, p. 395.

³³⁰ J. Słomka, *Pamiętniki włościanina. Od pańszczyzny do dni dzisiejszych*, Warszawa 1983, p. 133.

³³¹ A. Fisher, *Zwyczaje pogrzebowe ludu polskiego*, Lwów 1921, p. 202.

³³² Ibidem, p. 378.

³³³ ‘[...] if someone paid for a mass for the dead, or for a good harvest, or some other intention, he’d invite the neighbors to the mass, and friends and relatives, sending his children over the village to tell, and after the mass he’d invite them home to thank them for coming to pray for his wish, at home or in the tavern he’d host them, with vodka and food. To the house some people also invited the priest’. J. Słomka, op. cit., p. 54.

them to be used in many magical practices, especially curing skin diseases;³³⁴

2. Existential functions, concerning the quality of human life and its intangible components:
 - Vitality, ensuring life and health. Apart from the rites related to harvests and crops, customs of the time are meant to bring prosperity and blessing to private life. Maidens and bachelors were harnessed to a wooden bloc, girls danced in front of a goatling to apologise for remaining unwed, and newlyweds had to buy their acceptance. These practices were believed to have a beneficial influence on plant growth, they were a form of conjuring future prosperity and happiness through their creative, pro-biological powers. The belief in a beneficial influence of alcohol on human health is proven by its widespread use in folk medicine;
 - Fertility, strengthening the breeding powers of the Earth, people and animals. For this reason, some customs demanded that the participants roll on the ground in ritualistically significant foods like dumplings, scrambled eggs and vodka. Consuming them during rituals had the same reason as well.³³⁵ These activities were meant to ‘infect’ the soil with the vital energy of humans and food, to provoke fertility.

Summing up this short analysis, it should be noted that the mediative properties of alcohol are the most important in female vegetative dances. Courting functions, promotion of vitality and luck come close. This means that alcoholic beverages are a link between sacrum and profanum, meant to magically enhance life, prosperity, and relationships between women and men.

The image of vegetative dances that emerges from such examination is semantically complex, since it mixes ancient ideas such as agricultural sexuality, honouring the dead and magical mediation, with newer content, including ludic in nature. A full reconstruction of the array of mean-

³³⁴ Cf.: H. Biegeleisen, *Lecznictwo ludu polskiego*, Kraków 1929; J. Słomka, op. cit., p. 73.

³³⁵ The custom of rolling in soil is examined in more detail by D. Niewiadomski. Cf.: D. Niewiadomski, op. cit., pp. 34–38.

ings that vegetative dances convey would need an analysis of other practices, not mentioned here (such as ritual rolling around in soil or dragging a girl over the field stubble). Still, a presentation of ritual functions of alcohol does directly convey the most important meanings and allows a chronological examination of the rite.

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BZ (3-QUINUCLIDINYL BENZILATE) AS AN EXAMPLE OF A PSYCHOACTIVE SUBSTANCE IN THE NON- LETHAL ARSENAL OF THE UNITED STATES ARMY

Chemical warfare was an important part of the First World War – one of the bloodiest conflicts of the modern history. 125 thousand metric tons of chemical weapons were used, killing an estimated number of a hundred thousand soldiers and mutilating about 1.2 million.³³⁶ Thus, the resulting image of chemical weapons with the general public being extremely negative,³³⁷ efforts were made to curtail use of chemical weapons in future military conflicts,³³⁸ and, apart from a few infamous episodes,³³⁹ mass chemical warfare was discontinued.

Interest in chemical weapons was renewed in the Cold War. The United States have reinstated their work on incapacitating agents after year 1950, when the Committee on Chemical, Biological and Radiological Warfare published the Stevenson's Report – a document stating that the German

³³⁶ L. Konopski, *Historia Broni Chemicznej*, Warsaw 2009, pp. 56–58.

³³⁷ The use of chemical warfare in the First World War caused extreme controversy, although it was not an exceptionally lethal weapon. Mostly, the uproar was about the nature of the resulting damages. This was touched upon by the raport of general John Pershing, commander of the American Expeditionary Forces, summing up the 1914–1918 conflict: 'Whether or not gas will be employed in future wars is a matter of conjecture, but the effect is so deadly to the unprepared that we can never afford to neglect the question'. J. Pershing, *Final report of Gen. John J. Pershing, Commander-in-Chief, American Expeditionary Forces*, Washington 1920, pp. 76–77.

³³⁸ One of the articles in the treaty of Versailles (1919) obliged the surrendering countries (Germany, Austria, Hungary, Bulgaria) to discontinue use and production of chemical weapons. The Washington Naval Treaty of 1922 was a similar agreement between the USA, UK, France and Japan. A ban on the use in war of asphyxiating, poisonous or other gases and of bacteriological warfare was also introduced by the Geneva Protocol on 17th of June, 1925.

C. A. Warren, *GAS, GAS, GAS! The Debate Over Chemical Warfare Between the World Wars*, 'Federal History Journal', 2012, 4, pp. 49–54.

³³⁹ L. Konopski, op. cit., pp. 65–66; 73–77; 104–108.

technologies and giant chemical factories in the Eastern Germany, obtained by the Soviet Union, could give the Soviets an advantage in the arms race.³⁴⁰ The obsessive search for new weapons of mass destruction meant that large portions of the US budget were allocated to armaments, including chemical weapons research. While most of this was spent on improving lethal weapons (GB, CS), the US Department of Defence had also conducted experiments on psychoactive weapons.³⁴¹ The military scientists saw in those a chance to escape the negative image of chemical warfare (the public image of psychotropic substances had already changed with the invention³⁴² of LSD³⁴³): the lethal substances bringing about horrible death were to be substituted by a wondrous method of bloodless incapacitation.

The general public had mostly heard of the abovementioned LSD and lysergic acid – a derivative of alkaloids produced by a range of ergot fungi – as far as new, chemical weapons were concerned. This was due to the LSD's importance in the American counterculture movement.³⁴⁴ MKUL-

³⁴⁰ E. Croddy, *Broń chemiczna i biologiczna. Raport dla obywatela*, Warsaw 2003, pp. 51–52.

³⁴¹ Psychoactive incapacitating agents cause psychical anomalies or impede the functioning of the central nervous system, thus preventing an individual's normal functioning. They can only be used in gas form, and usually are a derivative of benzyl or phenylglycolic acid, tryptamine, phenylalkylamine, cannabinol, or lysergic acid. J. Błądek, *Broń chemiczna i toksyczne środki przemysłowe*, Warszawa 2011, p. 15.

³⁴² LSD-25 arrived in the United States in 1949, when psychiatrist Max Rinkel brought a sample from Sandoz Pharmaceuticals in Switzerland and began work at the Boston Psychopathic Hospital. Dr Harold Abramson, a New York chemist, allergist, and psychotherapist, began studying the clinical characterization of the new drug as well, and promptly published his results. Soon, the CIA was interested in this research as well. J. S. Ketchum, H. Salem, *Incapacitating Agents* [in:] S. D. Tuorinsky (ed.) *Medical Aspects of Chemical Warfare*, Washington 2008, pp. 413–414.

³⁴³ LSD (lysergic acid diethylamide) was first synthesised by a Swiss chemist working for the Sandoz Laboratories, Albert Hoffman, in 1938, during his efforts to obtain a cardiovascular stimulant. Since there were no useful results of further research on LSD in pharmaceutical animal trials, the research was discontinued. Hoffman discovered the psychedelic properties of the substance himself in 1943. A. Hofmann, *Odkrycie LSD i jego miejsce wśród substancji psychoaktywnych* [in:] A. Feilding (ed.), *Eliksir Hoffmanna. LSD i nowe Eleuzis*, Warsaw 2011, pp. 32–33.

³⁴⁴ M. A. Lee, B. Shlain, *Acid Dreams. The Complete Social History of LSD: The CIA, The Sixties, and Beyond*, New York 1985, pp. 113–119.

TRA tests also had a big impact on the public opinion, encouraging various borderline-conspiracy theories,³⁴⁵ especially considering the cases such as the infamous death of bacteriologist Frank Olson in 1953 – Olson was employed by the CIA, and was used as a test subject, being given LSD without his knowledge.³⁴⁶ After a series of tests and human trials, with initially promising results,³⁴⁷ the army gradually curtailed its research in military uses of LSD-25, as the substance proved too expensive to synthesise and tactically unsuitable (difficult to use in gas form).³⁴⁸ 3-Quinuclidinyl benzilate – turned out to be the alternative the American army was looking for.

3-Quinuclidinyl benzilate is an organic chemical compound produced by the Hoffman-La Roche laboratories in 1951. Its purpose was to treat stomach ulcers, but during trials it was re-discovered as a powerful psychedelic, and it was in that capacity that the American armament industry was interested in it. Eight years after its discovery, the University of Chicago College of Medicine³⁴⁹ investigated those properties, and soon the Edgewood Arsenal in Maryland, where military research and human trials were conducted, started to work on the substance, calling it EA 2277.³⁵⁰

³⁴⁵ Alternative interpretations of the MKULTRA trials are explored in such works as: J. Marks, *The Search for the 'Manchurian Candidate'*. *The CIA and Mind Control*, London 1979; H.P. Albarelli, *A Terrible Mistake: The Murder of Frank Olson and the CIA's Secret Cold War Experiments*, Waterville 2009; W. Bowart, *Operation Mind Control*, Glasgow 1978, J. Keith, *Mind Control, World Control*, Illinois 1997.

³⁴⁶ Olson was said to have learned that LSD had been slipped into his drink some 20 minutes after ingestion. The experiment was supposed to study the scientist's coping with the results of the powerful psychedelic. His case was only known by the general public in 1975, when the Rockefeller Committee, investigating the CIA after the Watergate scandal, found out about them. J. Ronson, *Człowiek który gapił się na kozy*, Warszawa 2010, pp. 239–243.

³⁴⁷ LSD's advantage was the small dose necessary to produce psychedelic effects: it can cause delirium in a portion of 20 micrograms. For comparison, mescaline caused delirium when applied in 15 miligrams – over a thousand times more. E. Croddy, op. cit., p. 154

³⁴⁸ L. Konopski, op. cit., p. 166.

³⁴⁹ R. Kirby, *Paradise Lost: The Psycho Agents*, 'The CBW Conventions Bulletin', 2006, 71, pp. 2–3.

³⁵⁰ Ibidem.

One of the researchers in Edgewood was a psychiatrist, doctor James S. Ketchum, who later published a detailed summary of the twenty years of his work on psychedelic substances: 'Chemical Warfare Secrets Almost Forgotten'. Four chapters are devoted, in their entirety, to 3-quinuclidinyl benzilate (BZ). He mentions several difficulties the research was meant to solve, such as the minimal active dose; the relation between the administration method (intra-venal injection,, hypodermic injection, ingestion, inhalation) and the hallucinatory effect; effect duration; the extent to which the effect is incapacitating; influence on basic life signs (arterial pressure, pulse, body temperature); and lastly, its usefulness on the battlefield.³⁵¹

In his book, Ketchum describes his experiments³⁵² as member of research team. He described three phases of the BZ's effect:

1. The first phase, 1 to 4 hours from ingestion of BZ,³⁵³ is characterised by such symptoms as difficulty in enunciation, dry mouth, stupor and spasms,³⁵⁴ and general body exhaustion.
2. The second phase is the sedation phase, where the patient enters a semi-coma³⁵⁵ and only responds to strong stimuli.
3. The third phase, about 12 hours from ingestion, is characterised by psychotic behaviour – the patient regains speech and indulges in long, nonsense rants as well as violent tantrums. Hallucinations supersede consciousness, real people and objects are ignored. A common behaviour is drinking hallucinated beverages and smoking illusory cigarettes. Time perception is lacking. This is followed by panic attacks and paranoia episodes, where the patient strongly believes someone

³⁵¹ J. S. Ketchum, *Chemical warfare Secrets almost forgotten*, California 2006, p. 44.

³⁵² Ketchum mentioned that all the work on various aspects of BZ use took three years – 100 000 hours of work by Edgewood Arsenal staff. Ibidem.

³⁵³ Ibidem.

³⁵⁴ J. S. Ketchum, H. Salem, op. cit., p. 429.

³⁵⁵ 'Sopor sleep – an abnormally deep sleep, wherein the patient manifests a deep depression of consciousness while responding to strong stimuli, but only momentarily. Pathological motor reactions can occur.'.

J. Wciórka, *Psychopatologia ogólna – objawy i zespoły zaburzeń psychicznych* [in:] A. Bili-kiewicz, W. Strzyżewski (eds) *Psychiatria: podręcznik dla studentów medycyny*, Warszawa 2006, p. 97.

want to kill them. Test subjects were also prone to recognise the medical staff of Edgewood as their friends or relatives, to hold long conversations with objects, and to hallucinate animals such as elephants, giant snakes or insects crawling on one's clothing. Test subjects were also unable to perform, and often even understand, simple instructions of the medical staff.³⁵⁶

Other, physical symptoms of BZ use include coughing and sneezing (since it's an irritant), and vomiting³⁵⁷ (since it reduces stomach acidity). The time it takes for the effect to wear off depends on the dosage: ingesting the minimal dose, inducing a mild delirium, meant the patient regained mental and physical aptitude after about 24 hours.³⁵⁸ A dose of 5 to 7 micrograms per kilogram of body mass meant the effect endured up to eighty hours.³⁵⁹

BZ acts as, among other effects, an inhibitor of the muscarinic receptors of the central nervous system,³⁶⁰ as well as those present in the neurons of the peripheral nervous system and stomach lining (for which reason it was tested as a stomach ulcer cure by Hoffman-La Roche).³⁶¹ It can certainly be described as hallucinogen (impeding the perception of reality, similarly to LSD). It does not produce symptoms of any known psychosis as these – for example the schisoaffective disorders – rarely include visual hallucinations.³⁶² Besides, as Ketchum had noted, BZ does not cause a need for social isolation, which is typical for schizophrenia,³⁶³ and does

³⁵⁶ J. S. Ketchum, op. cit., pp. 48–49.

³⁵⁷ L. Konopski, op. cit., p. 167.

³⁵⁸ J. S. Ketchum, H. Salem, op. cit., p. 424.

³⁵⁹ Ł. Kamiński, *Farmakologizacja wojny. Historia narkotyków na polu bitwy*, Kraków 2012, p. 233.

³⁶⁰ J. S. Ketchum, H. Salem, op. cit., p. 422.

³⁶¹ K. Orzechowska-Juzwenko, *Leki przeciwnowotworowe* [in:] W. Kostowski, Z. S. Herman (eds), *Farmakologia. Podstawy farmakologii. Podręcznik dla studentów medycyny i lekarzy*, Vol. 1, Warszawa 2010, pp. 405, 406.

³⁶² 'Visual hallucinations are rare, and usually are associated with ideas of external intervention (such as "having a film projected in front of one's eyes") or a symbolic, supernatural transformation of the world (changes in colour or light)'. J. Wciórka, *Psychozy schizofreniczne* [in:] A. Bilikiewicz, W. Strzyżewski (eds), *Psychiatria: podręcznik dla studentów medycyny*, Warszawa 2006, p. 329.

³⁶³ Ibidem, p. 328.

not show any symptoms known to be part of the manic episodes in a Bipolar Disorder.³⁶⁴ However, the hallucinatory effects of 3-quinuclidinyl benzilate are not unique: identical, though short-lived, symptoms can be observed in cases of overdose on such medicines as antihistamines,³⁶⁵ tricyclic antidepressants,³⁶⁶ ipratropium bromide³⁶⁷ or barbiturates.³⁶⁸

An interesting case, studied in Edgewood and described by Ketchum, was that of a chess master who volunteered to test the substance. The goal was to determine the military usefulness of BZ. The goal being to exclude soldiers from fighting by making them unable to think normally, the question was whether BZ could inhibit the decision process of an individual specialised in a given field. The subject was a man specialised in playing chess, described by Ketchum as an exceptionally intelligent individual. Before ingesting LSD, he had played a few chess matches with the Edgewood staff, where he beat them in only a few movements. After a dose of BZ, he engaged in a three hour series of matches with one of the facility technicians, which he won, but needing more and more time. Four hours after ingestion of BZ, he had committed a few tactical errors, but was still capable of beating the rival. Five hours into the experiment, the patient, after a series of mistakes in his play was sure of his defeat and refused to play on.³⁶⁹

³⁶⁴ J. S. Ketchum, op. cit., p. 51.

³⁶⁵ An antihistamine overdose is characterised by disorientation, agitation, short-term memory and speech impediment. Pointless body movement and visual hallucinations can also occur. E. Zawisza, *'Dobre i złe' leki antyhistaminowe*, 'Alergia', iss. 3/2009, pp. 25–27.

³⁶⁶ 1 to 2 hours after an antidepressant overdose, symptoms such as vertigo, drying of mucous membranes, drowsiness (may transform into coma), loss of consciousness and raving. J. Szymańska, *Zatrucia lekami* [in:] W. Seńczuk (ed.) *Toksykologia współczesna*, Warszawa 2006, pp. 280–281.

³⁶⁷ Ipratropium bromide poisoning causes dry mouth, drying and reddening of skin, aggressive behaviour, memory impediment and hallucinations. K. Orzechowska-Juzwenko, op. cit., pp. 420–421.

³⁶⁸ J. Szymańska, op. cit., p. 265.

³⁶⁹ J. S. Ketchum, op. cit., p. 50.

Ketchum had visited the patient in a few hours, observing the aforementioned symptoms of the delirium phase,³⁷⁰ and proposed a game of chess, which was enthusiastically accepted. Despite growing signs of disorientation, the chess master was able to concentrate on the game and to make logical moves, but his tactical ability was greatly diminished and he committed absolutely basic errors. This resulted in Ketchum, who described himself as a mediocre chess player, winning the game. This time, however, the patient did not react with frustration, but described the match as a 'good game' and offered a rematch. Ketchum had noticed that the patient's experience in chess games had ingrained in him a certain kind of muscle memory which prompted him to make game moves almost automatically – but 3-quinuclidinyl benzilate had suppressed this ability.³⁷¹

Another interesting case elaborated upon in the 'Chemical Warfare' was a BZ session with an 'average man'³⁷² as a volunteer: an ex-mailman and soldier dubbed 'John Blake' in the experiment. He received 7 micrograms of BZ per kilogram of body mass, so a larger dose than was usually recommended to induce delirium. The effects were simultaneously observed on a second test subject, dubbed 'Eddie Clark.' The tests took two weeks, and used the crossover double-blind method, wherein Eddie received 3-quinuclidinyl benzilate, while John received placebo drugs, and after a week, this was exchanged. The notes on this test are especially interesting as the only existing report which comprises an hour-by-hour description of the effects of 3-quinuclidinyl benzilate over a long period of 145 hours. During the experiments, the volunteers were subjected to routine health checks and simple tests that evaluated their mental state.³⁷³

In the first hours of John's intake of BZ, he exhibited all three abovementioned stages of effect, though they were produced much faster than with

³⁷⁰ Ibidem.

³⁷¹ Ibidem, p. 51.

³⁷² Two days prior to the experiment, health tests such as ECG and EEG, which showed John Blake to be in good condition, and MMPI psychological tests, which showed no anomaly. Ibidem, p. 82.

³⁷³ Draw-a-Man test was one of the methods used. Subjects were also given playing cards and told to describe the card number and suit. They were also asked simple control questions. All these the subjects found incredibly difficult under the incapacitating effects of BZ delirium. Ibidem, pp. 86–92.

the smaller doses (hallucinations started as fast as 5 hours after intake). During the experiment, subject showed typical BZ delirium behaviour, such as repeated smoking of non-existent cigarettes, ravings, interaction with imaginary objects and animals, irrational dialogue with staff as well as imaginary interlocutors. John found it very difficult, or indeed impossible, to perform basic tasks such as getting dressed or eating. He had rarely eaten the meals that were brought to him. Despite his fatigue, he could not sleep (exhibiting heightened motor activity), he was disoriented and incontinent. These symptoms had only started to wear off after about 84 hours of testing. They wore off entirely after 118 hours.³⁷⁴ The staff had naturally performed extensive tests on a sober patient, which showed no anomalies.³⁷⁵

At the conclusion of the tests, John Blake had described his own experience while under the influence of 3-quinuclidinyl benzilate, of which strange dreams stood out most. He also complained of memory loss, being unaware of what happened during the experiment, and under impression that he had slept through most of it.³⁷⁶ Interestingly enough, Ketchum had noted that most patients did not find the BZ delirium to be a negative experience. They had compared it to a two-three day drinking spree and many of them agreed to repeat the tests.³⁷⁷

Thus, the experiments showed that BZ was quite efficient at rendering individuals helpless while being relatively safe, and as such could be used as basis for a new non-lethal incapacitating agent.

A non-lethal weapon has been defined by the USA Department of Defence as a kind of weapon that incapacitates human opponent or damages equipment, while minimising fatal casualties and body mutilation.³⁷⁸ It was supposed to be an alternative or counterbalance to 'traditional'

³⁷⁴ Ibidem, p. 94.

³⁷⁵ Ibidem, pp. 93–94.

³⁷⁶ Ibidem, p. 95

³⁷⁷ 'In reality, most volunteers did not consider incapacitation with BZ to be a seriously unpleasant experience[...] It was pretty much like a lost weekend – 2-3 days of drunkenness, but quickly forgotten.' Ibidem, p. 82.

³⁷⁸ G. T. Allison, P. X. Kelley, R. L. Garwin, *Nonlethal Weapons And Capabilities*, New York 2004, p. 12.

weapons, the purpose of which is primarily to eliminate the target entirely. The non-lethal weapons are designed for optimal balance of maximum incapacitation of target with minimum chance of killing or wounding it.³⁷⁹ Several characteristic traits that can distinguish non-lethal weapons from lethal weapons are: 'a capacity to stun, slow, inhibit or disorientate, instead of destroying and killing; reversible effects on personnel; serious reduction of possible lethal casualties, wounds and destruction'.³⁸⁰ Non-lethal incapacitating agents, 'substances that cause a temporary loss of operational capability in personnel can be an important non-lethal weapon. Naturally, they should not have any lasting effects on the physical or mental health of the target'.³⁸¹

BZ had fulfilled most³⁸² of these conditions – it could incapacitate the enemy for 24–80 hours, the effects were reversible,³⁸³ and did not cause any lasting damage on human mental and physical health (in short term use). This caused it to become the first psychoactive drug to be included in the US military arsenal. Ketchum notes that the 'success' of BZ was mostly due to its pharmacological properties.³⁸⁴

At the end of 1963, the Millmaster armament company had started to mass produce BZ for the American army – 45 000 kilograms were delivered to the Pine Bluff Arsenal to be converted into ammunition. Hand grenades were considered at the start, as well as ballistic rockets and smoke generators. Two types of cluster bomb had eventually proven to be the best choice: the M44, 80 kg bomb used in light aircrafts, containing three thermic generators, 22 kg each,³⁸⁵ and the 340 kg M43, carrying 57

³⁷⁹ N. Świętochowski, *Współczesna broń nieśmiertelności. Podział i charakterystyka*, 'Zeszyty Naukowe WSOWL', 2013, 2, p. 6.

³⁸⁰ Ibidem, p. 7.

³⁸¹ Ibidem, p. 12.

³⁸² The substance's effect was unpredictable and could provoke patients into self-harm, as testified by one of the Edgewood volunteers, Franklin D. Rochelle, in his interview for the 'Guerres sur ordonnance' documentary. He mentions cutting open the skin on his arms with the shaving equipment provided, while under the influence of BZ. *Guerres sur ordonnance*, dir. Stéphane Benhamou, France, 2013.

³⁸³ Doctor Ketchum and his team had developed an antidote to BZ – physostigmine. J. S. Ketchum, op. cit., p. 116.

³⁸⁴ Ibidem, p. 66.

³⁸⁵ R. Kirby, op. cit., p. 3

smaller M138 bombs and adapted for supersonic aircrafts. The ammunition had a limited area of effect – 1100 to 8800 square kilometres, and could influence 10 to 110 infantrymen at a time.³⁸⁶ It was supposed to be used in special operations of high intelligence capacity, in hostage rescue or in cases of the enemy troops moving simultaneously with home troops.

BZ-containing weaponry was tested as part of the SHAD operation which was itself part of the larger Project 112,³⁸⁷ as shown by the de-classified files of the Deseret Test Center.

The documents from the sixties mention trials of BZ use in the Hawaiian nature preserve areas (Waiakea Forest Reserve and Olaa Forest Preserve). The so called Pine Ridge tests (DTC Test 65-16) were meant to evaluate the performance of the cluster bombs in difficult conditions: jungle or rainforests.³⁸⁸ Though not officially stated, it can be inferred that the tests were conducted with the specific conditions of the Vietnam War in mind.³⁸⁹ Officially, BZ was never used in combat by the American army. However, the idea of 3-quinuclidinyl benzilate being used on troops in

³⁸⁶ Ibidem.

³⁸⁷ Between 1962 and 1974 the Deseret Test Center in Fort Douglas, Utah had conducted tests of biological and chemical weapons efficacy. These were called Project 112 and Project SHAD. Fact Sheet of the 'Office of the Assistant Secretary of Defence (Health Affairs) Deployment Health Support Directorate', *Deseret Test Center. Pine Ridge*, 2002, http://mcm.dhhq.health.mil/Libraries/CBexposuresDocs/pine_ridge.sflb.ashx [20.12.2014].

³⁸⁸ L. D. King, *Test 64-8 – Tall Timber (U) and trial groups B and D of tests 65-16 Pine Ridge (U). Final Report*, Utah – Deseret Test Center 1967, pp. 24–28, http://www.dod.mil/pubs/foi/operation_and_plans/Exercises_and_Projects/1018.pdf [20.12.2014].

³⁸⁹ The vast majority of the Vietnam territory was covered in forest, vastly decreasing infantry efficacy.
G. L. Rottman, D. Anderson, *The US Army in the Vietnam War 1965–73*, Oxford 2008, p. 4.

the Vietnam War had entered pop culture in 1990 due to the plot of the *Jacob's Ladder* film by Adrian Lyne.³⁹⁰

Although BZ had never become a main incapacitating agent in the American arsenal – as opposed to various nerve agents³⁹¹ – it was doubtlessly one of the most original weapons in the US history. It was eventually forfeit, and the stockpiles destroyed (probably due to its unpredictable effects and the impractical spray form which reduced the element of surprise). Nevertheless, research on BZ and various psychoactive incapacitating agents (mescaline, THC, LSD), though ethically questionable, were a step towards a humanitarian conflict resolution. Although 3-quinuclidinyl benzilate had not found use on the battlefield, it promoted other work towards non-lethal weapon development.

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³⁹⁰ The movie's plot concerns a Vietnam veteran Jacob Singer, suffering from strange hallucinations and flashbacks. The protagonist suspects they are a result of medical experiments conducted on him in Vietnam without his knowledge. The closing credits include an unsourced claim of BZ tests being conducted during the Vietnam War. *Jacob's Ladder*, dir. Adrian Lyne, USA 1990.

³⁹¹ E. Croddy, op. cit., p. 53.

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DRUG ADDICTION IN THE LIGHT OF THE THEORY OF SOCIAL PROBLEMS

The premise of this article is a sociological description of the phenomenon of drug addiction. The analysis is carried out in relation to the theory of social problems, which conceptualizes the phenomena defined by members of a given society as pathological and threatening. The main risks arising from the consumption and distribution of drugs include: 1) deaths related to drug abuse; 2) injection-transmitted infections; 3) drug trade-related crimes; and 4) narcobusiness growing at the expense of the addicts. Generally, a society with a high degree of addiction bears the costs associated with lower activity of its members or their total inability to participate fully in social life (with resulting marginalization, and even dehumanization of these individuals). Restoration of social homeostasis requires large expenditures (financial as well as non-financial) associated with reintegration, treatment, and rehabilitation of addicts; consequently it is necessary to make efforts to fully understand the phenomenon of drug addiction, and thus to be able to counteract its negative effects.

THE MEANING OF SOCIAL PROBLEMS

Sociology, almost from its begging, has been developing as a science concerning various types of social problems – it explained their origin, discussed their duration, consequences, and effects. Although problems in general have always accompanied mankind, the concept itself first appeared in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, and in Poland only after the system change of 1989.³⁹² The spectrum of problems has been and still is very broad, and gradually expanding. Despite the

³⁹² L. Miś, *Teoria socjologiczna a praktyka rozwiązywania problemów społecznych*, [in:] M. Malikowski (ed.), *Problemy społeczne w okresie zmian systemowych w Polsce*, Rzeszów 1997, p. 19.

fact that social problems were never the same for each and every community (people have struggled with various difficulties depending on the ethnicity, gender, age, status, hierarchy, and many other variables), they are found in each anthropologically examined and described society. Therefore, it may be assumed that social problems are a characteristic of the society, regardless of its degree of organization.

There are many different definitions of social problems and theories that explain them. Definitional-theoretical systems are built based on the subject or object of the problem, that is the answer to the question what and/or whom the problem affects. Generally speaking, a problem stems from a serious breach or undermining of the norms and values that are considered in this group to be universally recognized, important, constitutive, and therefore necessary for the group's continuity. The problem is of a dichotomous structure; it can be, firstly, a behaviour classified as pathological or deviant; secondly, a conflict having an ethnic, sexual, religious, etc., background. Janusz Sztumski defines social problems as phenomena that cause a response in the public consciousness and are seen as dysfunctional and harmful.³⁹³ On the other hand, Robert Dentler indicates that social problems should be described through the prism of deviation from the norm – as 'conditions that were defined by significant groups within the population as a deviation or violation of certain social standards, which in the opinion of these groups must be maintained if human life or the order of actions or events determining or maintaining sense of life, should persist'.³⁹⁴ Thus, a problem arises when a norm adopted by the community as the standard (and therefore it is considered prototypical and fundamental) is bent or rejected. In the face of challenging or repudiating social standards, disorder, axionormative chaos – anomie – arises.

Because of the diversity within the social structures and cultures, issues are arbitrary or dependent on the social contract and moral fortifications. A situation becomes problematic when it is recognized as such, regardless of whether, objectively speaking, it is true. In other words, an issue is

³⁹³ J. Sztumski, *Problem społeczny jako przedmiot badań socjologii*, 'Studia Socjologiczne', 1977, 42: 3, p. 215.

³⁹⁴ Based on: K. Frysztański, *Socjologia problemów społecznych*, Warszawa 2009, p. 17.

a problem when the society calls it this way. As long as the circumstances/conditions/situations are not seen as problematic (i.e. they do not cause difficulties, crises, or unpleasant effects) they cannot be considered a problem, even if from an outside observer's perspective, they seem difficult, shameful, cruel. Thus, the way members of the group think about an issue dictates if it will be seen as a problem. Social groups indicate the importance and scope of the problem. It happens quite often that the same behaviour or event by some groups is interpreted as a problem threatening the survival of the society, while for others it does not affect the existing conventions even in the smallest way. Despite the fact that social problems are present in all societies, there are diametric differences in the perception of their forms, manifestations, and possible consequences. According to Frysztański, 'these social beliefs mark particular events as problems, a kind of a gap between how things are and how they should be'.³⁹⁵ In the case of an appearing cognitive dissonance, the individual begins to understand that the discrepancy between the existing and desired situation is the source of discomfort.

Ronald W. Maris wrote that social problems can be looked at from two extreme perspectives: the objectivist and subjectivist. The objectivist (external) perspective points to the objective nature and shape of the phenomenon that causes the problem. The objectivistic approach to social problems is supported by, among others, Janusz Sztumski, who argued that 'social problems are social facts, i.e. they objectively exist'.³⁹⁶ Social facts, in the light of Emile Durkheim's theory, have the following characteristics: 1) they are external to the consciousness of individuals (they exist objectively); 2) they are coercive (or have an impact on the consciousness); 3) and they are shared by the community.³⁹⁷ The other perspective – subjectivist (internal), deals with the response and actions of people in the event of a contact with a problem or attempts to solve it. Its supporters (Herbert Blumer, Peter Berger, Thomas Luckmann) recognized as problems those social phenomena, 'which are described by people as prob-

³⁹⁵ K. Frysztański, op. cit., p. 18.

³⁹⁶ Ibidem, p. 220.

³⁹⁷ E. Durkheim, *Zasady metody socjologicznej*, Warszawa 2000, pp. 27–39.

lematic. There are no specific features of a society that would be inherently pathological or problematic'.³⁹⁸ A problem emerges when a phenomenon is recognized and identified as problematic – the public decides on the existence of a problem.³⁹⁹ Identifying and acknowledging a problem by the group leads to taking preventive measures oriented towards minimizing or eliminating the issue completely.

Both the objectivist and subjectivist perspectives are extreme, and therefore controversial. Therefore, combining the two seems useful. A theory by Paul B. Horton and Gerald R. Leslie⁴⁰⁰ proposes a uniting optics, which defines the social problem according to following characteristics: 1) it is undesirable and troublesome (due to its intensity, frequency, range, or effects); 2) it affects a large portion of society (the problem must exist in the public mind and be evaluated negatively); 3) it is possible to overcome it (individuals should be convinced that the problem can be solved or minimized with sufficient determination and commitment); 4) not only professionals, but, most of all, the community takes part in tackling the problem.⁴⁰¹

In the drug addiction analysis and interpretation presented here, I employ the above-mentioned social problem definition components. The phenomenon, presenting a major threat to society, should be a subject of multi-faceted public debate, aiming to solve the problem by presenting corrective actions.

DRUG ADDICTION AND DRUGS IN SOCIETY

'Narcomania' is one of the ways to describe drug addiction. While this phenomenon has a very long history (drug abuse was a common practice

³⁹⁸ M. K. Mlicki, *Procesy identyfikacji problemów społecznych*, [in:] *Socjologia problemów społecznych. Teorie i rzeczywistość*, Wrocław 1987, p. 11.

³⁹⁹ E. Hałas, *Problemy nierówności społecznych w perspektywie symbolicznego interakcjonizmu*, 'Roczniki Nauk Społecznych', 1987, 24:17, p. 145.

⁴⁰⁰ Based on: J. Sztumski, op. cit., p. 217.

⁴⁰¹ Ibidem.

already in ancient times), a definition describing it as an addiction appeared only in the twentieth century.⁴⁰² The word comes from the Greek *narke* / *narkosis* (numbness, dizziness, intoxication) and *mania* (madness, drive). Etymologically speaking, 'narcomania' means an addiction induced by necessity of permanent and continuous use of substances of addictive nature in order to achieve an altered state of consciousness. Today, the phenomenon is defined through the perspective of dependence on the behavioural, emotional, and mental levels. The law on preventing drug addiction defines it as follows: '[narcomania - JT] is permanent or temporary use for non-medical purposes of narcotic drugs or psychotropic substances or substitutes, resulting or possibly resulting in dependence on them'.⁴⁰³ Addiction and the resulting disorders are the major factors distinguishing narcomania from incidental or trial use of the drug. The essence of addiction is the appearing physiological need to increase the amount and / or rate of administering the drug to achieve the desired effect. Systematic dose increase stems from developing substance tolerance and the occurrence of unpleasant withdrawal symptoms, which are caused by irreversible biochemical changes that has taken place in the body.⁴⁰⁴

In Europe, production and use of narcotic substances has been known for a long time, but up until the mid-twentieth century it was treated as a rare phenomenon, occurring only in certain circles: among artists (arousing creativity) or physicians (due to easy access).⁴⁰⁵ It was only in the 1960s when the society realised that drug abuse is not a characteristic of only nonconformists or outcasts, but concerns varying communities. The increase in drug consumption at that time was related to the dynamic social changes taking place (appearing contesting movements and youth rebellions, freedom and equality ideas with hippie slogans dominating the language). In Poland, drug addiction starts to be noticed, thought to be disturbing, and defined as a threat in the 1970s, thus gaining the status of a social problem. In the first decade of the twenty-first century, the phenomenon took another shape, which essentially was influenced by three

⁴⁰² A. Muszyńska, *Narkomani – sprawcy czynów karalnych*, Kraków 2004, p. 17.

⁴⁰³ isap.sejm.gov.pl, [16.01.2015].

⁴⁰⁴ R. C. Carson, J. N. Butcher, S. Mineka, *Psychologia zaburzeń*, Gdańsk 2006, pp. 552–553.

⁴⁰⁵ S. Petrovic, *Narkotyki i człowiek*, Warszawa 1998, p. 11.

factors. Firstly, new types of drugs appeared on the market. Secondly, the stereotype of a drug addict as somebody homeless, unemployed, representing the underclass was refuted; it started to include the middle and high classes, the rich and important. Thirdly, the acceptance of the so-called soft drugs (especially marijuana), which are treated rather as a stimulant than as a drug, became more and more apparent. It is also linked to an increase in the designer drugs supply, the use of which (although very dangerous, often fatal) is not subject to sanctions. In this context, some researchers propose a hypothesis that in the future we will have to deal with even greater attempt to de-stigmatize some psychoactive substances.⁴⁰⁶

Not only the concept of drug addiction, but also that of drugs themselves is vague and imprecise, as it lacks a clear and generally accepted definition. The descriptive definition states as follows: '[a drug - JT] is a compound or mixture of compounds, not used for health purposes, that when administered alters biological functions or biological structure'.⁴⁰⁷ In the literature, on account of semantic inconsistencies, synonyms are typically used, such as 'psychoactive substance' or 'intoxicant'. The essence of their actions is to decrease or increase the excitability of the central nervous system, resulting in the need for permanent use, physical and psychological dependence, and harm to the psychosomatic health.⁴⁰⁸ The World Health Organization classifies drugs as follows: opium and opiates, sedative-hypnotics barbiturates and barbiturate-likes, amphetamine and amphetamine-likes, cocaine, cannabis, plant-derived hallucinogen, khat, solvents (e.g. acetone, benzene, toluene).⁴⁰⁹ Regardless of the type and origin of the drug, all of the above-mentioned have non-specific action, causing a number of side effects, endangering the health and life of an individual. Although the harmful effects and physiological consequences of substance abuse are a major component of the definition of drugs, it

⁴⁰⁶ M. Jędrzejko, P. Jabłoński, *Narkotyki i paranarkotyki. Perspektywa polska*, Warszawa 2011, pp. 117–118.

⁴⁰⁷ S. Maisto, M. Galizio, G. Connors, *Uzależnienia: zażywanie i nadużywanie*, Warszawa 1999, p. 3.

⁴⁰⁸ A. Latka, W. Gąsiorowski, *Narkotyki. Podstawowe rodzaje i opis*, Warszawa 1997, p. 6.

⁴⁰⁹ Ibidem, p. 21.

should be noted that describing it solely through the prism of pharmacology is controversial and not fully legitimate. The researchers point out to the 'illusion of pharmacological objectivity',⁴¹⁰ which means that the drug should be defined not so much by means of biological changes or reactions it causes in the body, as in relation to how society perceives the substance. Erich Good claimed that the concept of a drug in reality is a product of the society. This is because the pharmacological criteria are not able to cast the essence of drugs as there are no universal causes and effects of their use. Undoubtedly psychoactive substances have some common pharmacological and chemical properties which strongly affect the mind and body, but the way in which they work has little to do with how they appear to public awareness and how they are defined.⁴¹¹ The society assigns meaning to certain facts, interpreting them in a way that it considers appropriate for itself and is justified from the point of view of the society's survival as a whole. Defining the phenomena arbitrary and giving them different meanings affect their eligibility as a problem or as a norm. In the case of drugs (especially soft drugs), differences result from the following basic sources: 1) social – they are conditioned by the structure of the given society, for example inequalities and class divisions, institutions and organizations, 2) cultural – they stem from traditions, customs, and cultural rules recognized in the community, 3) economic – directly related to the development of capitalism and international trade, 4) religious – they depend on values and standards followed by the majority and the degree of religiosity, 5) political – they are a derivative of liberal or conservative domestic policy 6) legal – resulting from the punitiveness or permissiveness of the legally adopted penal system.

DRUG ADDICTION – A PROBLEM AND A SOCIAL THREAT

Drug addiction is a current social problem, one of the most serious pathologies of the contemporary civilizations. This is because it prevents

⁴¹⁰ K. Frieske, R. Sobiech, *Narkomania. Interpretacja problemu społecznego*, Warszawa 1987, p. 13.

⁴¹¹ E. Good, *The Criminology of Drugs Use*, sagepub.com/oswmedia3e/study/chapters/handbooks/handbook6.2.pdf, [10.12.2014].

proper (in relation to the accepted norm) functioning of the society, inhibiting its development, and even threatening its survival. Although there is no consensus about the real effects of certain drugs on the lives of individuals and social groups, drug addiction still should be regarded as a global problem whose scope covers the macro- and mega-structures. As Charles W. Mills rightly pointed out,

‘problems are associated with issues that exceed than the local environment of individuals and the scope of their inner lives. [...] A problem is a public issue; a value having public importance is considered to be threatened. Discussions on what value actually is and what threatens it are common. These discussions often lack precision, if only because [...] the very nature of the problem means that it cannot be clearly defined in terms of the nearest, everyday environment of an ordinary individual’.⁴¹²

Drug addiction, as a global problem, consists of a plurality of specific problems. Among the most dangerous, we should note four basic ones. Firstly, deaths resulting from overdose, substance abuse-related illness, fatal poisonings, and suicides. Mortality among drug addicts is 20 times higher than that of the general population. The death rate is 1-2%, which translates to 10-20 thousands yearly. In the previous decade, the most deaths was reported sequentially in the UK, Germany and Italy (in Poland it is close to 200 per year). According to estimates by the World Health Organization, drugs cause the death of 1.2 million people annually; statistically more men than women die and 35 is the average age.⁴¹³ Secondly, drug-related infectious diseases (especially connected to the intravenous drug use) and drug addicts’ lifestyle diseases (risky sexual behaviours, poor hygiene, high sanitary risk further raised by exchanging infected needles or syringes, poor living conditions – living in shelters, serving time in prison). Especially dangerous are: AIDS, sexually transmitted diseases, hepatitis B and C, and mental illness (which is often a side effect of bodily damage caused by substance abuse). Psychiatric

⁴¹² C.W. Mills, *Obietnica*, [in:] P. Sztompka, M. Kucia (eds), *Socjologia. Lektury*, Kraków 2005, p. 14.

⁴¹³ <http://who.int> [18.12.2014].

problems were diagnosed in 40-80% of drug addicts;⁴¹⁴ usually personality disorders, dysphoria, endogenous and exogenous psychoses, and depression are reported. Thirdly, crimes including a number of activities (theft, robberies, murders, rapes) and the resulting pathologies, such as prostitution, corruption, gambling. Drugs are criminogenic, due to the fact that the drug underworld is characterized by a complete denial of recognized norms and values of the general society. In the case of breaching the ethical and moral attitudes, the strength of social control generally decreases, resulting in a gross violation of social order, whose maintenance is necessary for the survival of the society. The fourth basic problem is narcobusiness involving illicit production and trafficking of psychoactive substances. Despite the institutionalized war against smuggling and distribution of drugs at a national, European, and international level, it is still one of the most profitable businesses. The illegal drug market is constantly expanding: new trafficking routes are created, transnational organized crime is growing, there are new communication technologies that facilitate the distribution of drugs and drug tourism.

The problem of drug abuse is spreading in society. According to the World Report on Drugs, the number of abusers of illicit substances in the world amounts to 185 million, which represents 3% of the global population or 4.7% of the population in the 15 to 64 age group. This number is likely to continue to grow. Analysing the amount of consumed drugs, the largest consumption is reported in the case of hemp (marijuana and hashish), followed by: amphetamine type stimulants (including ecstasy), opiates (heroin, morphine, opium, synthetic opiates), cocaine.⁴¹⁵ These data illustrate the tremendous scope and scale of the phenomenon. It goes without saying that it is dangerous, causes damage and dysfunctions. Therefore, drug addiction should continuously be a subject of in-depth and specialized analyses, whose purpose is to recognize the problem and reduce the adverse effects of this phenomenon. There are special governmental and non-governmental institutions established to limit the incidence in numbers and areas it covers, however the most important in this

⁴¹⁴ <http://poradnia-monar.pl>, [18.12.2014].

⁴¹⁵ http://unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/WDR2012/WDR_2012_web_small.pdf, [18.12.2014].

struggle is to change the awareness of the general public. Herbert Blumer argued that an issue causes the need for corrective action if it finds its place in the social consciousness.⁴¹⁶ Only when the society becomes aware of the existence and importance of a problem, it can create a plan and take effective measures to correct the problem.

AFTERWORD

We can point to a number of, coupled together, causes for drug addiction. The phenomenon is often combined with poverty, prostitution, social marginalization, dysfunctional operation of rehabilitation and penal institutions, negligence in terms of socialization and education. It is reasonable to connect the problem to the socio-economic situation of the state and the ensuing pathologies, such as homelessness, unemployment, alcoholism, prostitution, violence, and crime. Nonetheless, it must be emphasized that drug addiction – like every other social problem – is a social product and only the society is able to solve it, with will and determination.

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⁴¹⁶ Based on: M.K. Mlicki, op. cit., p. 12.

Miś L., *Teoria socjologiczna a praktyka rozwiązywania problemów społecznych*, [in:] M. Malinkowski (ed.), *Problemy społeczne w okresie zmian systemowych w Polsce*, Rzeszów 1997.

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BOREDOM, EXISTENTIAL EMPTINESS AND FRUSTRATION, THAT IS SUFFERING AS A SOURCE OF ADDICTION

*The humanity of those who suffer is overwhelmed by the evil that rends it, otherwise than by non-freedom: violently and cruelly, more irremissibly than the negation that dominates or paralyzes the act in non-freedom*⁴¹⁷

The phenomenon of suffering refers to harm and, in the Western style of thinking, Kant's paradigm proclaiming that 'suffering and pleasure as emotional states are the domain of experience' prevails.⁴¹⁸ Władysław Tatarkiewicz stressed that the human life is characterized by tragism, and thus suffering that life is finite, that at some point we and our loved ones cease to exist.

'People are crying over the death of others, rather than on their own; It is however, the own death, that weights over their lives. Death of others may be a disaster, own death is a tragedy. The tragedy consists of fear of the end, of nothingness or the unknown, attachment to the well-known'.⁴¹⁹

The irremovability of suffering is linked to the feeling of unhappiness that besets the person when a loved one dies. They are overpowered by existential emptiness and meaninglessness of all activities. They feel internally disfigured, confused, passive, powerless. Barbara Chyrowicz in her article titled 'Understanding Pain And Suffering', argued that nobody is

⁴¹⁷ E. Levinas, *Useless Suffering*, [in:] *Entre Nous Thinking of the Other*, trans. M. B. Smith, B. Harshav, New York 1998, p. 92.

⁴¹⁸ W. Wilowski, *Metafizyka cierpienia*, Poznań 2010, p. 33; I. Kant, *Krytyka praktycznego rozumu*, trans. J. Gałęcki, Warszawa 1984, p. 101.

⁴¹⁹ W. Tatarkiewicz, *Tragedie i tragizm*, [in:] Arystoteles, D. Hume, M. Scheler, *O tragedii i tragiczności*, trans. W. Tatarkiewicz, T. Tatarkiewiczowa, R. Ingarden, Kraków 1976, p. 21.

able to adequately describe the phenomenon of suffering, for it is an extremely difficult experience. It is associated with emotional costs that are incurred just because of the suffering, which is why people often prefer to remain silent than to externalize their wounds, shame, and excruciating pain.⁴²⁰

‘The experience of suffering is not fully transferable, a philosopher would say that it is not intersubjectively communicable. So when we consider the possibility of understanding, we must first realize that the problem of suffering is not possible to be rationalized’.⁴²¹

The author also draws attention to the fact that we should distinguish suffering from pain. Pain as such can be explained and rationalized, while the range of suffering is vague; severe pain causes suffering, hence pain is felt, and suffering is experienced.⁴²² Viktor Emil Frankl – an, ignored in the psychoanalytic environment, Jewish psychotherapist of the existential orientation, drew attention of the contemporary psychologists to the cognitive aspect of suffering. One of its main ideas states that the concept of suffering connects to the pain, and more importantly has an ethical and axiological dimension. This assumption is well illustrated by the fact that when an individual suffers, there is also a feeling of mental or physical lacking. We can deduce it from the obvious fact that we feel limited by our upbringing, physicality, and intellectual qualities. Thus, we are overwhelmed by the feeling of lacking and weakness.

‘Suffering derails us from normality, of that to which we have become accustomed, which we consciously or unconsciously accepted as our stable reality. We begin to understand that it can and must be differently, that relationships and systems are fragile; may change, sometimes to our disadvantage. We begin to see facts that escaped our attention.

⁴²⁰ B. Chyrowicz, *Zrozumieć ból i cierpienie*, [in:] A. Bartoszek (ed.), *W poszukiwaniu sensu cierpienia. Dialog interdyscyplinarny*, Katowice 2006, p. 89.

⁴²¹ Ibidem, p. 90.

⁴²² Ibidem, p. 91.

We begin to see the reality around us and in ourselves differently, in a new way. we associate its elements and judge them in a new way'.⁴²³

According to Frankl on the stage of human life, suffering is not only possible, but necessary, as it is a result of the inevitable consequences of our anchoring in the social and biological reality. It sets this aspect of human existence with which we are never able to deal; it lowers our self-efficacy, self-determination, and finally can lead to disintegration of the self (understood as the sense of one's self). When we suffer physically, we often blame the people around us or external circumstances for it. Although it affects each of us individually, its meaning is generally difficult to explain within the intellectual categories. The power of its constructive and destructive impact is better be explained intuitively.

Suffering is often unannounced. Its comes in 'crashing through the door' and we never quite know where it will take us. We are not able to define its power and our approach to it is often characterized by a lack of distance and, as a result, it takes control over our whole psycho-physical structure. Suffering, according to Viktor Emil Frankl, is multidimensional; specifically, it links to three existential dimensions. In his therapeutical concept, the Viennese psychopathologist points to the somatic, psychological, and the most important one, spiritual dimension. In this regard, physical space is associated with various physical diseases or mental disasters. And although at first glance psychological suffering seems to us the most difficult, it is this space, among all the possible sufferings befalling us, that presents the deepest dimension. Namely, he describes direct experiencing of psychic pain, in the face of which we feel completely helpless.⁴²⁴ Mental suffering appears here as a phenomenon fundamentally different from physical pain. It overcomes us when our existential expectations are not met. It is a result of loneliness, bitterness, disappointment, outrage, and a sense of lack of social acceptance. It is accompanied by insecurity, arousing fear and the feeling of being lost.

⁴²³ S. Sawicki, *Myśli o sztuce i cierpieniu*, <http://miesiecznik.znak.com.pl/archiwumcyfrowe/90s/1991/435.pdf>, pp. 72–77 [05.04.2014].

⁴²⁴ See: V. E. Frankl, *Homo Patiens*, trans. R. Czernecki, Z. J. Jaroszewski, Warszawa 1984.

Often it manifests itself in our experience when we lose something valuable and important in life, when interpersonal communication fails, and misunderstandings and understatements take its place.

Frankl emphasized that in addition to somatic and psychological layers of suffering, there is also the spiritual, or noetic, layer. Fear of rejection, lack of life purpose, a sense of unfulfilled existential possibilities, or lack of hope and faith in future can serve as examples. We deal with this form of suffering when we lose something that has been giving us a sense of accomplishment and satisfaction. Längle in his article, 'Suffering As An Existential Challenge' argued that these three dimensions should be accompanied by a fourth one – the dynamic, that is existential, dimension.⁴²⁵ Existential suffering arises when an individual experiences frustration caused by confrontation with the world. It is accompanied by futility, resulting from a lack of understanding of their own existence, their own actions of everyday life, resulting from a string of failures or simply a lack of professional success, which, in the private sphere, leads to a sense of inner desolation and mental lability, and above all to addiction.

In most human life situations suffering is a destructive force. In modern times, it is particularly provoked by the cult of success and career achieved at any cost, bringing ubiquitous mental and spiritual chaos, resulting in the desire to forget and more frequent recourse to psychoactive substances, drugs, and alcohol. Mass culture craves health, subjective beauty and incessant self-gratification, at the same time it does not tolerate suffering and tribulations as necessary internal life situations. Yet, without suffering at all our life would not be possible. It is a symptom that something in life is changing, that is, for example, our physical, mental, or spiritual balance is compromised and ultimately a threat reveals itself. Psychology presupposes that suffering is universal and inevitable. The founder of psychoanalysis Sigmund Freud saw suffering in the 'power of nature, the fragility of human flesh, and imperfections of organizational structures'.⁴²⁶ The German philosopher Karl Jaspers referred

⁴²⁵ A. Längle, *Suffering existential challenge*, [in:] J. Jaworski, A. Rusak, W. Simon (eds), *The face of suffering*, Płock 2004, pp. 219–235.

⁴²⁶ S. Freud, *Kultura jako źródło cierpień*, trans. Jerzy Prokopiuk, Warszawa 1995, p. 258.

the presence of suffering in human life to border situations.⁴²⁷ Frankl treated suffering as part of the 'death – suffering – blame' triad. In his publication *Man's Search for Meaning*, he stressed that death and blame are indelible components of the human existence. The creator of logotherapy wanted us to develop a certain distanced attitude towards fate, which will allow us to pass through a period of suffering in a constructive way. Frankl, in the 'Metaclinical Explanation of the Meaning of Suffering' subsection of his *Homo Patiens* paper, examined the fact that, in the aspect of suffering, we can adopt a specific survival attitude. Values associated with the attitude to certain tragic situation are not set in stone. They rise in specific situations and this is when an individual learns to suffer.⁴²⁸ Most people realize unconsciously that suffering has a hidden meaning. The Viennese psychotherapist gives an example of *melancholia anaesthetica*. The patient suffering from this type of depression did not feel emotion, being in a state of dispassion and apathy.⁴²⁹

'When a man finds that it is his destiny to suffer, he will have to accept his suffering as his task; his single and unique task. He will have to acknowledge the fact that even in suffering he is unique and alone in the universe. No one can relieve him of his suffering or suffer in his place. His unique opportunity lies in the way in which he bears his burden'.⁴³⁰

The point here is to transpose the fact that a disease is imposed at a higher level. Therefore, according to Frankl, suffering also can bring a form of maturity. Frankl himself went through the terror of a concentration camp. In this perspective, maturity means that an individual acquires inner freedom, no matter the shackles of the external environment and the pressure

⁴²⁷ See: K. Jaspers, *Filozofia egzystencji*, trans. D. Lachowska, A. Wołkowicz, Warszawa 1990.

⁴²⁸ V. E. Frankl, *Homo Patiens*, op. cit., p. 69.

⁴²⁹ Ibidem, p. 70.

⁴³⁰ V. E. Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning: An Introduction To Logotherapy*, <http://streetschool.co.za/wp-content/uploads/2014/07/Viktor-Emil-Frankl-Mans-Search-for-Meaning.pdf>, p. 38. [03.01.2015].

of consequences.⁴³¹ Extreme situations can bring a person to spiritual maturity. Because of that, Frankl refers to a logotherapeutic technique used to free patients from neuroses and addiction:

'A realistic fear, like the fear of death, cannot be tranquilized away by its psychodynamic interpretation; on the other hand, a neurotic fear, such as agoraphobia, cannot be cured by philosophical understanding. However, logotherapy has developed a special technique to handle such cases, too. To understand what is going on whenever this technique is used, we take as a starting point a condition which is frequently observed in neurotic individuals, namely, anticipatory anxiety. It is characteristic of this fear that it produces precisely that of which the patient is afraid. An individual, for example, who is afraid of blushing when he enters a large room and faces many people will actually be more prone to blush under these circumstances. In this context, one might amend the saying "The wish is father to the thought" to "The fear is mother of the event".'⁴³²

Speaking about the category of suffering, we should realize that it permeates all spheres of humanity, and that the human being ultimately comes down to suffering. The truth, for the Austrian thinker, is also of procedural character, so it should be pursued beyond the categories of good and evil. It is about affirming the suffering, being aware of the fact that experiencing its manifestations often requires huge courage. Therefore, we cannot agree with pure escapism as a form of avoiding existential pain. Frankl here proposed a postulate of living according to the rule: *Primum philosophari, deinde Mori*. It is not about the primacy of reason and discursive thinking, but about the primacy of philosophy, which is derived from the essence of each individual.⁴³³ Existence consistent with the sense of purpose is related to acceptance of the inevitability of suffering.

⁴³¹ Ibidem, p. 75.

⁴³² V. E. Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning...*, op. cit., p. 55.

⁴³³ V. E. Frankl, *Homo Patiens*, op. cit., p. 84.

‘The realization of values connected to attitude is basically realization of the sense which can bring unavoidable suffering’.⁴³⁴ [trans. Marta Kuźba]

Frankl distinguished two destructive attitudes that distort the image of suffering. These are the escapist and masochistic attitudes. The first one compulsively wants to escape from all forms of suffering, the other is related to its unnecessary search. Escapist individuals are characterized by sentimentality, and masochists by martyrdom.⁴³⁵

Describing the above attitude, Frankl refers to the thought of the phenomenologist Max Scheler. Changing the unpleasantness into a hedonistic experience is the essence of the masochistic attitude. Both of these feelings are random, which is why they are not related to the sphere of intentionality. The escapist as well views the suffering as the goal, life’s passive foundation, without the possibility of progress.⁴³⁶

‘Suffering can be called intentional when it concern value and meaning. Maybe it would be better to turn to the sufferer. Then the place of masochism is taken by autism, and meaning and value reflectively turn towards each other’.⁴³⁷
[trans. Marta Kuźba]

People presenting their suffering to the public eye are characterized by a kind of egotism and exhibitionism. Individuals truly suffering do not throw their pain before others. ‘Chatter does not become sufferers, they should rather remain silent; real suffering is always quiet’.⁴³⁸ Values in the opinion of the German phenomenologist Scheler are objective, independent of our will. We can however destroy them by negating their essence. Here we are dealing with the phenomenon of tragedy. Tragedy is born when we allow removing values from the field of our consciousness and experience.

⁴³⁴ Ibidem.

⁴³⁵ Ibidem, p. 85.

⁴³⁶ Ibidem, p. 85.

⁴³⁷ Ibidem, p. 86.

⁴³⁸ Ibidem.

Frankl said that all kinds of suffering, from physical sensations to spiritual-religious pain, have some sense.⁴³⁹ Suffering is a kind of sacrificing what seems to us to be less valuable in favour of something that is relatively more valuable.⁴⁴⁰ Often it means avoiding evil of a higher order. However, not all are able to bear the consequences of this state of affairs. Here we can reflect on the contemporary, post-modern understanding of suffering as a form of escaping the joys of everyday life. The concept of happiness is also commonly associated with reduction of suffering.

According to Viktor Emil Frankl, we should raise the matter of sexuality and sex addiction. The Viennese psychotherapist emphasized repeatedly that only love can humanize sex, and progressive pornographizing of the culture leads to spiritual suffering and emotional numbness. A Frankl's student, Eugenio Fizzotti, called this contemporary phenomenon the 'dance of golden pig', because the development of the porn industry is taking on a staggering momentum. We live in a period in which great emphasis is put on the commercialization and trivialization of sexuality. The alternative film industry presents this problem in a clear and vulgarized manner. When we look at the psychological drama *Shame*, directed by Steve McQueen, we will find a clear analogy to the Austrian psychiatrist's 'subtle' diagnosis. The main character shamefully caught in a web of libidinal needs cannot deal with the sense of his own impotence, which leads to a sense of failure. We meet here a post-sexual demand to immediately satisfy one's basic instincts, which does not go hand in hand with the desire for intimacy and closeness. Building a relationship with another person requires commitment and a sense of responsibility, which is associated with temporary slowness and patience. Fizzotti stresses that sexuality has been dehumanized and reduced to the role of a means to satisfy human biological needs. People look to discharge sexual tension and they see the other person as an organ designed to help lower the

⁴³⁹ M. Scheler, *Cierpienie, śmierć, dalsze życie. Pisma wybrane*, trans. A. Węgrzecki, Warszawa 1994, p. 30.

⁴⁴⁰ Ibidem, pp. 12–13.

drive. Pleasure is momentary, fleeting, quickly passing away, because it lacks a personal aspect.⁴⁴¹

As we can see, according to current existential thinkers, we witness a disintegration and inflation of the realm of sexuality. It has to do with the popular statement that our behaviour is completely conditioned by our animal nature and instincts. It is false. While we agree with the statement by Frankl that sexual practices are rooted in existential emptiness, we come to the important conclusion that people moving on the superficial pane of social integration eventually collide with a sense of spiritual suffering. Georges Bataille in his publication *Eroticism* stated that purely erotic behaviours drown people in solitude.⁴⁴² And it is not about an inalienable, ontological loneliness of each individual, but about loneliness resulting from the inability of a human being to meet and resonate with the essence of another human being. Frankl talked about three levels of development of human sexuality:

‘At first it seems as libido, oriented only toward relaxation and defusion; the libido gets the purpose – stimulus, and then on a base of human love, gets an object – stimulus. Those who experienced repressions during psychosexual development, stay on the level of instinct. Before they were consummates of the prostitution, and now they are consummates of confusion. However, there where is no purpose – stimulus. What stays is a libido; oriented toward relaxation and defusion, in society occur cases of masturbation and consumption of pornography’⁴⁴³ [trans. Marta Kuźba].

Frankl emphasized that the state of culture requires all to restructure and rehumanise the concept of love. The point here is that we should realize that the optimal sexual development is based on a proper integration of the sexual aspect with the holistic dimension of personality. If, unconsciously, an individual is stuck in a ‘tangle of sexual vipers’, it might lead

⁴⁴¹ E. Fizzotti, *Aby być wolnym. Logoterapia na co dzień*, trans. Konrad Czuba, Kielce 2006, p. 29.

⁴⁴² G. Bataille, *Erotyzm*, trans. M. Ochab, Gdańsk 2007, p. 246.

⁴⁴³ E. Fizzotti, op. cit., p. 29.

them to existential emptiness, suffering associated with a lack of personal dimension of human relationships. Frankl in his book *Man's Search for Meaning* points out that the place of frustrated will of sense may be taken by a hedonistic will, since existential frustration often is compensated with compulsive sexual behaviour. Therefore, we can talk about a close correlation of lewd libido and existential emptiness.⁴⁴⁴

Here we should refer to one of the most famous existential psychologists, Rollo May. The American thinker was drawing on the concept of suffering created by Viktor Emil Frankl. He identified modern suffering with the overvaluation of the concept of love. May created the concept of the 'New Puritanism' which means negation of the essence of the Victorian concept of love. People from the Victorian era wanted love without the sexual aspect, nowadays people prefer sex without commitment. Puritanism in lowercase is characterized by three elements: the first concerns physical alienation, the second one oscillates around separating emotion from reason, and the third component treats the body as a mechanism.⁴⁴⁵ The so-called modern puritans approach the aspect of sexuality in a mechanistic way. Personal dimension of emotionality in this approach is completely destroyed by sexual techniques. They actually believe that inhibition of sexual desire is immoral.⁴⁴⁶ May also introduces a category of the 'modern sophist' to denote the postmodern relation to sexuality. The hedonistic sophist treats the body and sex as instruments that should be continuously polished. The modern sophist avoids intimacy, seeking solace in alcohol. They love others as long as they can be selfishly used, which destroys any intimacy and passion.⁴⁴⁷

As we can see, the progressive alienation of sexuality deprives the language of specifically human traits. Instead of sleeping together people copulate with each other, which leads to dehumanisation and reification of human relations, while they should be holy and intimate. Riesman in his *Lonely Crowd* emphasized that sexual behaviours are the last step. That means people psychoidally use each other to confirm their own self-

⁴⁴⁴ V. E. Frankl, *Człowiek w poszukiwaniu sensu*, trans. A. Wolnicka, Warszawa 2009, p. 162.

⁴⁴⁵ R. May, *Miłość i wola*, trans. H. Śpiewak, P. Śpiewak Poznań 1998, p. 42

⁴⁴⁶ Ibidem.

⁴⁴⁷ Ibidem, p. 43.

esteem and, seemingly, to find their lost identity. ⁴⁴⁸Gerald Sykes said that 'the world turned gray from market reports, time adjustment, taxes, laboratory analyzes, only sex turned out to be still susceptible to rebellion'⁴⁴⁹. Humans become mainly other-directed, tarnished with occasional stimuli, cannot drive an internal dialogue with themselves, therefore there is a sense of emptiness, and thus there is suffering. Of course, we cannot overcome the ontological suffering resulting from ontological loneliness. However, we can try to coexist with each other. May shreds into pieces the postmodern interactional term. Interpersonal relations in the postmodern world are not subjective any more, but began to be objective. We often use such expressions as 'go to bed with somebody' or 'sleep together' rather than 'make love'.⁴⁵⁰

Therefore, those without any involvement become schizoid, superficial, lacking deep interpersonal contacts. No significant relationships is compensated by manic, objectified, momentary copulations. Viktor Emil Frankl in his book *Psychotherapy For Everyone* strongly emphasized that the above lifestyle results in leading a makeshift existence.

We are beings of suffering – this is the ultimate axiom served to us by the Viennese thinker. We suffer from our own limitations, undervaluation, lack of financial stability. Suffering appears to us as an inseparable attribute of existence. Suffering individuals should be aware of the fact that if there was not any momentary despair in their existence, it would be more difficult to comprehend the issue relating to the sense of satisfaction and deriving joy from everyday life. Do we deal here with trivializing the concept of suffering? We should emphasise finally, that it is by suffering, and not martyrdom, human beings have the opportunity to build their identity, change the paradigm of their behaviour, and above all, find the awaited sense.

⁴⁴⁸ Ibidem, p. 57.

⁴⁴⁹ Ibidem.

⁴⁵⁰ Ibidem, p. 58.

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THE VIEWS OF JUNIOR HIGH SCHOOL STUDENTS ON THE PSYCHOSOCIAL DETERMINANTS OF PSYCHOACTIVE SUBSTANCE USE

INTRODUCTION

The issue of psychoactive substance use as a topic in the field of psychopathology has long been a subject of interest in clinical psychology. The currently dominant approach in psychology of disorders primarily focuses on the so-called problematic (continued or chronic) use of psychoactive substances resulting in significant disruption of psychosocial functioning of the individual. Disorders resulting from long-term, regular substance use, according to current health care classification systems (ICD-10 / *International Classification of Disease*,⁴⁵¹ DSM V / *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders*⁴⁵²) consist of two categories, i.e. 'substance abuse' and 'substance dependence'. The term 'abuse' of psychoactive substances refers to the relatively constant pattern in the use of these substances, as well as the resulting risky behaviours and occupational, social, and health problems. The category of psychoactive substance dependence is treated as a more acute clinical entity with clear symptoms of social maladjustment and specific diagnostic criteria, such as the presence of the withdrawal syndrome or tolerance to the substance.⁴⁵³

Most psychological studies on the use of psychoactive substances focus around the issues of abuse and dependence. Research in this area covers

⁴⁵¹ World Health Organization, . *International Statistical Classification of Diseases and Related Health Problems 10th Revision*, Geneva 2014.

⁴⁵² American Psychiatric Association, *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (5th edition)*, Washington DC, 2013.

⁴⁵³ R. C. Carson, J. N. Butcher, S. Mineka, *Psychologia zaburzeń*, Gdańsk 2003, vol.1, pp. 552–553.

a wide spectrum ranging from epidemiological studies showing the prevalence of problematic use of psychoactive drugs in the population taking into account specific socio-demographic characteristics to determining factors that influence the effectiveness of treatment. The search for psychological correlates (such as poor control of behaviour, impulsivity, and low behavioural inhibition) associated with a tendency to use psychoactive substances is another important area. The use of 'disinhibition' and 'externalizing spectrum' constructs to explain the etiology of addiction is an example of this type of analysis.⁴⁵⁴

Studies on episodic substance use, which is not seen as a purely pathological phenomenon, are less numerous. This form of consuming psychoactive substances applies to the situation of single or sporadic and occasional use. The studies on such forms of psychoactive substance use focus mainly on factors (personality, motivation, cognition, development) that increase the probability of initiating drug use or irregular consumption of intoxicants. Research on the sense of coherence and risks of psychoactive substance use in adolescents is an example of this type of analysis.⁴⁵⁵

Studies dealing with social perception and evaluation of psychoactive substance use can be treated as a separate category of research. Authors exploring public perception of drug-related issues focus on the analysis of conventional wisdom, beliefs, and attitudes towards psychoactive substances. In this approach, the main objective of the research is to seek answers to, among others, the following questions: What do people know about drugs? What are the common beliefs, views, or myths on psychoactive substances? Does the type of intoxicant of choice affect social perception and evaluation of its users? How do cultural and socio-demographic (e.g. gender, age, education, and place of residence) factors impact the attitudes toward substance use and users? Studies on the public's perception of substance use are based on the concepts developed in social psychology (attitudes, conventional wisdom, beliefs, convictions). On the

⁴⁵⁴ R. F. Krueger et al., *Etiologic connections among substance dependence, antisocial behavior and personality: Modeling the externalizing spectrum*, 'Journal of Abnormal Psychology', 2002, 111, pp. 411–424.

⁴⁵⁵ K. Bobrowski, *Poczucie koherencji oraz inne zasoby odpornościowe a zażywanie substancji psychoaktywnych przez młodzież*, 'Alkoholizm i narkomania', 2002, 2:15, pp. 221–240.

other hand, due to their complex nature, these studies require the support of other psychology subdisciplines (e.g. developmental psychology) as well as non-psychological branches of science, like sociology or anthropology.

Among relatively few Polish publications on the social perception of the drug use phenomenon, the data presented in the National Bureau for Drug Prevention report seem interesting. According to the review of the studies on this topic that was carried out by the report's authors, the attitudes of young people towards drug users and towards the use of psychoactive substances are characterized by:

- differences in the level of approval / disapproval depend on the type of the drug in question (e.g. positive evaluations of marijuana and negative attitudes towards brown sugar heroin);
- generally negative evaluation of peers using drugs;
- differences resulting from the subjects' own experiences with drugs and from opinions of their friends and family on substance use.⁴⁵⁶

According to the data presented in the report, knowledge on psychoactive substances among adolescents, despite being prevalent, is incomplete and not detailed (the knowledge of names of various drugs is not accompanied by the ability to differentiate their effects). Moreover, it presents some of the myths and false, popular opinions on the drug- and addiction-related risks.⁴⁵⁷

The research carried out by the author of this paper refers to the data presented in the above-mentioned report and has been designed as a kind of the report's complement. A need for this type of analysis arose also due to the fact that relatively few publications on social beliefs about substance use can be found in the psychological literature on the subject. In this project, the term 'view' has been conceptualized as a part of human consciousness, an opinion based on ambiguous evidence and considered by the individual to be true.⁴⁵⁸ A general, preliminary characterization of

⁴⁵⁶ E. Stępień (ed.), *Psychospołeczne korelaty używania narkotyków wśród młodzieży. Przegląd badań z lat 1997–2002*, <http://kbpn.gov.pl/portaal?id=105978>, [29.12.2014].

⁴⁵⁷ E. Stępień, op. cit., pp. 8–9.

⁴⁵⁸ A.M. Colman, *Oxford Dictionary of Psychology*, Oxford, 2009, p. 85.

high school students' views on the use of psychoactive substances in terms of its psychosocial determinants perceived by the subjects was the primary aim of the study. An exploratory nature of the analysis was adopted. The subjects – individuals in early adolescence – were chosen due to the data suggesting that this is the age of the first contact with drugs. Therefore, we assumed that because of direct or indirect (social environment, friends) experiments with drugs, young people – junior high school students – should have already clearly defined beliefs on the causes of psychoactive substances consumption and people reaching for them.

THE METHOD

Randomly selected junior high school students participated in the study. A total of 104 individuals aged 13-15 took part, including 51 girls and 53 boys. The research was preceded by appropriate pilot studies (N=30), which made it possible to construct the final version of the research tool. The task of the participants was to provide answers to open questions to measure the respondents' views in four aspects:

1. the causes of psychoactive substance use;
2. social characteristics of substance users;
3. psychological characteristics of substance users;
4. resilience factors influencing the decision to consume a drug or refrain from it.

Test-takers were asked questions about four different psychoactive substances: marijuana, amphetamines, designer drugs, and alcohol. The content of questions placed the respondents into four groups according to the type of the psychoactive substance. This resulted in the following types of questions corresponding to the examined aspects:

1. 'Why do you think people smoke marijuana / use amphetamine / take designer drugs / drink alcohol?'
2. 'Do you think that certain persons or group of people are particularly susceptible to the use of marijuana / amphetamine / designer drugs /

alcohol? If so, who uses marijuana / amphetamine / designer drugs / alcohol?’

3. ‘Are there any certain character traits that make someone prone to using marijuana / amphetamine / designer drugs / alcohol? If so, what are those traits?’
4. ‘What do you think prevents people from using marijuana / amphetamine / designer drugs / alcohol?’

The responses were classified, giving results for each of the questions as follows: 1 (reasons) – 7 categories, 2 (social characteristics) – 11 categories, 3 (psychological characteristics) – 12 categories, 4 (protective factors) – 11 categories. In every question, among the distinguished categories, not answering and giving an evasive or provocative answer – indicating youthful negativity and irreverent attitude to the study – were taken into consideration.

RESULTS

The obtained data were then developed by comparing the response rate in each category. The results of the research on the views of junior high school students on the psychosocial determinants of drug use will be presented for each of the studied aspects.

1. Causes of psychoactive substance use:
 - a. featured categories: mood enhancement, reaction to the problems of life, self-presentation, curiosity / experimenting, physical effects of the substance, provocative or evasive answer, no answer;
 - b. the most often mentioned categories⁴⁵⁹ (percentage of answers falling into the category):
 - amphetamine: self-presentation (48%), mood enhancement (34%), reaction to the problems (31%),
 - marijuana: reaction to the problems (52%), mood enhancement (40%), self-presentation (36%),
 - designer drugs: self-presentation (42%), reaction to the problems (33%), physical effects (29%), mood enhancement (25%),

⁴⁵⁹ The results are reported with the exception of the ‘no answer’ category.

- alcohol: reaction to the problems (78%), mood enhancement (39%), physical effects (17%), self-presentation (17%).
2. Social characteristics of psychoactive substance users:
 - a. featured categories: those in a difficult situation, the adolescent, subculture members, young adults / students, people with low self-control, thrill-seekers, those pushed by their social environment, other than the above-mentioned, no answer, no differentiation ('all' or 'none' response), evasive and provocative answers;
 - b. the most often mentioned categories (percentage of answers falling into the category):
 - amphetamine: the adolescent (17%), people with low self-control (14%), those in a difficult situation (14%),
 - marijuana: those in a difficult situation (28%), the adolescent (24%), young adults (20%), thrill-seekers (16%), those pushed by their social environment (16%),
 - designer drugs: the adolescent (25%), and evasive responses (25%), other, e.g. athletes (21%),
 - -alcohol: those in a difficult situation (39%), all (17%), those pushed by their social environment (13%).
 3. Psychological characteristics of psychoactive substance users:
 - a. featured categories: need for social approval, poor impulse control, avoidance coping, lack of assertiveness, recklessness, depression, neurosis, low self-esteem, other than the above-mentioned, no traits connected to using drugs, no answer, evasive and provocative answers;
 - b. the most often mentioned categories (percentage of answers falling into the category):
 - amphetamine: lack of assertiveness (31%), and avoidance coping (14%), recklessness (10%),
 - marijuana: lack of assertiveness (20%), need for social approval (16%), avoidance coping (12%), poor impulse control (12%),
 - designer drugs: need for social approval (25%), evasive answer (21%), lack of assertiveness (17%),
 - alcohol: lack of assertiveness (31%), avoidance coping (17%), poor impulse control (13%).

4. Resilience factors:
- a. featured categories: family / friends / partner, negative public opinion, awareness of negative effects, lack of availability, money, fear of detection, other than the above-mentioned, no resilience factors, no answer, evasive and provocative answers;
 - b. the most often mentioned categories (percentage of answers falling into the category):
 - amphetamine: awareness of negative effects (21%), evasive and provocative answers (17%), other (e.g. someone's support, disgust, 17%), negative public opinion (14%),
 - marijuana: family / friends / partner (36%), awareness of negative effects (28%), common sense (16%),
 - designer drugs: awareness of negative effects (42%), family / friends / partner (25%), evasive and provocative responses (13%), other (e.g. luck, 13%),
 - alcohol: family / friends / partner (43%), awareness of negative effects (30%), assertiveness (22%).

ANALYSIS AND CONCLUSIONS

Comparing the distribution of responses in the four analysed aspects allowed to point to certain similarities among the views of the young people, depending on the substance in question. When it comes to causes of amphetamine and designer drugs use, according to junior high school students, those referring to the desire to present oneself in a favourable light among the peers were most often mentioned. A slightly different pattern of response was observed in the case of marijuana and alcohol, where dealing with life's problems and improving mood and well-being were the most often justifications for using these substances. With respect to the views of the respondents regarding social characteristics of people who use psychoactive substances, the most commonly mentioned risk groups were adolescents (amphetamine and designer drugs) and those in a difficult situation (marijuana and alcohol). The analysis of views on psychological characteristics of psychoactive substance users has shown, however, that low assertiveness is a distinctive trait of people who use these substances according to junior high school students. That response

was the most common for questions related to amphetamine, marijuana, and alcohol. Finally, the participants recognized knowledge about the negative effects of substance use (amphetamine, designer drugs) and a restraining influence of family, friends, or partner (marijuana, alcohol) as the most important resilience factors that reduce the probability of alcohol and drug initiation.

In three out of four of the assessed substance use factors (causes, social characteristics, resilience), a similar response pattern occurring most frequently in relation to, respectively: 1) amphetamine and designer drugs and 2) marijuana and alcohol, was visible. An analysis of the response patterns in the most popular categories indicates a certain convergence of views when it comes to the substances in two separate pairs: amphetamine – designer drugs and marijuana – alcohol.

The similarity of views on amphetamine and designer drugs may suggest that these substances are treated as a single, broad, and undifferentiated category. It is possible that a significant part of junior high school students sees both psychoactive substances in a similar way, giving them the same 'conceptual label'. This explanation is consistent with the results of research on the knowledge of young people about drugs. According to these data, adolescents divide psychoactive substances into three groups.⁴⁶⁰ The first one includes marijuana, treated as not particularly harmful or dangerous intoxicant. The second group contains various types of synthetic substances (including amphetamine), perceived as proper drugs, the use of which poses some risk of addiction. The last, the most negatively evaluated group, includes injection drugs (heroin), considered as leading to drug addiction and social degeneration. The observable convergence of views on amphetamine and designer drugs seems to confirm the existence of such a division.

The similarities in response patterns between the views concerning the factors in marijuana and alcohol use may indicate similarity in the assessment and attitude of young people towards this type of psychoactive substances. According to the above-mentioned studies by Fatyga and

⁴⁶⁰ B. Fatyga, J. Sierosławski, *Uczniowie i nauczyciele o stylach młodzieży i narkotykach. Raport z badań jakościowych*, 'Serwis Informacyjny. Narkomania', 1999, 2 (11).

Sierosławski, marijuana is treated by adolescents rather as a substance not posing any serious health, psychological, and social threats. The belief that smoking marijuana poses little threat is connected to the general attitude of greater tolerance for the use of this type of drug. The similarity of views on marijuana and alcohol presented by the respondents may suggest that for at least a part of the junior high school students, the use of both substances (of which one is penalized) is equally acceptable. Given that the need to improve one's mood and well-being was one of the two most common reasons provided by the respondents to reach for marijuana and alcohol, it can be assumed that, in the opinion of junior high school students, the use of such substances for this purpose is considered acceptable and is not judged so negatively as it is with other drugs.

The research described in this paper was preliminary and exploratory in character only. An attempt to broadly present the nature of views on factors determining substance use in a specific age group was the aim of the author. The results should therefore be regarded only as a prelude to further, more in-depth analysis. However, considering the practical use of the data, it appears that they can be helpful in designing drug prevention programs for youth. Psychoactive substances differ from one another not only in chemical composition, mechanism of action on the body or the effects of short / long-term use. Therefore, while designing effective substance abuse prevention programs for the adolescent, we should take into account the differences in public perception of these substances.

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AN ALTERED STATE OF LITERATURE: AN ATTEMPT AT A NARCOANALYSIS ACCORDING TO AVITAL RONELL

I will start this paper with the passage opening the work of Avital Ronell. One should not be surprised that this quote comes from no one else but Friedrich Nietzsche: 'Who will ever relate the whole history of narcotica? – It is almost the history of "culture", of our so-called high culture' (*The Gay Science*, § 86). This excerpt somehow gives direction to all narco-cultural studies that aim at emphasizing connections between drugs and high modernism.⁴⁶¹ Ronell's *Narcoanalysis* might not be the first research on the topic, but certainly it influenced other studies. In this paper, I will try to point out the most important notions appearing in her *Crack Wars. Literature, Addiction, Mania*, including some ideas from the study on Flaubert's novel *Madame Bovary*. Finally, I would like to 'narcoanalyse' the novel *Niekochana (Unbeloved)* by Adolf Rudnicki.

TOWARDS NARCOANALYSIS

Let us take a closer look at the above-mentioned quote, as the word 'culture' to which it refers might be misleading. In the German original, we will find what actually stands for 'culture' and therefore what consequences this shift of meaning has for further considerations. As a matter of fact, Nietzsche writes about *Bildung*, which refers to the so-called 'high culture', however, it has an additional meaning connected to German Idealism. *Bildung* may be defined as a process of self-cultivation, concerning personal growth and education, which results in being able to participate

⁴⁶¹ A. Alexander, M. S. Roberts (eds), *High Culture: Reflections on Addiction and Modernity*, New York 2003; D. Boothroyd, *Culture on Drugs. Narco-Cultural Studies of High Modernity*, Manchester 2006; J. Skelly, *Addiction and British Visual Culture, 1751–1919: Wasted looks*, Ashgate Publishing Company 2014; S. Plant, *Writing on Drugs*, London 1999.

consciously in the high culture. This would mean that according to Nietzsche drugs play an important role in the growth of an individual and developing selfhood and personal identity.

In such an analysis, it is necessary to define what actually 'narcotica' stands for and which tools are to be used. Avital Ronell does not give a straight answer to those questions. Actually, she poses a question on the conditions of the possibility of undertaking such an analysis. Even though she uses a conventional definition of a drug that refers to its status as a psychoactive substance, both natural and chemical, known in antiquity or developed quite recently by the pharmacological industry, licit or illicit, she renounces it very quickly, as the whole idea is borrowed from Jacques Derrida⁴⁶²: 'Drugs resist conceptual arrest. No one has thought to define them in their essence, which is not to say "they" do not exist. [...] No one has as so much as defined drugs, and this is in part because they are non-theorizable'.⁴⁶³

It should not come as a surprise that the methods of narcoanalysis are non-theorizable too, so narcoanalysis 'is devoted to the understanding of a literary work'.⁴⁶⁴ If one feels curious about this matter, one may assume it derives its tools from a wide range of what we call comparative literature or cultural studies – or – as David Boothyard put it, define narcoanalysis as 'the critical approach to culture from the perspective of its articulation with and by drugs'.⁴⁶⁵ Even though for many critics, including Boothyard, this concept seems to be innovative and created alongside various Ronell's word formations, narcoanalysis has its own history.

'In clinical psychiatry narcoanalysis, as a component of diagnosis and therapy is conducted while a patient is in a

⁴⁶² As soon as one utters the word 'drugs', even before any 'addiction', a prescriptive or normative 'diction' is already at work, performatively, whether one likes it or not. This 'concept' will never be a purely theoretical or theorizable concept.' J. Derrida, *The Rhetoric of Drugs*, [in:] *Points....: Interviews, 1974–1994*, trans. M. Israel, Stanford 1995, pp. 228–254.

⁴⁶³ A. Ronell, *Crack Wars: Addiction, Mania, Literature*. Illinois 2004, pp. 51–59.

⁴⁶⁴ A. Ronell, op. cit. p. 49.

⁴⁶⁵ D. Boothroyd, *Culture on Drugs. Narco-Cultural Studies of High Modernity*, Manchester 2006, p. 2.

“sleeplike” state induced by drugs especially as a means of releasing repressed feelings, thoughts or memories. Its use is restricted to circumstances when there is a compelling and immediate need for a patient’s response’.⁴⁶⁶

In other words, narcoanalysis is a drug-induced psychoanalytical therapy, which aims at liberation of what Freud once called the ‘strangled affects’. This means that narcoanalysis might be an investigative, margin-centered and between-the-lines focused reading strategy, that is conducted to reveal the modes of existence of addicted subjects, no matter what the addictive and seductive object is.

THE DESIRE FOR NARCOTICS

The psychoanalytical theory works well for Ronell’s concept.

‘Provisionally they [drugs – A.A.] may be comprehended as master objects of considerable libidinal investment, whose essence still remains to be determined. As it happens, literature is on drugs and about drugs – and here I retain the license to open the semantic range of this term (which does not even amount to concept)’.⁴⁶⁷

With a little help from psychoanalysis, the question of addiction turns out to be the question of desire and fantasy as a way of obtaining fulfilment (which obviously cannot be obtained considering the structure of desire itself). I am referring here to the Lacanian theory set in *The Subversion of the Subject and the Dialectic of Desire*,⁴⁶⁸ in which he stated that becoming a speaking (thus desiring) subject is contained in the Other’s question: ‘What do you want?’, reversed into ‘What does he want from me?’, a question asked by the subject him/herself. A delusion that the answer to that question exists and may be obtained prompts the subject to search

⁴⁶⁶ M. M. Panditrao et al., *Propofol for Narcoanalysis, A Novel and Better Alternative: Preliminary Report of Four Cases*, ‘Indian Journal of Clinical Practice’, 20:3, p. 257.

⁴⁶⁷ A. Ronell, op. cit., p. 50.

⁴⁶⁸ J. Lacan, *Écrits. A selection*. B. Fink (trans.), London 2002.

for it constantly as it is perceived as a key to fulfilment (including gaining the desire of the Other in becoming an object of the Other's desire). Through this fulfilment, a door to prohibited pleasure – *jouissance* – would open and the subject would enjoy it fully and without consequences, which are usually death or insanity. But desire cannot go without fantasy.

'The first thing to note is that fantasy does not simply realize a desire in a hallucinatory way: rather, its function is similar to that of Kantian "transcendental schematism": a fantasy constitutes our desire, provides its coordinates; that is, it literally "teaches us how to desire". [...] fantasy mediates between the formal symbolic structure and the positivity of the objects we encounter in reality – that is to say, it provides a "schema" according to which certain positive objects in reality can function as objects of desire, filling in the empty places opened up by the formal symbolic structure'.⁴⁶⁹

Where would we put drugs into this scheme? Drugs and desire are bound together more tightly than it might be expected. Actually, they function as uncanny and undead objects that prey on our desire using the phantasmatic veil to convince us that they provide access to *jouissance*. They pretend to be a skeleton key to the Other's desire, turning out to be a parasite object wanting us to want more. And more. And more.

When addiction is at stake, the drug takes place of a desirable object destroying the schema of fantasy, which leaves us in a void. The figure which Ronell uses to describe this 'evil' and 'parasitic' character of drugs is crack. There might be good and bad drugs. However, crack is definitely a bad drug. 'Crack disappoints the pleasure a drug might be expected to arouse. Hence the quality of crack as a pure instance of "Being-on-drugs": it is only about producing a need for itself'.⁴⁷⁰

⁴⁶⁹ S. Žižek, *The Plague of Fantasies*, Verso 2008, p. 7.

⁴⁷⁰ A. Ronell, op. cit., p. 25.

BEING-ON-DRUGS

This is where addiction meets existence. What Ronell calls 'Being-on-drugs' makes a reference to the possibilities of Dasein's Being marked by Martin Heidegger. She quotes a long passage from *Being and Time* (§41 'Dasein's Being as Care') to discuss the link between Urge and Addiction to Heidegger's philosophy. Dasein seems to be always exposed to addiction and can never be fully moved from its possibility. Moreover, it brings up the question of freedom as such, which occurs to be impossible to achieve.

'For Ronell, addiction and urge in particular function like "accelerators" and "artificial additives" – that is, as pharmaceuticals, uppers – that "display problematic powers of being ontologically constitutive in certain cases", thereby collapsing the oppositional limit that Heidegger compulsively inscribes and reinscribes between being-in-the-world and being-on-drugs. [...] already, Heidegger is insisting on the parasitical nature of *Hang* and *Drang*, their unstable "location" both within and without boundary dividing the interiority of Sorge from exteriority of its mirror forms [...]. As in *Being and Time*, addiction functions suspiciously like a "narcotic", alluring and dangerous, spoiling Heidegger's axiomatic claims that the essence of Dasein's "desire" is nothing vulgarly desirous. For who could tell the difference between being-in-the-world and being-on-drugs? In Ronell's hands, Dasein pretends to designate a drug crisis when it is, in fact, itself the crisis to which it refers'.⁴⁷¹

'TOXIC DIRVE' AND 'NARCOCISSM'

If we look back to the psychoanalytic concepts of drugs, we will have to ask a question about the links between what Ronell calls 'toxic dirve' and

⁴⁷¹ D. L. Clark, *Heidegger's Craving. Being-on-Schelling*, [in:] A. Alexander, M. S. Roberts (eds), *High Culture. Reflections on Addiction and Modernity*. New York 20013, p. 99.

'narcocissm'. If drugs are *libidinally invested*, it is the *toxic drive* that is responsible; we do not need to do a lot of searching but recapture the lines from *Civilization and its Discontents*,⁴⁷² where Freud writes that those discontents are unbearable and there are only three ways of trespassing them: by means of art and aesthetics, by means of science and the pleasure of academic work, and finally by the courtesy of drugs. In that case, we should ask whether art and science could be considered drugs if they play the same part in the struggle of an individual to cope with the misery of everyday life? Avital Ronell answers: '[t]here are good and bad addictions, and anything can serve the function of a drug. "Drugs", in any case, make us face the gaping chasms of *Beyond the Pleasure Principle*, where death drive and desire round up their victims'.⁴⁷³ This *toxic drive* makes us resist the reality principle and seek for fulfilment beyond what is perceived rational and reasonable. But the *toxic drive* cannot be easily satisfied with simple pleasures, it is asking for more, more than can be actually achieved. This *toxic drive* feeds on desire and it might be the reason why it objects reality with such strength. That is why a fantasy, neurotic and overwhelming, unhinging the dreamer from a purposeful stream of everyday life, can serve the function of a drug. And *jouissance* is its purpose.

So what is so narcissistic about that? Actually, narcissism is a painful condition and the conviction that a narcissistic person is happy and (a little too much) self-loving is false. It is a situation when the drive cannot find its object in an external world, so it searches for it in the internal world of delusions, therefore this is a libidinal investment into a non-existing object, a phantasm. To avoid *an empty Investition*, which would be rather melancholic than narcissistic in its character, a narcissist invests in an idealised, imaginary picture of the Self. To hold this picture, a narcissist must keep dreaming. Their fantasy and desire to be desired need to be fed constantly. A narcissist needs to be intoxicated to exist. Becoming that person we are dreaming to be, would release an amount of *jouissance*, and that

⁴⁷² S. Freud, *Civilization and Its Discontents*. J. Strachey (trans.), W. W. Norton & Company 1989.

⁴⁷³ A. Ronell, op. cit., p. 53.

would become a part of the Self. Apparently, this situation cannot be obtained in the 'real world', so the world of fantasies and intoxication is the only place that is left, turning this situation into a *narcocissim*.

EMMA BOVARY – AN INTOXICATED DREAMER

The easiest way to stoke up the fantasy with new scripts is literature. The case of Don Kichot, who overdosed his readings is well-known. Another compulsive reader is a heroine from the Flaubert's novel – Emma Bovary. Furthermore, this particular novel was taken very seriously as a threat to the healthy imagination, as the accusations of *Madame Bovary* being obscene were commenced in October 1856. Regardless of that, the book was published soon after (1857), but its poisonous potential did not diminish as its interpreter, Eleanor Marx, a daughter of Karl Marx, committed suicide in a manner that might resemble the suicide of Emma Bovary. This example shows that even though Emma was a fictional character moulded on other fictional heroines to set her desire on the course, this mimetic poisoning affected a woman outside the imaginary world of the Falubert's narrative. Conclusion? Be careful what you read for.

'The "woman" regulates her dosage of fantasy, secretly indulging in the fiction of identification with a community of non-substantial others. [...] Literature is said to cast its spell over the feminized reader; she cannot stop reading, she is captivated by this other that opens itself up to her. She finds herself seduced by a hallucination; nothing is properly hidden behind hallucination',⁴⁷⁴

But consuming novels is not enough. After some time her desire starts craving for more. So she turns to the 'hard drug' of adultery, which doubles her crime against society. She is getting hectic and careless, indulges herself with food, dresses, and various gadgets, such as luxurious paperweight, and finally goes into debt. Her appetite for the artefacts of her delusions derived from novels and newspapers is insatiable. So when it

⁴⁷⁴ A. Ronell, op. cit., pp. 101–102.

comes to the end, she chooses to take her own life rather than renounce her desire. Curiously enough, adultery turns out to have a lot in common with the structure of addiction.

‘If the scenes of drunkenness trespass are constantly put into communication with one another, this is in the first place because Flaubert seems to register gradations of the word “adultery” according to the distillation of its etymology. Adultery means that which alters the mind, falsifying and modifying its natural inflection. In its concept adultery is indissociable from what today we call mind-altering drugs’.⁴⁷⁵

UNBELOVED

Unbeloved,⁴⁷⁶ a novel by Adolf Rudnicki, published in 1937, also deals with the problem of addiction. Both characters – Noemi and Kamil – are addicted, but their drugs are different. I will focus on Noemi as the narrative is based on her experience and view of the couple’s relationship. The story seems to be simple and concentrates around the relationship of the two lovers; she loves him to death (literally), he does not love her at all, but even though they are both suffering, they are unable to end their relationship. It finally brings Noemi to madness. Of course there is more than this to their conflict, e.g. Kamil’s Jewish roots underlying the cultural gap between them, his general nervousness and suicidal tendencies, and finally Noemi’s abortion. Despite these facts, my interest lies in the phantasmatic scheme which she uses to support her desire and therefore to keep herself high in a dreamland. Noemi is a dreamer. She is wrapped up in fantasies and not especially interested in the so-called ‘real world’ as the conversation with Kamil shows:

‘ “You are filled with dreams and hallucinations, you are dreaming constantly and see those pictures in your head, so tell me” he said “do you also see organic landscapes?” [...]

⁴⁷⁵ A. Ronell, op. cit., p. 99.

⁴⁷⁶ All quotations were translated from the following edition: A. Rudnicki, *Niekochana*. Szczury, Warszawa 1996.

“You lie down” he explained “close your eyes and see the mountains, the valleys, a forest.. No, not forest. Only water, that’s it” he added quickly.’ [*Unbeloved*, 14].

It may seem that Noemi’s desire feeds on Kamil’s love and attention, but it is more about the idea of being a someone’s beloved. His presence and especially his kind words and accidental smiles serve as a drug, which makes her feel pleasantly intoxicated, just as at the time, when he came back to her after a period of separation:

‘The cadence of the time, how often hostile to our internal history, that day happened to gain what we call harmony. The time did not press her down, the world did not hold her down. Noemi was walking on air with an overwhelming feeling of mellowness. One may say that she had been dying that day, if this thing inside her did not deserve to be called most certainly a beauty of life.’ [*Unbeloved*, 20].

To be loved by Kamil is almost like to gain the desire of Other – it carries such an amount of *jouissance* that would have been unbearable for human being if not lethal. This is the reason why being an *unbeloved* one, somehow, in a paradoxical way, suits Noemi – her desire can remain unsatisfied, so that it would incessantly generate visions to keep her dreaming and hallucinating. At the times of separation caused by Kamil’s unannounced departures (if not escapes) from her, Noemi develops a delirious condition, craving for another ‘hit’ of Kamil’s presence. She is unable to function as she is focused only on stalking him.

‘Noemi did not quit her job, but she devoted all her free time to search for him. The pace of those searches was rising with each day, somehow becoming manic and insane. The initial need or necessity of telling him about the separation declined. Having just one wish – to see him, over which she was powerless, she forgot about it. To see him. Nothing more. She could not remember of anything else.’ [*Unbeloved*, 42].

This obsession cannot come to an end and it gets worse with each day. The desire deprived of its phantasmatic feed starts to produce hallucinations that cannot longer be perceived as pleasant; the pictures in Noemi's mind are hostile and threatening, as if her own desire started to feed on her fear and despair, sucking the remaining life's energy out of her body. The process that used to be psychological, turns into a physical one.

'At the time, Noemi had this feeling, as if phenomena flew out of its beds, trod on their toes, got mixed up and misrepresented, causing chaos, which had nothing to do with a daily chaos where one is or might be familiar with the source of each sound. Chaos, she had been succumbed with, was odd and hard to describe. The cadence of time – a figment of well-known powers – had been stroking her so forcefully, that Noemi could not comprehend anything from what was going on around her. She had been hearing voices; not ordinary voices, but rather some kind of howls, overpowering in its undefinedness and nonsimilitude to anything but human, so distant from everything that is joyful – fallen angels might have convoked each other in that manner. It seemed to her, that the time outside the window was dead as if it waited for something; the world was congealed, the time was congealed, the time and the world have congealed.'
[*Unbeloved*, 43].

The trouble is that Noemi's desire cannot find another fantasy to feed itself with. She comes up with the idea of emigration to the United States, but this makeshift daydream is used only to enable her getting through the time necessary to reach Kamil. Her intention of leaving is obviously a lie. The 'drug' she has been on with Kamil is impossible to replace with a milder 'substance'. She renounces any substitutes. Thereupon, all she has left is to die as in death a shadow of this forbidden *jouissance* can appear.

As the narcoanalysis itself does not seem to be an operational and effectively useful meta-analytical category, the concepts derived from the interpretation of *Madame Bovary* which follows it, might be inspirational for narco-cultural studies. Connections between addiction, intoxication, fantasy, and desire that it exposes might be helpful in understanding the psychoanalytical structure of addictions in general – not only in fictional and metaphorical way (as in the examples presented above), but also when it comes to the material, cultural practices concerning ‘real’ drugs, not only phantasms.

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A CLUSTERKNOT OF COMPLEXES – MORPHINE, ALCOHOL AND COCAINE IN STANISŁAW IGNACY WITKIEWICZ'S *THE MOTHER*

Was Stanisław Ignacy Witkiewicz a drug addict? This question appears in Anna Micińska's work on Witkiewicz's *Narcotics*, where she explains that 'for the first time, [...] he encountered narcotics *sensu stricto* in Russia, during his wartime journeys'.⁴⁷⁷ This part of the renown writer's life is shrouded in mystery, mostly due to his own silence on the subject. It is only known that, the Great War started, Witkiewicz had volunteered for the army as, technically, a Russian subject.⁴⁷⁸ A graduate of a military school and using his uncle's influence, he was admitted to the Pavlovsky Regiment,⁴⁷⁹ filled to the brim with the so-called 'white aristocracy'. This was the young artist's first meeting with the true form of the 20th century.⁴⁸⁰ 'The regiment's daily life, its atmosphere, its drunken excesses and sexual orgies, the attitude of *après nous le déluge*,⁴⁸¹ that immense Russian decadence, whose enormity and characteristics remain unknown in Poland',⁴⁸² all that must have left an eternal impression on his work. Anna

⁴⁷⁷ A. Micińska, *Na marginesie „Narkotyków” i „Niemytych dusz” Stanisława Ignacego Witkiewicza*, [in:] St. I. Witkiewicz, *Dzieła wybrane*. 622 *Upadki Bunga czyli demoniczna kobieta. Narkotyki. Niemyte dusze*, Vol. 1, Warszawa 1985, pp. 489–490.

⁴⁷⁸ At the beginning of 1915, he was a student of St Petersburg military school. After graduation, he left for the Russian front and was injured. Discharged, he stayed in Moscow where he witnessed the start of the October Revolution. In 1918 he managed to flee the turmoil and return to his hometown of Zakopane.

⁴⁷⁹ A regiment of Imperial Russia, formed on 15th May 1790, disbanded in 1918, which served, among others, in Napoleonic Wars and the First World War under various names.

⁴⁸⁰ Konstanty Puzyna mentions this in his introduction to the fourth volume of the *Chosen Works of Stanisław Ignacy Witkiewicz*.

⁴⁸¹ *après nous le déluge* (French) – 'after us, the Deluge'; words attributed to either Louis XIV or his mistress, Marquise de Pompadour.

⁴⁸² K. Puzyna, *Witkacy*, [in:] St. I. Witkiewicz, *Dzieła wybrane, Dramaty*, Vol. 4, Warszawa 1985, p. 20.

Micińska remarked that, even in 1918, and therefore right after his return from Russia,

‘one of Witkiewicz’s paintings, a portrait of *My friend, who stole Ms Trojan’s fan*, bears a signature and a date, and next to them, the word “Ether”. In 1926, he makes first of his rare portrait paintings done under the influence of cocaine, and between 1928 and 1932 he shows great interest in all sorts of ‘dope’.⁴⁸³ Thus, in 1932 he publishes his “work on narcotics, including a comprehensive list thereof”. Since then, his own interest in psychedelics dwindles’.⁴⁸⁴

It was probably during that secretive period of his life that was formed Witkiewicz’s catastrophic outlook on history and philosophy, visible in later work that would present a borderline obsession of the power of a mindless mob, manipulated by cunning demagogues.

The Mother: a distasteful play in two acts with an epilogue was written in 1924, and is filled with sarcastic, caustic humour. Jan Błoński had noted that

‘rarely does one come across works, where all human emotion – especially the most hallowed ones – are so drastically scorned and ridiculed. [...] Witkiewicz exaggerates the stereotype of a mother exploited by her children to satirise Leon and his mother herself. In her expression of motherly feelings, she resembles an inhuman automaton. She also has her own faults, starting with her marriage to a serial criminal, whose son, Leon, becomes a ‘proper’ successor. Witkiewicz [...] tried to exaggerate as he always does, to caricaturise the menial, evil deeds which the reader must thus perceive with a laugh [...] underscored with anxiety, but a laugh nonetheless’.⁴⁸⁵

⁴⁸³ A word used by Witkiewicz in his original text.

⁴⁸⁴ K. Puzyna, op. cit., p. 20.

⁴⁸⁵ J. Błoński, *Wstęp*, [in:] S.I. Witkiewicz, *Wybór dramatów*, Wrocław 1974, p. 11.

The legendary theatrical production, directed by Jerzy Jarocki in 1972, begins with a gritty melody of a violin out of tune.⁴⁸⁶ Slowly, a room emerges, its walls dirty and grayed, a normal habitation only at a first glance. As the stage lights up, a lack of windows leaps to the eye. There are doors, there is old, worn furniture, there is underwear drying on a clothesline – all this suggests a home in a way that is slightly too insistent, blatant. The neglected, bourgeois living room will soon prove to be a trap. The disquieting atmosphere is strengthened by the unnaturally placed furniture.

What can be said about Janina Węgorzewska, the titular Mother?⁴⁸⁷ The play's short exposition presents a downtrodden woman leading a lacking life. As the light unveils the scene, the violin tune is joined by a monotonous litany of debts and bills waiting to be paid. The painful monologue of the Mother voices her disappointment, and the grating violin music fits the list of thwarted hopes.

The Mother is a study of the torment that is a reciprocal existence, of the destructive power of familial ties.⁴⁸⁸ Everything can happen here, and it will certainly happen negatively.⁴⁸⁹ The characters torment each other, bringing themselves to despair; each suffering the pain of her or his own existence in their own way. Starting with the servant, Dorota⁴⁹⁰ – the guardian of sobriety, who tries to keep up the dysfunctional household, does not mince her words: 'Madam has been drinking again, and on an empty stomach to boot? Couldn't madam have waited, at least till supper?'⁴⁹¹ Janina Węgorzewska struggles with alcohol abuse.

⁴⁸⁶ Stanisław Radwan was the author of the musical score.

⁴⁸⁷ The two roles – the Mother Janina Węgorzewska, played by Ewa Lassek, and the son, Leon, played by Marek Walczewski, were considered the greatest interpretations in the history of Polish theatre.

⁴⁸⁸ B. Guetzalska, *Jerzy Jarocki – artysta teatru*, Kraków 1999, p. 202.

⁴⁸⁹ Words of Stefan Treugutt, Polish theatre critic and historian of literature, in his introduction to the TV broadcast of the play. He was a popular television personality in the sixties, delivering his own introductions live before plays in the TV Theatre.

⁴⁹⁰ Played by Halina Wojtacha.

⁴⁹¹ St. I. Witkiewicz, *Matka*, [in:] Idem, *Dzieła wybrane, Dramaty*, Vol. 5, Warszawa 1985, p. 375.

'The need to drink appears as a result of certain feelings; some emotions may encourage drinking. Alcohol, as well as narcotics, can bring a momentary relief from stress and anxiety [...] The exact manner of alcohol abuse is determined by an array of factors. Each individual has their own model. It can result from a feeling of alienation, of rejection, a feeling of emotional void, of helplessness, or memories of some traumatic past event. A lack of closure, a brutal refusal'.⁴⁹²

The Mother is disappointed with her life. She tries to cope with her need for love, emotional emptiness and loneliness. 'I will drink, it's all I have', she replies.

'I do morphine, too, but rarely [...] I tell you this in strict confidence, Dorota. And frankly, somewhere deep inside, I am enraptured by this senseless life, this endless sacrifice in the boundless mediocrity, which I love so deeply. [...] I love myself in this, Dorota. [...] It's not a normal love for the world, it's a terrible inverted egoism.

'Bah,' Dorota replies, 'you're just completely pissed to-day'.⁴⁹³

The lady of the house surpasses her household intellectually. She is the one most conscious of her own situation, and heroically suffering the fear of loneliness. She's not a petty bourgeoisie or a snobbish social climber, she's an 'aristocrat of spirit' down on her luck.⁴⁹⁴ She suffers the consequences of her misalliance to an unsuccessful singer and carpenter, whose subsequent acts of robbery and murder led him to the gallows. In these errors of her careless youth she sees the reason for her thwarted ambitions: 'I used to paint, I had a musical talent, I could write decent

⁴⁹² W. R. Miller, dr R. F. Munoz, *Picie kontrolowane*, trans. K. Mazurek, Warszawa 2006, pp. 106-107.

⁴⁹³ St. I. Witkiewicz, *Matka*, op. cit., pp. 376-377.

⁴⁹⁴ As characterised by Barbara Guczalska, B. Guczalska, op. cit., p. 203.

novellas [...] ah, the eternal loneliness, and no solace anywhere'.⁴⁹⁵ A character full of contradictions, she is strong and weak, great and petty, possessive and overprotective of her son.

The son, Leon Węgorzewski, suffers even more. His independence is an illusion, as is his image of a nonchalant bohemian, the rebellious artist. In fact, the character is more akin to rambling lunatic: 'I think that, in a year, maybe in nine months, I will be a professor in my own school' he says. 'Without a PhD, without any diploma at all, and most of all without any connections? Aren't you exaggerating a bit?'⁴⁹⁶ He is so focused on himself he doesn't even notice his mother's problems. 'What? You drink, Mother?' 'I've been drinking for two years. I am a complete alcoholic, my dear'.⁴⁹⁷ This confession does not seem to rattle him, either: 'A new blow, I guess. But we must suffer it.'⁴⁹⁸ A failed artist, whose only success is a pamphlet of thirty six pages, presenting his *idée fixe*, a degenerate mother's boy who wallows in his intellectual and creative stupor only to become a morphine addict and finally the pimp of his own wife. His episode as an agent of a hostile country lands him in the arms of a degenerate millionairess.

The Mother's behaviour is consistent with a long-lasting mental illness: her episodes of anxiety, dismay and irritation are symptoms of a deep depression. It is the opinion of a mental health specialist, doctor Elżbieta Sadowska,⁴⁹⁹ that

'Depressive or psychotic episodes, in conjunction with substance abuse, are a mental illness. Coexisting with a personality disorder, they are a grave illness, where the addicted patient, struggling in addition with a personality disorder –

⁴⁹⁵ St. I. Witkiewicz, *Matka*, op. cit., p. 374.

⁴⁹⁶ Ibidem, p. 379.

⁴⁹⁷ Ibidem, p. 394.

⁴⁹⁸ Ibidem.

⁴⁹⁹ E. Sadowska, *O chorobach psychicznych i nie tylko* – author's own interview with the doctor, Opole 2014 (author's home archive).

is incapable of normal existence, of handing their own emotions'.⁵⁰⁰

This diagnosis resembles the symptoms presented by the play's protagonist. With no one else to turn to, she is overcome by her loneliness and illness, and her alcoholism deepens. She neglects house chores and family relations, only ever interested in her sewing, which slowly renders her blind. She tries to muffle her helplessness and solitude with alcohol: she drinks, because she is lost, she is lost because she drinks. A vicious circle of hopeless vegetation.

'Lack of control over one's own emotions and destructive feelings like anger or aggression are often considered psychotic. Lack of control over own behaviour is also often considered a sign of insanity or mental illness'.⁵⁰¹

All indicates that the Mother and son have remained in a toxic relationship for years now. In his work on addictive personality, doctor Lee Jampolsky stated that

'Addictive relationships happen not only because they are made of 'defective elements', meaning they are formed by people who have unconscious emotional deficiencies and disorders [...] such a relationship has its underlying goal, and the people living in it gain specific, though very twisted, 'benefit'. It usually is a way to re-create and relive the crucial, the most painful aspects of one's own childhood, hoping that this time it will be possible to fill that deficiency of love which was formed then'.⁵⁰²

By drinking, the Mother wants to desensitise herself, silence the feeling of solitude, but she also wants to draw attention to herself. Alcohol makes her lose control.

⁵⁰⁰ Ibidem.

⁵⁰¹ Ibidem, pp. 2–6.

⁵⁰² L. Jampolsky, *Leczenie uzależnionego umysłu*, trans. A. Szewczyk, K. Wilczek, Warszawa 2004, pp. 41–42.

‘Alcohol is a depressant, and using it as an aid in difficult situations, conflicts or just when feeling bad is a mistake. It is not a stimulant of the nervous system, on the contrary, and the illusory wellbeing it provides is only due to its distortion of human perception’.⁵⁰³

There is an odd, poisonous love between the Mother and son. They both project their negative emotions on one another: hate, regret, guilt, shame, fear. They blame each other for their failures.

‘Living with an addictive personality, we believe we are lacking and less than whole. We believe this lack cannot be filled from the inside, that we cannot do it ourselves. We embark on a search for fulfilment, looking for it in other people or things, which make us feel whole for a moment’.⁵⁰⁴

The young fiancée of the son, Leon – working-class girl Zofia Plejtus⁵⁰⁵ – only appears carefree. She suffers because of her lowly origins, constantly ridiculed by Leon’s mother. Her shocking change from a schoolgirl in a demure uniform into an ostentatious prostitute is nothing more than an attempt at escaping the real life with its painful difficulties. Because Zofia does not want to work, she can ‘improvise artistically’ at most, and that is the core of her tragedy. Suffering from acute ‘work phobia’, she prefers to become a hooker and then a drug addict. Her father, Apolinary Plejtus,⁵⁰⁶ though he covets money and power, doubts the honesty of his only child’s work. When voicing his suspicion, ‘Her constant night duties, and that night-time bookbinding course, and the night-time artistic-dance-health class, I don’t like all that’,⁵⁰⁷ he shows his pain and humiliation. And what’s more, he can see how Leon abuses his Zofia – they are another couple in an extremely toxic relationship.

⁵⁰³ E. Sadowska, op. cit., p. 5.

⁵⁰⁴ L. Jampolsky, op. cit., p. 41.

⁵⁰⁵ Portrayed by Danuta Maksymowicz in the theatre production, and by Ewa Dałkowska in the television production.

⁵⁰⁶ Portrayed by Wiktor Sadecki – from Kraków’s Old Theatre.

⁵⁰⁷ St. I. Witkiewicz, *Matka*, op. cit., p. 401.

Psychology experts, when asked about ‘toxic relationships’, would say that, firstly, it’s not a proper scientific term, and secondly, that it became very popular in mass media and is now a handy blanket term for any failed relationship. Originally, it was meant to denote drastically destructive and strongly emotional relationships, with reciprocal humiliation, pathological jealousy and violence.

‘There is a vast repertoire of behaviours that can make a personal relationship be harmful when it’s supposed to be constructive and bring joy. [...] The destructive influence of all sorts of pathological behaviours, such as alcohol abuse or violence, include the threat of codependency [...] Such toxic elements appearing within the relationship and proving impossible to remove are a signal to end the relationship, but leaving proves impossible. This is the crux of toxic relationships – the obsessive clinging to the person that abuses and hurts. [...] And since, against all reason, the victim of such a relationship not only remains in it, but becomes more and more involved, then it is nothing more than a toxic form of love – an addiction to another person, or strictly speaking, to one’s relationship with that person’.⁵⁰⁸

Witkiewicz himself writes in his *Narcotics* that it is a base trait of human nature (and animal as well, in all probability), that any living thing tries to forget its unpleasant experiences as soon as possible, and wallow in the pleasant ones as long as possible. And there’s nothing surprising in that.⁵⁰⁹

‘An unpleasant experience, consciously repressed, may seem shunned from our mind, but it does not perish entirely,

⁵⁰⁸ G. E. Kwiatkowska, *Psychologia i psychoterapia. Toksyczne związki*, http://www.emito.net/spolecznosc/grupy/zdrowie_i_uroda/psychologia_i_psychoterapia_318899/forum/toksyczne_zwiazki_warto_poczytac_543760 [30.05.2014].

⁵⁰⁹ St. I. Witkiewicz, *Pojęcie kompleksu węzłowego*, [in:] Idem, *Dzieła wybrane*, 622 *Upadki Bunga* czyli demoniczna kobieta. Narkotyki. Niemyte dusze, Vol. 1, Warszawa 1985, pp. 672–673.

it does not disintegrate [...] Each painful event, a harm inflicted, an insult, humiliation or disappointment, is forgotten as soon as possible. Yet their consequences continue, sprouting series of particular reactions around the cyst that is the original event. [...] And thus the concealed clusterknot is carried, sometimes throughout one's whole life, until it is provoked to erupt. However, this often doesn't come at all and an individual remains, for the rest of their life, victim of concealed powers that are unknown and unrecognisable to them.⁵¹⁰

Witkiewicz uses the word 'clusterknot' (*'węzłowisko'*) to describe the Freudian term of complex, specifically an inferiority complex. All characters in *The Mother* are tied with this demonic clusterknot, hidden under a deep layer of unpleasant experiences and reactions.

The play also includes an important theme of vampirism:

'Some characters call each other vampires or confess to being one. The Mother often describes her son as such, meaning that he is a parasite: draining her, living off her [...] An additional part is Leon being overly tied to his mother, dependent on her: he is not a self-reliant being, but an embryo, a vampire in a sense'.⁵¹¹

Zofia falls prey to Leon's vampiric tendencies, though she formed a relationship with him from purely ideological reasons.⁵¹² She does not really understand her fiancé's philosophy, but she wants to sacrifice herself, or her body, for them nonetheless. Thus the couple of losers, pushed into

⁵¹⁰ St. I. Witkiewicz, *Pojęcie kompleksu węzłowiska*, op. cit., pp. 681–689.

⁵¹¹ L. Sokół, *Witkacy i Strindberg: dalecy i bliscy*, Wrocław 1995, p. 38.

⁵¹² 'Art is dead, and let its end be light – we can do very well without it. Religion is over, philosophy is chewing its own guts and on its way to suicide. The individual has been slaughtered by the society – a banal constatation of the times. How can we stop this unstoppable process of collectivization, where everything dies that was great, that had any relation to the Infinite, the Mystery of Existence?' Leon searches for answers. His views, tarnished with catastrophism and fear of the new mechanised world devoid of *sacrum* are an echo of Witkiewicz's own metaphysical ideas.

motion by Leon's ideas, falls ever lower. He conducts suspect transactions in cocaine and spying, while she, with his approval, provides sex to rich clients. 'Yes, I pushed you into it' he says, 'but you leaned that way as well. Otherwise it would not have been possible'.⁵¹³ Money earned in prostitution is squandered on luxuries and orgies of sex and drugs. The degradation of the protagonists is completed by the Mother's death, blind and destroyed by alcohol, who dies in ecstasy after overdosing cocaine.

Repression of complexes, according to psychiatrists, should not be used as a viable strategy, as it can lead to disastrous effects, including mental illness. Unfortunately, the play's protagonists seem to have forgotten that solitude is not always evil, a punishment and suffering that has to be fought with any means available. There can exist 'a good solitude, one that Petrarch described: "the holy, simple, unspoiled and the purest of all humane things", and her chief advantage is being resistant to the dehumanising influence of both short-term and long-term tendencies of the civilizational progress'.⁵¹⁴

However, that is not possible in this case, because *The Mother* is a story of a man, who loved his own mother in a way both violent and morbid. His toxic love showed its blasphemous mirror image. The accidental matricide falls victim to the masked labourers, the new world order, the mechanised, de-personalised civilization that Witkiewicz feared so much. In the finale, a group of nameless automatons lynches Leon, 'the last intellectual. Here, everything is morose and tragic'.⁵¹⁵

The happy family brothel in a mental hospital, the perverse sadomasochistic over-cabaret, without probability or 'guts'. But with a mechanistic vision, familiar from the author's other plays: the parade of familiar types, artists, hookers, demonic geniuses, 'athletes of power' and the mob. Witkiewicz shows a tragi-comic inevitability that sentences all his

⁵¹³ St. I. Witkiewicz, *Matka*, op. cit., p. 423.

⁵¹⁴ P. Domeracki, W. Tyburski, *Wprowadzenie* [in:] Eidem (eds), *Zrozumieć samotność. Studium interdyscyplinarne*, Toruń 2006, pp. 9–10.

⁵¹⁵ R. Szydlowski, „*Matka*” a la Sartre, *Trybuna Ludu*, 1972, 346, [in:] P. Rudzki, „*Matka*” w *Czystej Formie*, „*Notatnik Teatralny*” 2006, 41, pp. 121–134.

characters to the hopeless insatiation. Obsessed with metaphysical passion, they delve deeper into frustration. They must act despite themselves, until they fall victim to their own insanity. Witkiewicz's characters show suicidal tendencies, a certain programmed predilection to spiritual destitution that leads to self-destruction.

Theatrical endeavours of Jerzy Jarocki have never been pleasant. 'The so-called liberating laughter is not in his nature'.⁵¹⁶ It could therefore be said that Jarocki's dramatizations do not bring catharsis. *The Mother* is a play where all characters choke on their own suffering and cannot spit it out. They feed on it and suffer from it, but they endure it, fatally.

'Juggling conventions and quotations, a distance towards intertextuality are not a game of theatre, or a demonstration of author's professional adroitness. The brilliant form hides the director's very personal missive. [...] It is also a direct representation of the condition of the modern art, which is pieced together from fragments and regurgitates older content; capable of appropriating and transform anything and transgress all barriers. Witkiewicz has not only foreseen, but practiced this kind of art'.⁵¹⁷

The production described here became an exceptional one. *The Mother* produced by the theatre from Kraków, with its clarity and transparency, became a paragon of dramatization when it came to Witkiewicz, whose writing has always been, and still is, very difficult for theatre.

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⁵¹⁶ A. Wirth, *Teatr Jarockiego II*, trans. D. Borkowska, 'Dialog', 1991, 2, 102–108.

⁵¹⁷ B. Guczalska, op. cit., pp. 102–103.

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POLISH POETRY AFTER YEAR 2000 – NARCONAUTICS

References to Great Polish Avant-garde are not new in Polish poetry, even though literary critics have had difficulties in defining avant-garde as a category for years. Is avant-garde literature even possible at all, or can authors only relate to the works of past avant-garde? Opinions abound, though this article will not try to answer that particular question. What I am interested in is the way in which young poets nowadays use the results of avant-garde experiments as they had been performed a century before, and the fact that this method of reference had drastically changed over the last decade.

Looking at them with the eye of today, one can understand the poetics, born in Poland after 1989, easier. Themes introduced to the mainstream by such authors as Andrzej Sosnowski or Marcin Sendecki – introduced and maintained by these authors consequently – were not an attempt to continue the avant-garde experiments with all their ideological and meta-artistic implications. These authors could be said to make references to the avant-garde tradition, as the innovations in poetry introduced in the first decades of the last century have become as classic an inspiration for them as the actual Classicism. Thus, they see the avant-garde of the early 20th century as one of the natural turns of literary history, and not as a radical rejection of all tradition that would be possible to maintain and perform today. The avant-garde poetry is not, therefore, an attitude or a strategy of artistic creation, but a closed canon of literature: thus their work is not a 'reanimation' of it, but a reference. Using this constataion as basis for an observation strategy, one can see the processes present in the youngest generation of Polish poetry easier and clearer.

It would be difficult to define an event that could serve as a new – after year 1989⁵¹⁸ – turning point for Polish poetry. However, this change, this new phase in the poetic language brought about by authors after year 2000 is sharp enough that sooner or later it will have to be described in the context of certain literary categories that seem to have been critically depleted – including the category of avant-garde. This re-orientation of poetic language seems primarily related to the renewed interest in the poetic tendencies of the early 20th century innovation. Such an observation does not end the matter, however, since – as I’ve mentioned before – references to the Great Polish Avant-garde are not new in Polish poetry. The key point here is the attitude of the young poets towards the avant-garde movement, which they see as a live, unachieved project that – and this is the most important part – can be continued, and is primarily a political project. According to Peter Sloterdijk, the level of social inequality today is comparable to one before the October Revolution, and the frustration and anger of the people may even be greater. However, despite protests and actions erupting worldwide, this anger cannot be channelled into a revolution, because there is no coherent political and economic system that could be proposed instead of neoliberalism.⁵¹⁹ Young poets’ references to the avant-garde ideas, with their aesthetic and ideological connotations, is doubtlessly an attempt at expressing that anger.

Much has been said already about ‘poets activists’, usually grouping together Szczepan Kopyt, Konrad Góra and Kira Pietrek – left-wing poets with a penchant for anarchy. This is an oversimplifying approach, however, because the strategies of social resistance – closely related to the re-animation of avant-garde and its ideologies – can take various forms and often be indirect. One of these forms, in my opinion, is ‘narconautics’ (term by Tomasz Pułka): if one observes the attitude of young poets towards the alternative states of consciousness, their work can easily be identified as political, as the following examples will show. Timothy Leary had said, in his famous work *The Politics of Ecstasy*, that ‘whenever

⁵¹⁸ Obviously, I am simplifying by pointing to the year 1989 as a breakthrough. Much has been written about arbitrariness of this date.

⁵¹⁹ V.: P. Sloterdijk, *Rage and Time: A Psychopolitical Investigation*, trans. M. Wenning, New York 2012.

many individual beings experience ecstasy in the same time, an ephemeral counter-culture is created'.⁵²⁰

In 2007, Adam Grzelec used the Nieszuflada.pl portal to publish his essay *MPdG* – an acronym meaning *Monomedialny Projekt dla Gandziarzy* ('Mono-media Project for Potheads'). He argues that what he calls 'smokers' show a completely different perception of poetic works, and he tries to describe this difference between 'traditional' reading and one influenced by THC.⁵²¹ Despite the author's usual component of derision, the essay shows a rigorous and cohesive construction and shows the author's conviction that psychedelics enable a fuller and broader reception of literature: Rimbaud's 'disordering of the senses'. Thus, Grzelec's essay brings me to my main theory.

Adam Hofman, the Swiss chemist who synthesised LSD for the first time in 1938, said in one of his interviews that

'The action of LSD is simple: the door of perception opens and we see much more [...] Humanity's achievements are wonderful, but they are a secondary concern. We are able to achieve many harmful things as well [...] If we are to be enraptured by nature again, we need to change our consciousness. LSD serves this purpose best. [...] Our current political leaders have no clue as to what is actually important on Earth. They don't understand that humanity owes its existence to nature. We must reinvent that knowledge if we are to survive. The scientist who does not grasp the wonder of nature uses it instrumentally [...] then he makes the atomic bomb'.⁵²²

⁵²⁰ T. Leary, *Polityka ekstazy*, trans. D. Misiuna, R. Palusiński, Kraków 1998, p. 20.

⁵²¹ V.: A. Grzelec, *MPdG*, <http://nieszuflada.pl/klasa.asp?idklasy=88580&idautora=1716&rodzaj=2> [03.12.2014].

⁵²² A. Hofmann et al., *Eliksir Hofmanna. LSD i nowe Eleuzis*, trans. M. Lorenc, Warszawa 2011, pp. 18–21.

The late-capitalist society, with its obsessions of consumption, where the alienation as described by Marx is in its apogee, lives on permanently anesthetised to the real problems of its own world. Thus, the gesture which lets one see this world as it is, is a revolutionary act – while the recreational drug use of the Hippie movement had finally compromised the theories of Hofman of Stanislav Grof, the actions of poets-narconauts are an attempt to regain the meaning of this meaningful gesture.

Grzelec's poem makes a direct reference to Hofman's elixir:

'~(LSD^~(LSD^~(LSD^~(LSD:):):):)

It's a lie, that you can go crazy because of acid.
The state is not a party to any of my contracts.
When I was receiving the Holy Communion I was thinking
about you,
about how much I'd like to get your body,
girl from the first pew: Te Deum Laudamus

It's a lie too, that you can heal yourself with an acid.
I am every party to all of my contracts.
I've got a hundred of thousands faces and some poems for
you,
'cause you're so beautiful. For which army are you
fighting,
girl with a basket full of here and now?

It's too many functions, dumb evolution. We all gonna die
trying to eat our reflections in the mirror'.⁵²³ [Trans. Dawid
Kujawa]

While an analysis of such a work will have to be brief here, its most important elements can still be touched upon. The first two verses have a distinct structure, divided into two segments: a rapid sequence of images repeats with a few modifications. The tension between these phrases,

⁵²³ A. Grzelec, ~(LSD^~(LSD^~(LSD^~(LSD:):):):), <http://magazyn-cegla.net/archiwum/cegla,7,wiersze,114.html> [03.12.2014].

which remain in a strict parallel, is the most important part. 'It's a lie, that you can go crazy because of acid'; 'it's a lie too, that you can heal yourself with an acid': the apparent junction of these two verses seems to form some sort of unclear ambivalence, but soon it becomes clear that it serves to reject both polar opposites. Dualist thinking, philosophical dichotomies have been rejected here, and thus the whole paradigm of western thought, based on them, has been transgressed and unmasked as one of possible ways of perception, but by no means the only one. LSD cannot be the miraculous medicine, the Holy Grail that heals thousands, because it is a substance that lets one understand that all the Holy Grails and Philosopher's Stones are just rhetorical figures that only legitimise a certain discourse and make it the dominant one.

Stanislav Grof remarks that one of the biggest problems with psychedelic research is the evaluation of the research's results, performed accordingly to the currently valid paradigm. But what if the psychedelics really do let one see beyond the current paradigm, see its flaws and render it invalid? The effects of such an analysis are usually discredited, for example labelled as New Age gibberish.

'A paradigm is more than simply a useful theoretical model for science; its philosophy actually shapes the world by its indirect influence on individuals and society. Newtonian-Cartesian science has created a very negative image of human beings, depicting them as biological machines driven by instinctual impulses of a bestial nature. [...] Informal and confidential contact with anthropologists has convinced me that many of them have decided not to report certain aspects of their field experiences for fear they would be ridiculed or ostracized by their Newtonian-Cartesian colleagues and would endanger their professional image'.⁵²⁴

An even more interesting tension results from the friction of the next two verses. 'The state is not a party to any of my contracts'; 'I am every party to all of my contracts' – the anti-systemic resistance, expressed explicitly,

⁵²⁴ S. Grof, *Behind the Brain: Birth, Death and Transcendence in Psychotherapy*, New York 1985, pp. 45, 47.

leaves a clear message: one does not collaborate with the state. But there is also a very interesting idea of subject dispersion – the singular ego is rejected, the filter which limits reality perception and at the same time hides the limitation itself. The rejection of ego is an anti-systemic act in itself, since it destroys the vertical hierarchy of the world, similarly to the Gilles Deleuze's and Felix Guattari's schizoanalysis. Grof says, 'An LSD subject can experience himself or herself as a single cell, as a foetus, and as a galaxy; [...]'.⁵²⁵ By being 'every party to any of [one's] contracts', one remains faithful to oneself, while at the same time transgressing the Cartesian model of singular agency, and becoming a collective – one is empathetic to the collective and conscious of the complex form of one's existence.

This particular poem contains more references to the interesting problem of alternative states of consciousness – a sacrament, a ritual, a mystical experience correlated to an erotic one – these elements, however, will have to be expanded upon on a different occasion.

Another Polish poet associated with 'disordering of the senses' – indeed most often associated with it – is Tomasz Pułka, who not only referred to his experiences with psychedelics in his poetry, but also expanded on the matter in his feuilletons. The poem Miły Kawalek (*Nice piece*) from his poem collection *Schools* touches upon one of the author's biggest obsessions:

'1.

No foreplay: I went out to the kitchen,
to eat four sandwiches, drink a coffee
and smoke a cigarette. During the 'meal'
I've been reading a Scandinavian crime story about
a Swedish policeman. If I would have to
admit right now, what induced me
to all the rest – I would indicate myself.

⁵²⁵ Ibidem, p. 33.

2.

If I would like to indicate myself,
I would have to use a part of 'myself'.
I don't know if the grammar predicted this.

3.

Haha, I guess it did'.⁵²⁶ [Trans. Dawid Kujawa]

The title fits the piece quite well: a short poem engendered by reflection on 'conscious consciousness' – something that escapes the Newton-Cartesian paradigm and illustrates the intuitive or even speculative action of psychiatry and psychoanalysis. In short, a reflection on the human mind is nothing more than hammering a nail with a nail. The light and even innocent description of everyday life (notice the poem's ending, very adroit), a frequent motif in Pułka's poetry, is not shaken by the epiphany of the second verse. This enlightenment is a part of the routine reality, the laid-back language does not change one bit, the subject does not climb a high horse and there is not an ounce of exaltation in its voice. Pułka retains his childish manner so that his intellectual conclusion could have an even stronger voice. The poem cited above does not explicitly mention alternative states of consciousness – or uncanny states, as Grof prefers to call them – but the 'enlightening' phrase about using the mind as a tool of research on the subject of mind is suggestive of that topic. Besides, the protagonist of Pułka's poems should not be observed outside the context of author's other poems, explicitly 'narcotic', since they also create him.

Freeing the conscious from the confines of systemic thinking, broadening one's scope of reception with help of psychedelics, which enhance the receptors' sensitivity, all this lets one see the world from outside, while simultaneously strengthening one's link to that which escapes the laws of logic; such a state of consciousness lets one see reality as it really is, but not distance oneself from it – on the contrary, one is immersed in it, one can reach its deepest ends and gradually uncover the laws that run it. 'Turn on, tune in, drop out', said Leary.

⁵²⁶ T. Pułka, *Miły kawalek*, [in:] Idem, *Zespół szkół*, Kraków 2010, p. 19.

The last poet to be mentioned here will be Kamil Brewiński, winner of the 2011 Połów prize, author of the well-known poem collection *Clubbing* (issued by the editorial hub *Rozdzielczość Chleba* and nominated to Silesius award). The poem *Plankt* is part of that collection.

discos for mimes in Venetian basements
portable players studio headphones

contact is allowed smoking is impossible
selection of a song is your own singing is inadvisable

discos for mimes in Venetian basements
free alcohol in an inexhaustible vessel

ethereal deepness of colors in an untwisted ball
inflated anchors (condoms – decorations)

discos for mimes in Venetian basements
powder installations inhaled by pipes

in articulated bathrooms rotating mirrors
are merging seals of Narnia with guys of Navarone'.⁵²⁷
[Trans. Dawid Kujawa]

Brewiński's debut collection is an attempt at reclaiming the techno subculture for poetry. Naturally, the poem is rife with meanings and contexts, among others the combination of the classical thirteen syllable verse with modern, even 'thuggish' language, and the tradition of 13th century troubadours (obviously filtered through the works of Ezra Pound) by the atmosphere of a stuffy, seedy club. The most interesting part, in my opinion, is the analogy of the clubber's trance and the shamanic trance known to ethnologists. Brewiński's language is strongly rhythmic and very dynamic, while at the same time he seems slightly out of breath, bringing to mind the physical exhaustion that comes with MDMA effect wearing off. Author did in fact mention his references to psychedelics being 'hidden' in the poems, in an interview I had with him for the artPapier magazine:

⁵²⁷ K. Brewiński, *Plankt*, [in:] Idem, *Clubbing*, Kraków–Internet 2013, p. 9.

‘You can find all sort of stuff in here, of course most often I don’t spell it out, because dope is not what’s most important here, they’re more like means of presenting some sort of collective consciousness. I hate rubbing people’s faces in it’.⁵²⁸

It’s no accident that Brewiński’s successful debut had been reviewed by, among others, Adam Grzelec. In his article, he writes, ‘Clubbing is [...] nothing more than a tribal ritual. Jorub writhing in trance is not much different than Mike, on speed, in the club down the block. DJ is the shaman. History brings about the only variations, and for its own reasons’.⁵²⁹

Brewiński’s trance is important for two reasons: firstly, it is a way to break the aforementioned valid paradigm, no matter if we’re talking here of cultural norms, social structures, or scientific methods privileged by the time.

Secondly, the author of *Clubbing*, by describing the primal ritual, follows the concept of Jacques Rancière and makes visible that which was invisible.⁵³⁰ The rave ecstasy had not been included in the ‘high culture’ so far, although it could very well work with various philosophical ideas of today, with Nietzsche being first in the line with his ‘I should only believe in a God that would know how to dance’⁵³¹. After all, dance and ecstasy have been one of primary means of expression of anti-establishment sentiment, regardless of the nature of the establishment.

⁵²⁸ *Normalny jakiś tam proces twórczy. Z Kamilem Brewińskim rozmawia Dawid Kujawa*, ‘art-Papier’, 2014, 15–16, <http://artpapier.com/index.php?page=artykul&wydanie=206&artykul=4476&kat=17> [03.12.2014].

⁵²⁹ A. Grzelec, *Dekonstrukcja dyskoteki*, ‘artPapier’, 2014, 15–16, <http://artpapier.com/index.php?page=artykul&wydanie=206&artykul=4478&kat=17> [03.12.2014].

⁵³⁰ V.: J. Rancière, *Aesthetics and Its Discontents*, trans. S. Corcoran, Cambridge 2009.

⁵³¹ F. Nietzsche, *Thus Spake Zarathustra: A Book for All and None*, trans. T. Common, Hazelton 1999, p. 47.

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